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Bihar, Jharkhand sign Sone river water pact

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Bihar and Jharkhand on Monday signed a long-awaited water-sharing agreement for the Sone River with Union Home Minister Amit Shah present. Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Chaudhary and Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren signed the historic agreement. This ends a 25-year dispute and opens the way for irrigation, storage, and power projects that officials say will directly help farmers in both states. The Sone River, a major southern branch of the Ganga, supports farming across the eastern plains.

Shah announced that the agreement between Bihar and Jharkhand has settled a long-standing water dispute in eastern India. He explained that the agreement will bring irrigation water to hundreds of thousands of farmers in rural Bihar and Jharkhand, and also supply drinking water to local communities. The Home Minister said that today's agreement on



sharing the Sone River's waters shows the success of the 'Team Bharat' vision and cooperative federalism promoted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. He noted that although each state has its own identity, working together as 'Team Bharat' helps solve any problem. Shah also mentioned that this is the fourth water agreement between states this year, which will improve water access for irrigation, rural development, and drinking needs.

The agreement splits the 7.75 million acre-feet (MAF) of water originally given to undivided Bihar under the 1973 Bansagar Agreement among

Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, and Bihar. Now, Bihar will get 5.75 MAF, and Jharkhand will get 2.0 MAF, following a formula suggested by a Central Water Commission technical committee with members from both states.

The dispute started after Jharkhand was created from Bihar in November 2000. Jharkhand claimed that much of the Sone catchment was in its area and wanted a clear share from the Bansagar system. Bihar continued to use the 1973 agreement and kept drawing water from the Sone canal network. This deadlock delayed central approvals and put the

planned Indrapuri reservoir on hold.

The breakthrough occurred at the Eastern Zonal Council meeting in Ranchi on July 10, 2025, which Shah chaired. Later, both state cabinets approved the draft agreement. Officials said that the formal signing removes the last legal barrier to joint planning for the river. For Bihar, the main benefits are a reliable water supply through the Sone canal system and approval to turn the Indrapuri barrage in Rohtas into a full reservoir. The reservoir will be built between Kadwan in Jharkhand's Garhwa district and Matiwani in Bihar's Rohtas district, with a planned storage of about 4,170 million cubic metres.

Officials say this will help stabilise irrigation in eight districts: Bhojpur, Buxar, Rohtas, Kaimur, Aurangabad, Patna, Gaya, and Arwal, which have long depended on monsoon rains and delayed water releases from upstream dams. The project also includes a 300 MW hydropower unit, which will

provide extra electricity for the region.

Bihar officials said the state was already using much of its previous water share and that having a clear formula would enable a new, detailed project report and faster construction. Farmers in southern and central Bihar will get more reliable water for rabi and kharif crops, which should reduce crop losses during dry years.

For Jharkhand, this agreement is the first time its share of Sone water has been formally set. The 2 MAF allocation ends years of uncertainty. It lets the state plan its own irrigation, drinking water, and industrial projects from the river, which covers Garhwa and nearby Palamu-belt districts. Since the Indrapuri reservoir will cross the state border, Jharkhand will also have a stake in a major storage project, instead of just being an upstream catchment state. Officials in Ranchi said this settlement closes a claim that started soon after the state was formed.

Delhi Court allows NIA to question two foreigners inside Tihar jail



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A special court in Delhi on Monday allowed the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to question American citizen Matthew Aaron Van Dyke and Ukrainian citizen Kaminskyi Viktor inside Tihar jail on September 2 and 3. Judge Prashant Sharma approved the request after both men, who are already in judicial custody, were brought to court as part of a terror-conspiracy investigation.

The NIA claims the case involves foreign trainers working with ethnic armed groups along the India-Myanmar border. The two men are part of a group of seven foreign nationals arrested on March 13. Van Dyke was stopped at Kolkata's Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International Airport. The six Ukrainians, Hurba Petro, Sliyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskyi, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyi Viktor, were caught at airports in Delhi and Lucknow.

Investigators say the group entered India on tourist visas, flew to Guwahati, travelled into Mizoram without the required permits, and crossed the border near Sangau in Lawngtlai district.

The NIA has charged them under Section 18 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, which deals with terrorist conspiracy, as well as under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The agency claims they held planned training sessions for Myanmar-based ethnic armed groups in drone

warfare, assembly, operations, and electronic jamming. It also alleges they moved large shipments of drones and related equipment from Europe through India. These groups, the FIR states, have historically supplied weapons and training to banned insurgent organisations active in India's Northeast region.

The accused were moved to judicial custody in early April and have stayed in Tihar Jail since then. Van Dyke's judicial custody is set to last until September 8. The agency has also requested voice samples from several of the accused and is still searching for local people who may have helped the group travel through Assam and Mizoram.

Van Dyke, born in Baltimore on June 11, 1979, is a political scientist. He graduated in political science from the University of Maryland and earned a master's degree in security studies from Georgetown University. He became known internationally in 2011 after joining anti-Gaddafi rebels in Libya, where he was captured and spent almost six months in prison before being released when Tripoli fell. Later, he filmed and advised rebel groups in Syria, started the non-profit Sons of Liberty International, and since 2022 has worked with Ukrainian forces. His documentary 'Point and Shoot' won Best Documentary at the 2014 Tribeca Film Festival.

The NIA claims him the organiser of the Ukrainian group in the Orom corridor in 2025 and a possible intel-

ligence tip-off from Russian services; those claims remain part of an unfinished probe. Detention has produced a parallel legal track. Van Dyke's lawyers, Rohit Dandriyal and Rohit Gour, have sought private medical care and virtual family contact.

In July, the court approved a vegetarian diet, a cook, an electric kettle, and mosquito protection for Van Dyke after he said he had been on a hunger strike since May 6. He reported losing about 14 kilograms because he could not tolerate the jail's spicy, oily food. At the same time, Van Dyke's family has publicly asked the US Embassy to step in, saying he is being held in solitary confinement and that there are delays in getting approved supplies.

"The family of Matthew VanDyke seeks urgent US diplomatic intervention as Matthew VanDyke is presently still denied basic detainee rights and is being kept in solitary confinement at Tihar Jail 8/9 in Delhi, India. It is time to bring Matthew VanDyke back home," the family posted from his verified X handle, with the last edit on Monday.

The Ukrainian Embassy has requested consular access for its citizens. The court has considered the case sensitive from the beginning, sometimes holding hearings at NIA headquarters or behind closed doors. The investigation continues amid concerns that Mizoram's open border is being used by foreign trainers entering Myanmar's civil war, which New Delhi sees as a possible risk for Northeast India.

National body for SCs seeks arrest within five days in derogatory remarks case against Buta Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) on Monday recommended that authorities take immediate steps to arrest the accused persons in a case concerning alleged derogatory remarks against former Union Home Minister late Buta Singh during an election campaign in Punjab's Tarn Taran district last year.

The Commission, under the chairmanship of Kishor Makwana, also sought the status of such action within five days and recommended that the investigation be completed "expeditiously" and the chargesheet filed before the competent court without further "undue delay".

According to the Commission, the hearing was held in connection with alleged derogatory remarks made by Punjab Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring against Buta Singh during an election campaign at Tarn Taran.

Warring was booked in November last year under the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and Section 196 (promoting enmity based on religion, race) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The case was registered following a complaint by Buta Singh's son, Sarabjot Singh Sidhu, at the Cyber Crime Police Station in Kapurthala district.

Punjab Police officials, including



DSP Harpreet Singh and DSP Gulzar Singh, EO and Cyber Crime, appeared on behalf of the respondent authorities, while petitioner Sarabjot Singh was also present.

After hearing the parties and considering the material on record, the Commission expressed "serious concern" over the delay in investigation, arrest of the accused persons and submission of the action taken report (ATR) despite specific recommendations made during its previous hearing, the Commission said.

During the hearing held on May 5, the Commission had recommended that the investigation be completed within the stipulated period in accor-

dance with the rules.

It had also taken note of Sarabjot Singh's complaint that he was receiving threatening calls from the alleged accused and directed that he and his dependents be provided necessary protection under Section 15A of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989.

The Commission had also sought an ATR within 30 days. However, during Monday's hearing, it noted that the requisite ATR on its earlier directions had not been received.

"Taking serious note of the continuing delay, the Commission today recommended that the concerned authorities take immediate necessary

steps, in accordance with law, for the arrest of the accused persons involved in the matter and furnish the status of such action to the Commission within five days," the statement said.

It further recommended that the competent authority examine accountability for the delay in investigation and arrest.

"In the event of any wilful neglect of duty" on the part of the concerned investigating officers is found, appropriate departmental action, including consideration under Section 4 of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, may be taken in accordance with law, the Commission said. An ATR on the Commission's recommendations has been sought within 30 days, it said.

The Commission also viewed the issue of the petitioner's safety with "particular seriousness" and, in view of the alleged continuing threats to Sarabjot Singh, recommended immediate and adequate police protection to him and his dependents, both in Delhi and Punjab, in accordance with Section 15A of the Act.

The NCSC reiterated that the protection of victims, complainants, witnesses and their dependents is an "important statutory safeguard" and the concerned authorities must ensure that the petitioner can pursue the matter without "fear, intimidation or threat".

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Naveen Bholia has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Ghaziabad, U.P. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Property No. 127, (162 sq. mtrs.), Block-D, Sector-108, Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. from Mr. Rajesh Jethmalani (mutatee vide Mutation Letter dated 25.08.2026 issued by NOIDA), who has represented that he himself, Mrs. Mani Rajkumar & Mrs. Sharmila Ahuja are the only Class-I legal heirs of Mr. Raj Kumar Jethmalani, who was owner of the said property by virtue of Transfer Deed dated 31.07.2014 (Doc. No. 7584). If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 07 days of publication of this notice. Otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate
Narang & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.

PUBLIC NOTICE

ENTIRE THIRD FLOOR, PLOT NO. 3631, AREA 220 SQ. MTRS., SECTOR-23-23A, URBAN ESTATE, GURUGRAM, HARYANA

That our client, **Tarun Kumar Arora**, is the absolute owner and in possession of the said property having acquired the said property vide **Sale Deed No. 3108 dated 13.06.2024** from **Kiran Balu, Omvati Dahiya and Lilavati Devi**, who were owners of the entire Plot, having acquired the said property from **Ranjana Nijhawan**. The said **Ranjana Nijhawan** acquired the said property after the death of **Anand Kumar Nijhawan**, who died intestate and left behind **Deeksha Nijhawan, Akash Nijhawan and Ranjana Nijhawan** as his legal heirs. The said **Deeksha Nijhawan and Akash Nijhawan** gave their **No Objection Certificates/consents to HUDA** for transfer of the said property in favour of **Ranjana Nijhawan**, and accordingly **Ranjana Nijhawan** became entitled to deal with and transfer the said property, which was thereafter sold by her to **Kiran Balu, Omvati Dahiya and Lilavati Devi** vide **Sale Deed** dated 28.10.2021.

Under the circumstances, notice is hereby given to the General Public, Bank/Financial institutions or other persons's, organization/s, company/s, government authority/s, having any claim, rights, title, or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the said property, is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing with documentary evidence by registered AD Post to the undersigned at the address mentioned hereinbelow within **14 days of the publication of this notice** and in the event of response having been received to the notice, the title of **Tarun Kumar Arora** to the said property shall be deemed to be clear of all claim, charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our client in any manner whatsoever.

Kumar Abhishek, Advocate
Legal Access
132A, Anankali Complex, Jhandewalan Ext., New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

BE IT known to all that **M/s Jagdish Construction Company, A-143 Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110063**, registered vide No. 2688/82, dated 13.09.1982, intends to join **Anshul Garg, S/o Sushil Garg, R/o House No. 426, First Floor, Block-12, Sunder Vihar, Delhi-110087**, as partner in the firm. The existing partner, **Jagdish Chander Gupta, S/o Shri Laxmi Narain Gupta, R/o A-143, Paschim Vihar, N.D.-110063**, has requested to retire from partnership. Now the firm will have the following partners: (1) **Mrs. Manali Garg & (2) Anshul Garg**. Objections, if any, may be legally filed within a week from today with the concerned registering authority (**M/S Jagdish Construction Company**).

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I, DELHI

4th Floor, Jeevan Tara Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi-110001
TA No. 3241/2022

STATE BANK OF INDIA
Vs
VINOD KUMAR AND ANR

APPLICANT
DEFENDANT

To, (1) **MR. VINOD KUMAR S/O MR. OM PRAKASH** (2) **MRS. SEEMA W/O MR. VINOD KUMAR**
BOTH RESIDING AT- UNIT NO. G-5, PLOT NO. 6/127, VAISHALI, GHAZIABAD, U.P.-201010 ALSO AT- H. NO. 254, SHAHCHANDAN CHANDPUR, BUNJUR, U.P.-246725 ALSO AT- PLOT NO. C-467, 1ST FLOOR, BLOCK-C, SWARN JAYANTI PURAM, GHAZIABAD, UP-201013

Whereas the above-named applicant has instituted a case for recovery of **Rs.24,02,197/- (Rupees Twenty Four Lakhs Two Thousand One Hundred Ninety Seven Only)** against you and whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in ordinary way. Therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance before **LD. Registrar** on **27.10.2026**. (for further details kindly visit **DRT Website. www.tribunal.gov.in** (Phone Number: 011-23748473)). Take notice that in case of your failure to appear on the above-mentioned day before this Tribunal, the case will be heard and decided in your absence.

(i) All concerned may attend their cases by hybrid mode (by physical appearance in the Court or through **CISCO WEBEX VC Link**) (ii) For online appearance through **VC** all the **Advocates/Litigants** shall download the **Cisco Webex application/software**; (iii) Meeting ID and Password for the next date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/Registrar/Recovery Officer/Land Recovery Officer-III shall be available one day prior to the next date at **DRT Official Portal i.e. drt.gov.in** under the **Public Notice Head**. (iv) In any exigency qua that, the **Advocates/Litigants** can contact the concerned official at **Ph. No. 23748473**. Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal on this **11th AUGUST, 2026**.

By order of this Tribunal

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of **VEER PAL SINGH** who is purchasing Built-up/Upper Ground floor Back side, Without roof rights, area 50 sq. yds., Property Bearing No. 19, out of Kharsa No. 309, situated in the revenue estate of Village Bindapur, Delhi State Delhi, Colony known as Bhagwati Vihar, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059, from Mr. Prem Prakash (undivided share 80 %) & Mukesh Aggarwal (undivided share 20 %) who had owned the subject property through Notarized GPA, ATS, Will dated 26.12.2025 executed by Mr. Jasbir Solanki now **VEER PAL SINGH** is intend to purchase the subject property and same to be mortgaged with **ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED SO**, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that, if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances.

For Mr. Jasbir Solanki, Advocate
N-161, Ground Floor, Sakra Tower, Gautam Nagar
Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049
Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be It known to all that I, **Rakesh Dahiya, S/o Sh. Omprakash Dahiya, R/o 194, Babu Lal Chowk, Munirka, South West Delhi-110067**, have disowned and debarred my son **Vaibhav Dahiya** from my movable and immovable properties/assets, to the extent permissible under law and have severed all social and personal relations with my son **Vaibhav Dahiya** due to his misconduct. Any person dealing with him in relation to me or my property shall do so entirely at his/her own risk, and I shall not be responsible in any manner whatsoever.

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is informed that my client **Suleman Akhtar S/o Gayasuddin R/o, K-125, 2nd Floor, Quba Apartment, Thokar No-5, Abul Fazal Enclave-2, Jamia Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025**, and his family has severed all relationship with his son **Mohd Zaid Suleman S/o Suleman Akhtar**, and has **DEBARRED & DISOWNED** him from all his moveable and immovable properties absolutely & forever. Anybody dealing with the above mentioned debarred person shall do so at his/her own cost & risk.

Mohd Usaid Khan (Advocate)
Chamber No: 305, Saket Court, Lawyers Chambers, Saket, New Delhi-110017
Mobile No- 7838366416

PUBLIC NOTICE

Re: Entire Third floor with Roof Rights (Said Floor) Built on southern portion Property Bearing No. 167, Bearing Plot No. 126, area measuring 118.8/9 Sq. Yds., out of Kharsa No. 153, Khewat No. 4, situated in the abadi of Gali No. 17, "WEST AZAD NAGAR" in the area of Village Ghondli, Ilahia Shahdara, Delhi-110051, hereinafter referred to as "said property".

NOTICE is hereby given to general public that our client, **Avnish Kumar** (hereinafter called the "owner") is the absolute owner of the said floor of the said property vide a Sale Deed dated 28.11.2024 registered as document no. 2024/18/11052 executed by Mr. Chand Sehgal & Mr. Bharat Sehgal. It has been also informed that initially Mrs. Harshajain Kaur and Mr. Joginder Singh were the owner of the said property vide Sale Deed dated 18.07.1970 and thereafter Mr. Joginder Singh had transferred his share in the name of Mr. Surjit Singh vide GPA along with ATS & Will dated 04.02.1971. Thereafter, said property transferred in the name of Mr. Raj Pal Sehgal vide Sale Deed dated 09.03.1971. After the death of Mr. Raj Pal Sehgal, his legal heir, Mr. Bharat Sehgal, Mr. Vishal Sehgal through his SPA Mr. Chand Sehgal & Mr. Chand Sehgal had relinquished their share Mrs. Raj Sehgal vide Relinquishment deed dated 03.02.2010. And after the death of Mrs. Raj Sehgal her legal heirs Mr. Vishal Sehgal had relinquished his undivided share in the name of Mr. Chand Sehgal & Mr. Bharat Sehgal vide Relinquishment Deed dated 25.11.2024. And finally, seller has sold the said floor in favour of owner as mentioned above. The said owner has also informed that the said floor is not mortgage anywhere and there is no dispute or any litigation pending in writing with respect to documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the owners in respect of the said floor shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our clients/owners, in any manner whatsoever.

Shivkant Arora, Advocate
For M/s Intelective Law Offices
A-74, LGF, Defence Colony,
New Delhi-110024

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Aamir Ahmad Afzal S/o Ahmad Afzal, R/o A-14/2, 2nd floor, Lane No.6, Shaheen Bagh, Abul Fazal Enclave-II, Jamia Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025, hereby declare that my name has been incorrectly mentioned in my Passport as **Amir Ahmad Afzal** instead of **Aamir Ahmad Afzal**. Both names refer to the same person.

I, JC-302299P Sub(TIGM)

Andra Narayan Mishra, R/o-VIII&PO- Peeng, P.S- Maheshganj, Teh- Kunda, Dist- Pratapgarh, U.P-230141, have changed my father's name from **Sita Ram Mishra** to **Seeta Ram Mishra**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Ram Sanehi Yadav,

Father of No.8038285Y NK Yadendra Pratap Singh, R/o-VIII- Pancham Purwa Balai, PO- Hadha, Dist- Unnao, U.P-209801, have changed my name from **Ram Sanehi Yadav** to **Ram Sanehi**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Anupma Mishra, W/o

JC-302299P Sub(TIGM) Indra Narayan Mishra, R/o- Vill&PO- Peeng, P.S- Maheshganj, Teh- Kunda, Dist- Pratapgarh, U.P-230141, have changed my name from **Anupma Mishra** to **Anupama Mishra**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Venda N, Mother of

No.15332981N Hav Gunanithi S, R/o- Vill & Post- Ammundi, Teh- Katpadi, Dist- Vellore, Tamilnadu- 632519 have changed my name from **Venda N** to **Venda Subramani**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Aher Babu Gangadhar,

Father of- No.4593252X NK Aher Mahavir Bapu, R/o- Vill & Post- Mandawd, Teh- Nandgaon, Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra- 423106, have changed my name from **Aher Babu Gangadhar** to **Bapu Gangadhar Aher**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.1541786H HAV DVR

(MT) Ingle Surajkumar Shrirang, R/o- VTC- Takali Viro, Po- Taki Viro, Dist- Buldhana, Maharashtra- 444203, have changed my daughter's name from **Tanvi Ingle** to **Tanvi Surajkumar Ingle**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Ushabai, Mother of-

No.4593252X NK Aher Mahavir Bapu, R/o- Vill & Post- Mandawd, Teh- Nandgaon, Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra- 423106, have changed my name from **Ushabai** to **Usha Bapu Aher**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Maya Ingle, W/o

No.1541786H HAV DVR (MT) Ingle Surajkumar Shrirang, R/o- VTC- Takali Viro, Po- Taki Viro, Dist- Buldhana, Maharashtra- 444203, have changed my name from **Maya Ingle** to **Maya Surajkumar Ingle**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Selvi P, W/o No.15436924Y

Hav/N A Palpandy R, R/o- Vill- Guruvappanayakkanpatti, Po- Periya Poolam Patti, Teh- Peraiyur, Dist- Madurai, Tamilnadu - 625703, have changed my name from **Selvi P** to **Selvi S**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Chander Kala Devi, W/o

JC-344519P Sub Sanjay Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill- Marichavan, PO- Darauli, Teh- Bhabua, Dist- Kaimur, Bihar- 821101 have changed my name from **Chander Kala Devi** to **Chanderkala Devi**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15436211N Hav

Satyavir, R/o- Vill- Bhandwa, PO & Teh- Badhra, Dist- Charkhi Dabri, Haryana- 127308, have changed my Mother's name in my service record from **Bimla Devi** to **Bimla**, vide affidavit dated 31/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.14852974L Sep Karthi

Keyan N, R/o-7/8 Munceepariyannan Street, PO/Teh/Dist- Krishnagiri, Tamilnadu- 635001, have changed my name from **Karthi Keyan N** to **Karthikkeyan N**, vide affidavit dated 29/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Tanya Mahajan had acquired Land Measuring 1 Bigha, 14 Biswas, out of Mustali No.86, Killa No. 5Mn (1-12), and 26 (0-2), situated in the revenue estate of Village Dera Mandi Tehsil Mehrauli New Delhi vide Sale Deed dt. 21.10.2024 executed by Mr. Kish Gupta. Original Gift Deed dt. 12.10.2021 and Original Regd. GPA dt. 29.10.2024 along with Will w.r.t. said supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client. **Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi-110024**

OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client. **Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi-110024**

PUBLIC NOTICE

Reg: Industrial property having land belonging to Kishore Kumar Singh, 90/1 Pasai, 14/15 to 14/20 bearing Kharsa no. 178 Total Land area measuring 0.3638 hectare or 3638 Square meter, Situated in Village-Rajpur, Pargana & Tehsil-Bhagwanpur, District-Hardwar & "hereinafter referred as the said property".

Be it known to all that our client, **Mr. Harsh Arora** (hereinafter called the "Purchaser") intend to purchase the said property from **V.M.I. Industries** through its Partner **Shri Sandeep Gupta** (hereinafter called "the seller") who owned the said property vide Sale Deed dated 11.08.2008 Doc. No. 4369, Bahi No. 1, Jild No. 534, Pages 17 to 58, registered in the office of Sub-Registrar office Roorkee. Further, seller has informed that initially **Shri Nagina** was the owner of the said property through **Akar Patra-23** and **lot Chakbandi Akarpatra-1 & 45**. Thereafter, **Shri Nagina** sold this said property to **M/s Balaji Steel vide Sale Deed** dated 19.12.2003 and further the said property sold to **M/s Part Engineering Company vide Sale Deed Dt. 14.07.2006** and finally to **V.M.I. Industries** through its Partner **Shri Vinod Kumar Agarwal**. Hence, seller became the owner of the said property. The seller has also informed the purchaser that the said property is not mortgaged anywhere and there is no charge or dispute or any litigation pending regarding the said property.

Any person having Bank/s, Financial Institution/s, relative/s having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the aforesaid property is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the seller to the said property shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our client/Purchaser, in any manner whatsoever.

Shivkant Arora, Advocate
M/s Intelective Law Offices
A-74, LGF, Defence Colony,
New Delhi -110024



CONTINUED ON >> P4

11 killed in firecracker factory blast in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kaushambi

Eleven people were killed and five were injured after a massive explosion at a firecracker factory in Uttar Pradesh's Kaushambi district on Monday afternoon, officials said.

District Magistrate Amit Pal said the blast occurred at a firecracker factory in Manori village under the Pipri police station area, following which 11 injured people, who had been referred to SRN Hospital in Prayagraj, died during treatment. He added that the five seriously injured people are undergoing treatment at the same hospital.

The deceased have been identified as Priyanjali (5), Praveen Singh (13), Jahanvi (12), Aditya (12), Aditya (8), Ravi (8), Anju (32), Gyan Singh (40), Vikram Saroj (35), Ansh (6) and Nana (4), the DM said.

All the deceased persons resided in the vicinity of the factory, the officials said. "More



Family members mourn after explosion at a firecracker factory in Kaushambi (PTI)

than 18 people are suspected to have been injured in the incident," according to the officials. The explosion occurred near the Manori power house and caused extensive damage to the factory and nearby structures. Five to six houses located adjacent to the factory also collapsed in the impact, the officials said.

Given the intensity of the blast, train operations on the Delhi-Howrah railway line passing near

the site were suspended for about an hour. The Ajmer-Sealdah Express, which had reached near the incident site, was sent back to Manori railway station, while the Vande Bharat Express travelling from Delhi to Varanasi was stopped at Saiyad Sarawan railway station, one station before the site.

Pal, Kaushambi Superintendent of Police (SP) Satyanarayan Prajapat and Prayagraj Range Inspector General of Police (IG)

Ajay Mishra reached the spot along with teams of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), police and fire brigade personnel. More than a dozen fire tenders and around two dozen ambulances have been deployed at the site, while more than 50 Air Force personnel are also assisting in the rescue operation.

The fire brigade had earlier brought the blaze under control and rescue operations were launched to evacuate people from the factory. Rescue teams are continuing to clear the debris and excavators are being used to remove the rubble in search of any people who may be trapped.

The blast also damaged a high-voltage electricity pole and power lines in the area. Electricity department personnel are working to repair the damaged infrastructure and restore power supply at the earliest. The Manori Air Force Station is located around two kilometres from the site. Debris from

the collapsed house is being cleared with the help of 10 bulldozers. Police suspect that more people might be trapped underneath, and therefore, the death toll could rise further.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has expressed condolences over the loss of lives in the incident, and has also announced an ex gratia for the kin of the deceased and the injured persons. In a post on X in Hindi, Adityanath said, "The loss of life in the unfortunate incident in Kaushambi district is deeply saddening and heart-wrenching. My condolences are with the bereaved families." "Instructions have been issued to local officials to ensure proper medical treatment for the injured and to reach out to the affected families to provide all possible assistance. Furthermore, directives have been issued to provide financial aid of ₹2 lakh each to the next of kin of the deceased and ₹50,000 each to the injured," Adityanath said.

NIA arrests 3 in Nalagarh police station IED blast

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh



Representative Photo

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has arrested three people in connection with the improvised explosive device (IED) explosion at Nalagarh Police Station in Himachal Pradesh. These are the first arrests in the case.

The accused are Mahavir Kumar, also known as Kaka, Ajay Mehra, and Manpreet Singh, also known as Mani. The agency said their suspected involvement was discovered during the investigation. According to the NIA, these arrests are part of efforts to uncover a larger conspiracy behind what it describes as a terror act. The blast took place on January 1 at about 9:40 a.m. near the outer wall next to the investigating officer's room at Nalagarh police station in Solan district. The case was first registered as FIR No. 02/2026 at that station.

The NIA later took over the investigation and, on May 8, re-registered the case as RC-27/2026/NIA/DLI under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Explosive Substances Act, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The three accused were brought before the Special NIA Court in Shimla. The court sent Kumar and Mehra to eight days of police custody and placed Singh in judicial custody. The agency said it is still working to find and arrest others involved in the conspiracy and to uncover the larger network behind the attack. Nalagarh is an industrial town in the Shivalik foothills and is a gateway into Himachal Pradesh from the plains. The police station is in a busy part of

town. The explosion on New Year's morning turned a local crime case into a federal terror investigation after the NIA took charge in May. The official record remains brief and factual.

In its statement, the NIA has not explained the specific roles of each accused, only that their involvement was discovered during the investigation. The agency has not named any co-conspirators who are still at large, nor has it released a chargesheet. So far, it has only said that these are the first three people arrested in this case and that the investigation is ongoing.

The state police filed the original FIR on the day of the blast. The state police filed the original FIR on the day of the blast. When the NIA re-registered the case months later, it brought the matter under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act and moved custody and trial to the special court in Shimla.

The arrests in August marked the point when the national agency officially took the three men into its own case, brought them before its court, and secured police custody for two of them. The court will next review the progress of questioning during the eight-day remand for Kumar and Mehra. Singh remains in judicial custody, with bail requests pending and further hearings scheduled.

51 Indians recruited into Russian army killed: MEA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 51 Indian Nationals recruited into the Russian Army have been killed so far, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said, highlighting the grave risks faced by Indians who became involved in the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

According to figures shared by Misri, 227 Indian nationals were recruited into the Russian military, of whom 51 have died and 139 have been discharged. The



Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri

figures provide a clearer picture of the scale of Indian involvement in the conflict and the casualties suffered by Indian citizens serving with Russian forces.

The Indian Government has been actively engaging with Russian authorities over the issue and has been seeking the release, discharge and repatriation of Indian Nationals serving in the Russian armed forces.

New Delhi has repeatedly raised the matter with Moscow, urging Russian authorities to ensure that Indian citizens are released

from military service and allowed to return to India.

The latest disclosure comes amid continued diplomatic efforts by India to secure the return of Indians caught up in the Russia-Ukraine war.

The issue has emerged as a significant concern for the Indian Government, particularly as reports of Indians being recruited into the Russian military have surfaced over the course of the conflict.

Misri made the remarks during his visit to Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, where discus-

sions included matters concerning Indian nationals involved in the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

The figures underscore the human cost of the involvement of Indian nationals in the war, with dozens having lost their lives while others continue to seek discharge and repatriation.

India has maintained that its citizens should not be involved in the conflict and has continued diplomatic efforts with Russia to facilitate their safe return.

FROM PAGE - 3

PM Modi urges Putin to end Ukraine War

"Every day spent in war sets humanity back, whereas every step taken towards peace fills humanity with new hope and enthusiasm," Modi said during the meeting. He emphasised that moving away from endless wars and towards their conclusion was necessary for the well-being of humanity.

Referring specifically to the Ukraine conflict, Modi said India had maintained regular discussions with Putin on the issue. He reiterated New Delhi's support for all efforts directed at establishing peace and called for an early resolution to outstanding disputes.

"A peaceful resolution to all issues at the earliest is the call of humanity, and this is India's message," Modi said, adding that the traditions associated with Mahatma Gandhi and Gautama Buddha convey a common message of peace.

The Prime Minister also invited Putin to attend the upcoming BRICS Summit in New Delhi in September. Modi said India was looking forward to welcoming the Russian president and expressed the view that his visit would further strengthen relations between the two countries.

Putin thanked Modi for his personal attention to India-Russia relations and underlined the importance of continued engagement between the two countries.

In a post on X following the meeting, Modi said the two leaders had discussed the full range of the India-Russia Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership. He said significant progress had been made in several sectors in recent years, identifying energy, innovation, space, fertilisers and people-to-people ties as key areas for further cooperation.

Following their bilateral talks, Modi and Putin travelled together in the same car to Bishkek Arena for the opening ceremony of the VI World Nomad Games.

The meeting came several months after Putin's state visit to New Delhi for the India-Russia Annual Summit on December 4-5, 2025. During that summit, the two countries adopted a joint statement and announced 21 outcomes, including 16 memoranda of understanding and agreements.

Those agreements covered areas including mobility, fertilisers, healthcare, food safety, maritime cooperation, customs, trade, academia and media.

India and Russia have conducted 23 annual summits so far, with the meetings alternating between the two countries. Their bilateral ties were elevated to a "Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership" in 2010.

The latest meeting in Bishkek comes as New Delhi continues to engage closely with Moscow while maintaining its stated position that dialogue and diplomacy are the preferred routes to resolving international conflicts.

India rejects Indus water ruling

The decision came amid heightened tensions between the two nuclear-armed neighbours. Pakistan has repeatedly opposed India's move, with its leaders describing water access as a critical national interest and warning of serious consequences if the treaty remains suspended.

India, meanwhile, has maintained that the decision remains in effect.

The latest ruling has therefore added another layer to an already contentious dispute involving both the future of the water-sharing agreement and the legal mechanism through which disagreements under the treaty should be

resolved. Monday's response follows India's earlier rejection of decisions issued by the same arbitration body.

On May 16, India dismissed an earlier award concerning the issue of "maximum pondage", which was linked to proceedings examining the interpretation of provisions under the Indus Waters Treaty.

At the time, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India did not accept that arbitration process and rejected the latest award as well as earlier decisions issued by the tribunal.

New Delhi's position has remained consistent: it does not recognise the Court of Arbitration as a validly constituted body under the treaty and does not consider its rulings binding on India.

The dispute now leaves the two countries sharply divided not only over the interpretation and implementation of the Indus Waters Treaty, but also over which mechanism, if any, has the legal authority to adjudicate disagreements under the agreement.

GDP surges 7.8%, beats RBI forecast

"The collective strength of our people ensured India delivered such growth despite oil price shocks and supply chain issues in the midst of global uncertainties. "Doomsayers were doomed and India bloomed...yet again!" the PM posted on X.

"The credit for this strong performance goes to the people of India and their hard work. Reforms undertaken by the NDA Government, together with an agile management of the economy, are bearing results," she posted on social media. Sitharaman also said the Government remains committed to further expanding economic opportunities for all citizens.

Key primary sectors witnessed moderation during the first quarter. Agricultural growth slowed to 3.6 per cent YoY in the first quarter from 4.4 per cent a year earlier, while the mining sector registered a sharp drag, shrinking 2.4 per cent compared to a stellar 12.4 per cent growth in the corresponding period last fiscal. On the industrial front, manufacturing kept up its solid run, growing 9.2 per cent in Q1 compared to 8.3 per cent a year ago. The electricity sector saw a dramatic turnaround, jumping to 8.9 per cent growth after shrinking 1.8 per cent in the same period last year. Construction also picked up healthy steam, expanding 7.7 per cent against 5.2 per cent last fiscal, giving a solid boost to overall economic activity.

The Q1 GDP figures are provisional and could be revised. The data will offer some relief to policymakers as they balance efforts to sustain growth with risks stemming from geopolitical tensions and volatile commodity markets.

Ankit Baliyan murder: Two shooters killed...

On August 26, Baliyan was shot as he left a gym in Shamli's Kotwali area and walked to his car. Four men on two motorcycles opened fire. Police said he was hit by five bullets, including two to the head, and was declared dead at a community health centre. CCTV footage later showed the attackers following him and firing several rounds before escaping toward Haryana. Investigators believe the attackers had watched his movements in advance, with two men involved staying at a local hotel days earlier to track his routine.

The DGP said the investigation showed the crime was planned. The shooters were organized, the victim's movements were tracked, weapons and an escape plan were arranged,

and protection was set up after the attack. "Our objective is not merely to reach the shooters. Those who hatched the conspiracy, provided resources and weapons, got the victim's movements monitored and provided protection to the accused- the entire chain will be brought within the ambit of law," he said.

Shortly after the murder, a social media post claiming to represent the Gogi gang took responsibility. The post said Baliyan had supported their rivals and made a song about the 2021 courtroom killing of gangster Jitender Mann, also known as Gogi, in Delhi's Rohini court. Baliyan's 2023 track, "Bhari Court Mein Goli Maareng Meri Jaan", received millions of views. Police now say the song had angered gang members for some time and linked Baliyan's gotra to the rival Tillu Tajpuria.

Earlier, the singer received threats over a video and publicly explained that he had only acted in it, and that the lyrics and tune were not his. "Despite this, information has emerged during the investigation that the gang was linking him to the Gogi gang," Krishna said.

The DGP warned that being outside Uttar Pradesh would not protect those responsible for the crime. "Those sitting outside Uttar Pradesh's borders and conspiring to commit crimes should not live under the illusion that the distance will keep them beyond the reach of law." Police are investigating possible coordination from jails in Haryana and Delhi, as well as the role of missing suspects linked to the Gogi gang. "Let me assure the media that the Uttar Pradesh Police's action will not end here," Krishna said.

This assurance is especially important to the family, who first demanded it. After the murder, retired soldier Satbir Singh, Baliyan's father, stood in the street as residents blocked the road and his wife sat with their son's body. He filed the complaint and told reporters he wanted only one thing. "I want the man who killed him. I don't want anything else. The protest will continue." He insisted Ankit had no criminal connection that could explain the attack. The courtroom song, he said, was years old. There was no extortion, no gym quarrel the family knew of. "What does that song have to do with today's incident?" He gave the administration four days, warned that a soldier's son's blood would not be allowed to "mix with the soil," and said his army comrades would stand with him if the police failed.

On Monday, after hearing about the encounter in Bantikhera, Satbir's tone changed, but his demand remained the same. He thanked Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and the police. "What we want is that this gang must be uprooted." He called the two deaths "half justice." He said full justice would come only when everyone involved, "two or four," was caught, especially the mastermind "pulling the strings." His wife, Seema, and sister, Reena, praised the Shamli and STF teams and said the remaining suspects must be arrested soon. Ankit's mother, Amaresh Baliyan, asked the chief minister to catch those still at large.

SIR shocker: Nearly one in three Delhi voters...

This is followed by New Delhi at 39.24 per cent, South at 38.68 per cent and Central at 38.04 per cent. At the other end, Outer North has a potential deletion rate of 24.32 per cent, the lowest among the 13 districts.

Voters whose names are missing from the draft roll will be able to file claims and objections between August 31 and September 30. During this period, officials will closely examine the claims for inclusion in the electoral roll, while booth-level officers (BLOs) will conduct field visits to

verify them. Claims and objections will be examined, and the notice and disposal process will be on till October 29. Once the details are found to be in order, the voters' names will be included in the final SIR electoral roll, scheduled to be published on November 4.

The deletions under SIR has sparked a huge political controversy ahead of Assembly elections in States where the SIR exercise was held. According to the poll body's data, in Maharashtra 21.14 per cent of the State's previous voter base were deleted. Similarly, 23 per cent voters' names were excluded from the draft roll in Karnataka. In West Bengal, where Assembly polls were recently held around 12 per cent of the electorate were removed. In neighbouring Bihar, where the SIR exercise was held first, around six per cent names were removed. The number was 10.78 per cent in case of Andhra Pradesh. Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu reported 29.64 per cent of total voters deleted in draft rolls published under SIR.

In case any person is aggrieved by the decision of the ERO, he/she may prefer an appeal to the District Magistrate within 15 days of the ERO's order under Section 24(a) of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, read with rule 27 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. If the appellant remains unsatisfied, a second appeal may be preferred before the Chief Electoral Officer within 30 days of the District Magistrate's order, as per Section 24(b) of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 read with Rule 27 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

The number of electors has decreased from 1500 to 1200 per polling station. Similarly, the number of polling stations has increased from 13,033 to 14,947 showing an increase of 1914 polling stations. Further, Polling station locations have also increased from 2,696 to 2,856 showing increase of 160 polling station locations after rationalization in NCT of Delhi.

Nepal flood toll rises to 903 as search for 4,247...

The scale of the disaster has posed a major challenge for rescue agencies, with teams having to work through difficult terrain and hazardous conditions to reach affected communities. Rescuers are continuing to search riverbanks, debris-filled areas and other locations where people may have been swept away or stranded.

The NDRRMA said 4,247 people remain missing, including 85 security personnel and 320 foreign nationals.

The authorities have stepped up efforts to locate those still unaccounted for, while recovery teams continue to retrieve bodies from areas affected by the floods. Officials have also been coordinating rescue and relief operations to assist people stranded or displaced by the disaster.

With hundreds of people still missing nearly a week after the floods, rescue teams are racing against time to find possible survivors and recover those who may have been swept away by the powerful floodwaters.

The disaster has once again highlighted Nepal's vulnerability to sudden floods and landslides, particularly in mountainous and riverine areas where difficult terrain can make emergency response and evacuation operations especially challenging.

Five years on: Remembering...

He moved fluidly between the two, using each to sharpen the other, and in doing so built a template for the journalist-parliamentarian

that few in Indian public life have matched since. By every account of those who worked alongside him, he was also a generous mentor as an editor who gave young reporters room to find their voice, much as he had found his.

Five years after his passing, the newsroom he shaped, and the standards he insisted on, remain his most enduring editorial.

MHA warns of fake porn apps that can take...

The important step then comes when the malware asks the user to grant Accessibility services, a powerful Android feature intended to assist people with disabilities. After this permission is granted, the application can read everything on the screen, click buttons, enter OTPs and PINs, confirm payment screens, and initiate fund transfers.

Victims can lose all the money in their bank accounts, even though their phones appear to work normally. Sometimes these apps also force a VPN connection, routing all internet traffic through servers controlled by attackers. Like other similar apps, they often block standard uninstallation methods, so they remain on the device even when the user tries to remove them in Settings.

The attack usually happens in this order: a social media ad, redirection to an adult website, installation of a sideloaded APK, installation of more malware, VPN activation, control of the Accessibility feature, silent control of the device, and then unauthorised UPI or banking transactions. NCTAU advises that you should only download apps from the Google Play Store or other official stores, and never accept APK files from ads, random websites, or unknown links.

You should never grant accessibility permissions to an app you don't know. It's important never to grant accessibility permissions to apps you do not recognise. Regularly check your Settings, review all installed apps, and remove any you do not know. Keep Google Play Protect turned on and make sure your phone's operating system is up to date. Check your bank statements and UPI records often. If you think your phone is infected, there are two ways to remove the malware. Hold down the power button until the Safe Mode option shows up, select it and then wait for the phone to restart, at which point 'Safe Mode' will appear at the bottom of the screen. In Settings, go to Apps, select the suspicious application, then tap Uninstall. Also remove any other unknown applications or those related to it. Finally, restart the phone normally; Safe Mode will then automatically exit.

The second method starts by restoring your original home screen launcher, such as System Launcher, One UI Home, or Pixel Launcher. Next, go to Settings, tap Accessibility, find the malicious app under Installed Services or Downloaded Apps, and turn off its Accessibility option. Then, go to Security or Security & Privacy, select Device Admin Apps or Device Administrators, choose the same app, and tap Deactivate.

After you finish these steps, open your Apps list to make sure the program has been removed. If it returns after you restart your device, save your important data, then perform a factory reset. If you lose money or find a fake app, report it immediately to the national helpline at 1930 or visit www.cybercrime.gov.in.

This scam happens because many people in India download apps from unofficial sources, and the Accessibility API can be misused. With UPI so common, it enables quick and often hidden theft. Cyber-fraud groups often use social media to trick people, so it is important to stay alert when installing new apps.

■ States Focus ■



PM MODI'S POEMS RECITED BY UZBEK STUDENTS IN TASHKENT

A musical performance based on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's poem 'Abhi Toh Suraj Uga Hai' at an informal dinner hosted by Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev, and the recitation of his poetry by university students in Tashkent were in the spotlight during his just-concluded visit there.

Uzbek students at the Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies came together to recite the poems in both Hindi and Uzbek languages before the prime minister, officials said.

The poem 'Abhi Toh Suraj Uga Hai' was recited in Hindi by Keldiyorov Dilhushbek, a fourth-year student from the university. Its Uzbek translation was recited by Dilshoda Juraboeva, a third-year student.

(PTI)



MEHBOOBA SLAMS BJP OVER WOMEN'S SAFETY, VIGILANTISM

PDP president Mehbooba Mufti on Monday expressed concern over the rising cases of sexual violence against females in the country, saying cow protection seems to be a higher priority than women's safety.

"In BJP's India, cow protection has become a higher priority than women's safety. On mere suspicion of cow slaughter, people have been lynched to death by mobs. Yet, when it comes to protecting women from rape, sexual violence and brutality, the convicted rapists not only enjoy parole after parole but also full patronage," Mehbooba said in a post on X.

(PNS)

BJP slams Rahul Gandhi over Haldwani FIR row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress-BJP sparring over the alleged "purification ceremony" in Haldwani intensified on Monday, with the BJP accusing the Opposition party of doing petty politics on the issue due to upcoming Assembly polls and calling Rahul Gandhi the "most anti-Dalit leader" in the country.

The BJP's response came after the Congress lashed out at the ruling party over the registration of an FIR against Gandhi, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, over his recent remarks on the "shuddhikaran" ritual at the venue where Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, who is a Dalit, addressed a rally in Uttarakhand last month. Gandhi had alleged that it was a form of practising untouchability.

The FIR was registered against Gandhi on Saturday following a complaint by a

member of the Valmiki community in Haldwani alleging that the Congress leader at a recent press conference gave a casteist spin to a "religious ritual".

The Congress on Monday vowed that it would not rest until the true culprits are punished and this "frivolous FIR is thrown in the dustbin". The main Opposition party also said it will give a fitting response to the registration of the FIR through democratic and legal means.

Hitting back, BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia alleged that the Congress is playing "petty politics" over the issue because the party knows it is set to suffer setbacks in the next round of Assembly elections due in various states in 2027.

He also questioned why it took Gandhi three weeks to raise the issue and alleged that the Gandhi family had insulted Kharge on several occasions.

"It's a different matter



BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia

whether his (Kharge's) allegation is right or wrong, but Rahul Gandhi didn't care. He kept sleeping for three weeks," he said.

"There has never been a leader in India more irresponsible, anti-Dalit and anti-backwards classes than Rahul Gandhi," Bhatia told a press conference at the BJP headquarters in New Delhi, while replying to queries

on the issue.

The FIR has been registered under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) related to promoting enmity between groups and deliberate acts intended to outrage religious feelings. The Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, has also been invoked, police said on Sunday.

Rajnath assures full support to flood-hit Nepal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Describing India as Nepal's close friend and "*Sukh Dukh ke saathi*", Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday said New Delhi stands shoulder to shoulder with "our Nepali brothers and sisters", and it is committed to supporting Kathmandu's efforts for search, rescue and rehabilitation following the large-scale devastation caused by the flash floods in that country.

In a social media post, he said, "Went to the Embassy of Nepal in New Delhi and expressed my condolences by signing the condolence book."

"On behalf of the Government and people of India, I extend my deepest



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh signs a condolence book at the Embassy of Nepal following the loss of lives in Nepal in New Delhi

PTI

condolences to the people of Nepal and their Government, on the loss of precious lives and large-scale devastation caused by the flash flood on 26 August 2026," he wrote.

This tragic natural calamity has affected the citizens of Nepal along with a number of foreign nationals, including Indians, he said.

"Our thoughts and prayers are with the families of those who lost their lives in this disaster. We hope for speedy recovery of those who were injured. As a close friend and partner, and '*Sukh Dukh Ke Saathi*', India has always stood by Nepal. In this trying time also, we stand shoulder to shoulder with our Nepali brothers and sisters and are committed to support Nepal's efforts for search, rescue and rehabilitation," Singh said in his post.

On the day the disaster struck the Himalayan nation, Singh, in a post, had said that he was deeply saddened by the loss of lives and damage caused by the devastating floods in Nepal, and asserted that India would provide all possible support and assistance to its "friendly neighbour".

My responsibility to help upper castes if they need justice: Chirag Paswan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

Union minister Chirag Paswan on Monday said it was his responsibility to help upper castes if they need justice, asserting that safeguarding interests of deprived classes should not result in "exploitation of other castes".

Paswan, who was responding to a query from journalists about his vehement opposition to introducing a sub-quota for the most deprived sections among SCs and STs, also said he sought to "serve as a bridge" that connects various social groups. The Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) chief and Union minister Jitan Ram Manjhi on Saturday sparred over a separate sub-category for the most deprived Dalit sections, with Paswan opposing it as divisive and the former Bihar chief minister arguing that it would benefit the communities.



Paswan also charged upper caste politicians with failure to "effectively voicing the concerns of their own communities".

The Hajipur MP did not directly reply to his tiff with Manjhi, the Hindustani Awam Morcha founder, but said, "About reservations, I hold the clear

view that if one social segment has its own concerns, taking care of the apprehensions of the others is also the responsibility of our Government."

"On one hand, we need to protect the interests of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes, but on the other we also ought to allay fears of the upper castes. Safeguarding interests of one caste should not result in the exploitation of another," Paswan said.

"But, I wonder why those from the upper castes are not able to voice the concerns of their communities with the same intensity that I do for the social segment I represent? The Constitution has created ample space for uplift of all social groups without any friction between upper castes, OBCs, SC/ST and minorities. Chirag Paswan shall serve as a bridge between these social groups," he said.

India needs long term approach towards South Asian neighbours: Former diplomat Raghavan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Emphasising on a clinical and not a sentimental appreciation of the turbulently fluid situation in the Indo-Pak relations, former diplomat TCA Raghavan on Monday underlined the need for a long-term approach on the part of India to manage its South Asian neighbourhood.

Speaking to a distinguished gathering comprising senior officials from armed forces and civil dispensation, faculties, researchers and students from different universities across the state and other distinguished luminaries, Raghavan discussed the Mecca Accord in terms of potential for complementarities that Pakistan, Turkiye and Saudi Arabia could bring to the table.

According to a Press release, the eminent diplomat, scholar and author delivered an insightful lecture on "Mecca Accord, Pakistan and the Future of India-Pakistan Relations" at Bihar Lok Bhawan as part of the first edition of the 'Patliputra Pragya Prawah' series. Bihar



Dr Faizan Mustafa, VC of Chanakya National Law University, Bihar Governor Lt Gen Syed Ata Hasnain (Retd) and diplomat TCA Raghavan at a lecture on 'Mecca Accord, Pakistan and the Future of India-Pakistan Relations' at Bihar Lok Bhawan

PIONEER PHOTO

Governor Lt Gen Syed Ata Hasnain (Retd.) also graced the occasion.

He explained that Pakistan with its nuclear arsenal and defence capabilities, Arabia with its financial resources and Turkiye with its template of modernity and technology prowess could introduce new possibilities and new uncertainties not only in West Asia but also in South Asia.

While the three countries were not abandoning Washington, the Chinese factor loomed in the background and the Mecca Accord, he said, amounted to the creation of a more

autonomous regional security architecture.

Raghavan made certain general points of great salience: first, foreign policy is not a zero sum game and it is perfectly possible for different powers to engage in multi-alignment in order to serve their self-interest; second, the very nature of warfare is changing and the factor of asymmetry between unequal powers is getting reduced.

In the context of new sources of volatility, he underlined that the choice for India was to tread a fine balance between its uncompromising stand against terror provocations from

Pakistan and the long-term need for engagement. Earlier, detailing the idea of 'Patliputra Pragya Prawah' Governor of Bihar Lt Gen Syed Ata Hasnain (Retd.) emphasized that Bihar has civilizational been the centre of intellectual ferment, argumentation and contestation and given this, there is a need to revive and rejuvenate the idea of knowledge-sharing.

He assured that the Lok Bhawan would be at the forefront of encouraging and facilitating a culture of debate and dialogue in pursuit of which more lectures and seminars would be organised.

He also added that more and more such events should be organised at the decentralized level in order to usher in de-concentration of knowledge and new ways of looking at things.

Welcoming the participants, Dipak Kumar Singh, Additional Chief Secretary to the Governor, informed the distinguished gathering that Bihar Lok Bhawan would organize two lectures each month with domain experts interacting with the audience on a host of issues.

SIR - 2026

(Special Intensive Revision, Delhi)

APPEAL

No Eligible Voter to be excluded and No Ineligible Person to be included

Draft Electoral Roll Has Been Published

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Form-7

If someone's name needs to be removed due to relocation, death, or duplicate entry, fill Form-7.

Form-8

If there is any error in your name, age, address, photo, or other details, fill Form-8.

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MoU signed to develop space under Deepali Chowk flyover

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday signed an MoU with two private companies for the development of space under Deepali Chowk flyover in northwest Delhi. The agreements were signed in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

“Delhi Government has signed the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Dixon Technologies Limited and Kanodia Group, advancing its resolve for a clean, green, and beautiful city,” Delhi CMO said in a post on social media.

Under the partnership, beautification and development of the area under the Deepali Chowk flyover will be taken up as part of corporate social initiative(CSR). Additionally, murals on

pillars depicting Indian culture, modern art, and environment-themed artwork, restoration of the green belt along Mathura Road and MP Marg, and installation of drip irrigation and fencing with pollution-resistant plants will be part of the initiative.

These initiatives, carried out through corporate social responsibility (CSR), will help make Delhi’s public spaces cleaner, greener, more organized and more citizen-friendly. On the occasion, Rekha Gupta said building a clean, green and beautiful Delhi is a collective responsibility of the government, society and the private sector. The Delhi government is encouraging public-private partnerships through which neglected spaces in the city can be transformed into better, safer, attractive



and environment-friendly public spaces for citizens.

The goal of Delhi’s development is not only to create new infrastructure facilities but also to improve the quality of life of citizens by making better use of existing urban spaces. The transformation of spaces beneath flyovers and green belts along major roads is part of this



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the signing of an MoU between the Delhi Government, Dixon Technologies Limited and Kanodia Group for the beautification and maintenance of flyovers and public spaces PANKAJ KUMAR

PWD minister Parvesh Verma, who was also present at the MoU signing, said the Government requires public partnerships for better results, and added there are many NGOs and companies that want to help in beautification of Delhi. Under the MoU, the two companies will have two stretches each for beautifica-

tion under the CSR initiative, he said.

The partnership aims to transform neglected or underutilised spaces under and around flyovers into clean, green, safe and useful public spaces for citizens. The initiative will focus simultaneously on cleanliness, greenery, beautification, safety, pedestrian movement and environmental awareness.

As part of an initiative by Dixon Technologies and Vrikshit Foundation, neglected spaces along the 2.5-km stretch from Deepali to Mangolpuri Market beneath the flyover will be developed as clean, green and safe community spaces. The project will include fencing along the approximately 2.5-km stretch beneath the flyover.

Environment-friendly mural paintings and artworks based on environmental themes and clean energy will be created on 61 flyover pillars, covering an area of around 5,100 square metres. Organised greenery will be developed using local plant species, grass, shrubs and flowering plants.

As part of a CSR initiative, the Kanodia Group will undertake the development

and long-term maintenance of around two acres of green belt along Mathura Road and MP Road. At present, issues such as garbage dumping, unauthorised slums, roadside encroachments and unplanned use of these areas are affecting greenery, cleanliness, safety and the overall appearance of the surroundings.

The green belts will be developed through local plant species, organised landscaping and improved maintenance. The proposed development will include organised green spaces, flowering plants, shrubs, trees and plants, walkways, lighting and attractive public spaces.

This will not only enhance the greenery and appearance of the area but also provide citizens with a better and more convenient environment.

Govt to set up medical rooms in 100 schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday said the Delhi Government will set up dedicated medical rooms in 100 Government schools on a pilot basis to provide students immediate first aid, basic health support and counselling. The initiative will subsequently be expanded in phases to 1,086 Government schools based on the outcome and evaluation of the pilot project, according to a statement issued by the Chief Minister’s Office.

An allocation of ₹5 crore has been made in this year’s Budget Estimates for implementing the pilot project. Additional funds required for the expansion will be provided in the coming years based on the pilot’s evaluation and outcomes, it stated.

The medical rooms will provide first aid, temporary rest, basic health support, age-appropriate health guidance and counselling to students when required, it said.



The facilities will also provide girl students with a safe and private space during menstrual discomfort. “Our aim is to provide students immediate first aid, basic health support and counselling when needed,” Gupta said.

Trained health workers will be engaged through an approved outsourcing arrangement to provide primary health support at the medical rooms. They will also assist with counselling, health-awareness activities and maintenance of relevant records, according to the statement.

The Government plans to use existing school infrastructure for the initiative, which has been designed as a low-cost arrangement, it said. The initiative is aimed at creating a safe, inclusive and health-supportive environment in schools and is in line with the vision of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, the statement said.

The programme is also intended to support students’ physical and emotional well-being while minimising disruption to their studies, it added.

LG reviews traffic, seeks action on congestion hotspots

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday reviewed Delhi Traffic Police’s functioning and directed its senior leadership to step up coordination with civic agencies to ease congestion, strengthen road safety and improve traffic discipline across the Capital.

During his visit to the Delhi Traffic Police Headquarters in Todapur, Sandhu stressed the need for proactive management of congestion-prone locations and closer coordination among agencies responsible for roads and traffic management. He also called for greater public participation in efforts to make Delhi’s roads safer and traffic movement more efficient.

The LG said a coordinated, technology-driven and citizen-focused approach was necessary to address traffic-related challenges and improve public confidence in the city’s traffic management system. Senior Delhi Traffic Police officers briefed the LG on measures and programmes being used to tackle congestion, improve road discipline and engage with road users. These included Traffic Pathshala, Traffic Panchayat and



special enforcement campaigns targeting dangerous traffic violations.

Traffic Pathshala is aimed at sensitising traffic violators and promoting awareness about responsible road behaviour. Traffic Panchayat seeks to bring civic agencies and other stakeholders together to identify traffic-related problems and work towards their resolution.

The Traffic Police also outlined its enforcement drives against violations considered dangerous to road users. The initiatives are intended to complement routine enforcement with public awareness and coordinated action.

The visit also covered preparations for the forthcoming BRICS Summit in Delhi. The Traffic Police briefed the LG on the arrangements being planned for the international event, which is expected to bring Heads of State and Government, foreign dignitaries and senior delegates to the Capital.

According to the Traffic Police, technology-driven arrangements are being put in place to ensure the safe and smooth movement of foreign dignitaries as well as Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other ministers during the summit.

Officials assured the LG that traffic arrangements would focus on maintaining security and uninterrupted movement of the visiting dignitaries while keeping inconvenience to the general public to a minimum. The summit preparations are expected to require close coordination among multiple agencies, particularly for managing routes used by visiting delegations and maintaining regular traffic movement in other parts of the city.

During the review, the LG emphasised that inter-agency coordination would be critical not only during major events but also in the routine management of Delhi’s traffic. He called for traffic authorities and other concerned departments to work together rather than addressing congestion and road safety issues in isolation. The meeting was attended by Special Commissioner of Police, Traffic, Ajay Chaudhry, Joint Commissioner of Police, Traffic, Sanjay Tyagi, three Additional Commissioners of Police, Traffic, along with Deputy Commissioners and Assistant Commissioners of Police from the Traffic unit.

Delhi turns monsoon farewell into folk culture celebration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi marked the end of the monsoon with a large cultural festival at Talkatora Stadium on Monday, bringing folk music, dance, painting and regional traditions to the city’s stage. The event, titled ‘Badariya: A Monsoon Farewell Festival’, was organised by the Delhi Government’s Department of Art, Culture & Language in association with the Mata Chakery Devi Foundation and the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy. The programme featured performances

rooted in the folk traditions of Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and the wider Purvanchal region.

Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra, Delhi Art, Culture & Language Minister Kapil Mishra and BJP MP Manoj Tiwari were among those who attended the event. Other MPs, MLAs and cultural personalities were also present. Padma Shri awardee and folk singer Malini Awasthi was the main performer of the evening. She presented Kajri, Thumri and other folk compositions before a large audience. Other performers presented traditional music, instrumental pieces and folk dances.



The festival drew its theme from the long association between the monsoon and Indian cultural expression. The season has traditionally found a place in literature, music and folk traditions, often representing joy, love, longing and creativity.

Organisers used songs associated with Sawan and Bhado, along with folk performances and visual art, to present this cultural connection. The programme was designed not only as a celebration of the changing season but also as an effort to bring regional artistic traditions before audiences in the

national Capital. Malhotra said cultural programmes such as Badariya could help strengthen Delhi’s identity while supporting the Government’s efforts to develop the Capital as a major centre for cultural activities.

Mishra said the Delhi Government had expanded its focus on cultural programmes celebrating Bhojpuri, Maithili and other folk traditions. He said a major programme showcasing these traditions was started in the city last year and that the response had encouraged the Government to continue such initiatives.

Pink tickets extended till September 17

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday extended the paper-based Pink Ticket system for women travelling free on DTC buses till September 17. The extension gives commuters more time to shift to the Pink Saheli Smart Card system.

Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the extension was intended to ensure that women do not face disruption during the transition, particularly during the upcoming festive period. From September 18, the Pink Saheli Smart Card will be mandatory for women seeking the free bus travel facility.

Nearly 19 lakh women have already applied or registered for the Pink Saheli Smart Card, according to the Transport Minister. He said the response to the registration drive had been encouraging and that the Government would continue issuing cards even after September 17. “The extension has been given till September 17,” Singh said, adding that paper tickets would remain available until that date. He said the smart card system would take over fully from the following day.

The extended deadline

comes ahead of several festivals, including Janmashtami, Teej and Ganesh Chaturthi, when travel tends to increase for religious, social and family occasions.

The Government said retaining the existing system during this period would help prevent inconvenience to women commuters. September 17 is also the birth-



day of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and marks the beginning of Seva Pakhwada, which will continue until October 2. The minister linked the extension to the Government’s effort to ensure continuity of the free travel facility during the transition.

Singh said women who have not yet registered for the Pink Saheli Smart Card will not lose the opportunity after the September 17 deadline.

Delhi Govt seals Maujpur play school over fire, building safety violations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A private play school in northeast Delhi’s Maujpur was sealed on August 31 after a Government inspection found serious violations involving fire safety, building permissions, emergency access and the use of a basement for classes.

The action was taken after an inspection report issued by the Sub-Divisional Magistrate, Yamuna Vihar. The school, which is under scrutiny, is Makoons Kids Unplugged, a pre-school and daycare activity centre located at 158, Main Road, Jammu Mohalla, Maujpur.

The officials found that the premises did not have a fire safety certificate and lacked a sanctioned building plan or completion and occupancy certificate. The inspection was conducted to check compliance with provisions of the Delhi Maintenance and Management of Immovable Property Act, the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act and the Delhi Fire Service Act.

The report, dated August 31 and signed by SDM Shakti Bangar, said the school had failed to produce satisfactory replies or the required permissions during the inspection. The premises

were subsequently sealed “to ensure public safety”. Among the most serious findings was the condition of the building’s emergency arrangements. The inspection team found that the emergency exit and staircases were blocked. The only fire extinguisher available at the premises was also found to be non-functional.

The school was further found to be operating without a fire safety certificate. Officials also found



that there was no sanctioned building plan, completion certificate or occupancy certificate for the premises. The inspection raised concerns about the use of space inside the building. Rooms in the basement were allegedly being used by the school for conducting classes, which the report described as a violation of the Delhi Municipal

Corporation Act. The officials also noted that the school was functioning in a residential area while carrying out commercial activity.

Another concern was the lack of ventilation. The inspection report said the rooms did not have proper air circulation, adding to concerns about the suitability of the premises for young children. Officials also found a borewell at the site but said the school management could not produce

permission for its installation during the inspection.

The school was also found to be operating a kitchen on the first floor using domestic LPG cylinders, according to the report. The combination of cooking activity, residential use and inadequate fire safety arrangements raised further concerns about the safety of children and staff on the premises.

The inspection was carried out specifically to identify violations of provisions governing building use, municipal requirements and fire safety. The report said the authorities sealed the premises after the director of the play school failed to provide a satisfactory response or produce necessary permissions. The school’s Maujpur address is also listed on the official Makoons website as one of its Delhi pre-school centres. The site describes the centre as a Makoons pre-school and gives the same address at 158, Main Road, Jammu Mohalla, Maujpur.

The action comes against the backdrop of Delhi’s regulatory framework for educational and early-learning facilities. The city’s planning documents recognise play schools, nursery schools and similar early-learning facilities in certain residential settings under mixed-use provisions, but such premises remain subject to development and safety controls.

Fire safety certificates issued by the Delhi Fire Service also make clear that safety equipment must remain functional and that such certification does not regularise unauthorised construction or alterations.

MCD panel to take up medical college, Town Hall proposals



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The MCD Standing Committee is set to consider a slew of proposals on Tuesday, including setting up a medical college and an attached hospital at Kingsway Camp under the PPP model and revival of the historic Town Hall in Chandni Chowk.

The meeting, scheduled to take place at the Municipal Council of Delhi’s (MCD) Civic Centre, will also take up the proposal to formally declare 48 villages as “urban villages” under sections of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957, officials said.

On the urban planning front, the agenda includes development and revision of layout plans for several educational and institutional sites, including Hindu College and Hansraj College in Delhi University’s North Campus, Jamia Hamdard and the National Metro Rail Knowledge Centre near Vishwavidyalaya Metro station, according to officials.

Under the healthcare proposal, the civic body plans to develop a medical college and hospital on vacant land within the premises of the RBIPMT at Kingsway Camp. The MCD has proposed appointing SBI Capital Markets Ltd (SBICAP) as the transaction service adviser for the project.

The committee is also expected to consider a conservation and adaptive reuse plan for the Town

Hall in Chandni Chowk, including its side wings and adjoining parks.

Officials said that anticipatory approval of many of these projects has already been taken and passing the agenda item will be formalised and ratified by the Standing Committee.

Several proposals aimed at improving sanitation and cleanliness are also on the agenda. These include the procurement of 70 mechanical road sweeping machines through a 10-year service-outsourcing contract and the engagement of 1,000 battery-operated vacuum-based “litter picker machines” for eight years.

The committee will also consider agenda item of upgrading street lighting in the Civil Lines, City-SP, Karol Bagh, Keshavpuram, Rohini and Narela zones. The proposal envisages a 10-year comprehensive operation and maintenance contract, including areas that have not been authorised for regular civic development.

Other items include proposals related to renaming MCD zones, settlement of long-pending audit paras, extension of solid waste management contracts and setting up Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Kendras at municipal hospitals.

The proposals are part of the civic body’s broader efforts to improve municipal services, infrastructure and access to public amenities in the city, officials added.

Minor gang-raped on sleeper bus from Greater Noida to Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 16-year-old girl from Uttar Pradesh was allegedly gang-raped by a bus driver and conductor inside a moving sleeper bus. The incident took place during a 47-kilometre journey from Greater Noida to Old Delhi on the night of August 4. The crime surfaced after the Delhi police confirmed on Monday, nearly a month after the incident.

Police used CCTV footage and other investigative inputs to trace the bus to a parking facility in Timarpur, north Delhi. The accused, identified as driver Kuldeep, 39, and conductor Sandeep, 26, have been arrested, and the bus has been seized and sent for forensic examination. Deputy Commissioner of Police (North) Niharika Bhatt said. Police said Sandeep has no prior criminal record.

The crime, which brought back painful memories of the 2012 gang-rape and murder in Delhi known as the Nirbhaya case, took place on the night of August 4.

Investigators have also examined the circumstances in which the bus was being operated. According to police sources, the vehicle had earlier developed a technical fault and had been taken to a workshop in Surajpur, Greater Noida, for repairs. After the repairs, Kuldeep and Sandeep were driving the empty bus towards Timarpur when they encountered the girl.

According to police, the



The suspected sleeper bus after a 16-year-old Class 11 student was allegedly gang-raped inside it in Delhi's Kashmere Gate area on Monday

PTI

girl, a class 11 student from Mainpuri district, left home without informing her family on August 4 after being scolded by her mother a day earlier. She was travelling to Noida Sector 63 to meet her cousin.

Amid heavy rain and darkness, she mistakenly got off at Pari Chowk in Greater Noida, believing she had reached her destination, police said. Realising her error, she signalled an approaching empty sleeper bus for help. The conductor told her the bus was headed to Noida Sector 63 and offered her a lift, following which she boarded the vehicle.

According to the girl's statement to police, the conductor began behaving inappropriately soon after the bus started moving. The driver and conductor then sexually

assaulted her and threatened to kill her if she resisted, DCP Bhatt said.

The bus, which had been returning empty from a repair workshop in Greater Noida's Surajpur area, continued on toward Delhi. The girl was allegedly assaulted through the length of the journey before being abandoned near Ring Road, close to Kashmere Gate ISBT, late that night. The accused then fled.

The girl approached Kashmere Gate police station and reported the assault. Police arrested both accused the same day from a bus parking lot in north Delhi's Timarpur. Police said the sleeper bus had curtains fitted throughout, meaning people outside would not have been able to see what was happening inside the

vehicle during the journey.

A forensic team examining the bus found strands of the girl's hair inside, according to reports. Police have also conducted potency tests on the accused following their arrest. An officer investigating the case, speaking on condition of anonymity, said frequent barricading along the route had been difficult since much of it ran through highways and Ring Road, where checks risked causing severe traffic congestion. Police personnel had, however, been deployed near the Delhi border at the Noida entry point.

The officer said police informed the girl's family about the incident the same night and called them to Delhi. A woman police officer remained with the girl and

43-km bus journey exposes gaps in roadside surveillance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 43-km journey by a private sleeper bus through Greater Noida and Delhi, during which a 16-year-old girl was allegedly gang-raped, has exposed glaring gaps in roadside surveillance and policing, with investigators finding just two proper checkpoints along the route, officials said.

A senior police officer privy to the investigation said the entire route, from Pari Chowk to Kashmere Gate, is being mapped to ascertain the availability of police checkpoints, barricades, CCTV cameras and other surveillance mechanisms along the 43-km stretch.

"We got to know that the first checkpoint was a few metres away from Pari Chowk. There was a police booth and heavy barricading installed along the roadside," the officer said, requesting anonymity.

Investigators are track-



ing the bus's journey through major checkpoints and intersections to determine whether it was captured by CCTV cameras, whether vehicle monitoring systems were operational and whether police personnel were deployed at critical points.

One such point was the Delhi-Noida intersection near Mayur Vihar, one of the busiest stretches along the route. Heavy barricading was installed along the roadside, but there were no police personnel present at the spot during the night, the officer said.

CCTV cameras were also missing from the traffic signals at the intersection, creating another surveillance gap on a route that the bus allegedly travelled without being stopped, he said.

Police are examining footage from cameras installed at other points to reconstruct the bus's movement and identify any locations where it may have stopped before reaching Kashmere Gate.

The route assessment found further gaps near the destination. At Kashmere Gate, there was no barricading or checkpoint at the

location where the journey ended, according to the investigation.

"In the 43-km stretch that we covered, we could trace only two proper checkpoints before reaching the final destination, Kashmere Gate," the officer said.

The findings are significant as the bus was not operating a regular passenger service that night. According to the travel company and investigators, it had been taken to a workshop at Surajpur in Greater Noida for repairs after developing a technical fault and was later being driven towards Kashmere Gate for painting.

The route assessment has raised questions over the monitoring of vehicles travelling between the National Capital Region and Delhi, particularly at major intersections where barricading and surveillance infrastructure existed but police personnel or CCTV cameras were allegedly missing.

School cab driver held for sexually assaulting toddler

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A cab driver employed at a private school in Delhi's Bawana area has been arrested for allegedly sexually assaulting a three-year-old nursery student on multiple occasions, police said on Monday. According to police, the accused allegedly lured the child with chocolates before touching her inappropriately on several occasions. He has been identified as Vikas Singh and had been working at the school for around eight months.

The case came to light after the child's mother noticed a change in her daughter's behaviour and questioned her about it. The child told her mother about a "bad uncle" at school who used to give her chocolates, but was unable to identify the person by name.

Unable to get further details from the child, the parents approached the school administration. On August 24, school authorities showed the child photographs and CCTV footage from the premises, through which she identified the accused driver, police said. Police's preliminary investigation indicated the child had been assaulted four times.

Following this identification, the school informed police, and



the child's parents filed a complaint at Bawana police station. An FIR was registered under relevant sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, along with provisions relating to sexual harassment and assault, according to police. The accused was arrested from the school premises. Preliminary investigation found he had been employed at the school as a driver for approximately eight months prior to his arrest.

A police official described the pattern of the alleged assaults. "CCTV footage shows the accused roaming around the

school premises with chocolates in his pocket. It is alleged that he followed the minor when she went to the washroom, offered her chocolate, and assaulted her under the staircase," the official said.

Investigators have seized the accused's mobile phone, which reportedly contained several videos showing him offering chocolates to other young children at the school. Police said they are working to identify these other children so that they can be provided with necessary counselling. CCTV footage from across the school premises has also been taken into

police custody as part of the investigation, which remains ongoing.

Police have not yet disclosed the total number of children who may have been targeted, nor have they specified the exact dates on which the alleged assaults on the identified victim took place, beyond confirming that they occurred on multiple occasions over the course of his employment at the school.

The case adds to a series of recent incidents in Delhi involving alleged sexual offences against children by drivers, conductors and other support staff employed in and around schools and transport services, prompting renewed scrutiny of background verification and monitoring procedures for such staff.

Police said further investigation is underway, including efforts to corroborate the child's identification of the accused with additional footage and any further statements from other children or staff members who may have witnessed his movements around the school.

The accused was booked at Bawana police station under relevant provisions of the POCSO Act. The case includes Sections 8, 10 and 21 of the POCSO Act and Section 74 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The accused has been arrested as the investigation continues.

10-year-old dies after allegedly being made to stand in sun at Govt school

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 10-year-old girl studying at a Government school in east Delhi's Vinod Nagar died last week during treatment. The family of the child alleged that she had been punished by a teacher for not bringing a book to school, forcing her to stand out in the sun, police sources said on Monday.

Commenting on the matter, Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood said that an inquiry is currently underway into the tragic death of the student at the school in East Vinod Nagar.

"Pending the completion of the inquiry, the concerned teacher has been transferred with immediate effect to ensure that the investigation is conducted fairly and without any interference. The Government is treating this matter with the utmost seriousness and sensitivity. If the inquiry establishes any negligence, dereliction of duty, or irregularity at any level, strict and decisive action will be taken against those found responsible, in accordance with the law," he said.

According to police sources, the incident occurred at Sarvodaya Kanya Vidyalaya on August 27. The school contacted



The family members protesting outside the school on Monday

the girl's mother, identified as Anjali, after her daughter's health deteriorated during the day. The mother of the child alleged that when she reached the school, she found her daughter standing outside in the sun and visibly unwell. The family has alleged that a teacher had punished the girl for not bringing a book to class that day.

The girl was subsequently taken to a hospital, where she died during treatment on August 27, according to the police source. Following her death, family members and local residents held a protest outside the school, demanding strict action against those found responsible for the

incident. BJP MLA Ravinder Singh Negi visited the school after the protest and said an inquiry would be conducted into the matter, adding that strict action would be taken against any school staff member found guilty of wrongdoing. Police said the allegations made by the family are currently being investigated.

The police source did not specify what medical condition led to the girl's death, nor has an official cause of death been confirmed pending further investigation. It also remains unclear whether any specific teacher or staff member has been formally named or questioned by police in connection with the incident so far.

Police have not indicated whether a formal FIR has been registered in the matter, or under what specific legal provisions the investigation is currently proceeding. The Directorate of Education has not yet issued a public statement on the incident or on the inquiry referred to by the local MLA.

Further details, including the findings of any inquiry ordered by education authorities or a post-mortem examination report, are expected to emerge as the investigation progresses

GPS plan for buses entering Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Days after a teenage girl was gang-raped on a moving bus in Noida, the Delhi Government plans to adopt a GPS to monitor buses entering the national Capital from neighbouring States in real-time and facilitate swift action in emergencies.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the city Government plans to link the GPS systems of buses entering Delhi from neighbouring States with the relevant Delhi government department's system. The chief minister also ordered the sealing of a private daycare and playschool in Jafrabad following allegations of physical and sexual abuse of a three-year-old child. The Chief Minister warned that school managements found negligent in cases involving children's safety would be held accountable alongside those directly responsible.

The Chief Minister's remarks come amid separate ongoing police investigations into the Jafrabad daycare case, the Bawana school assault case, and the interstate bus rape case involving the minor from Uttar Pradesh, all of which have drawn public attention to gaps in child safety oversight across schools, daycare centres and transport services operating in and around Delhi.

The chief minister said that inhumane treatment of young school-children was deeply distressing for any civilised society and that her government would not stay silent on such



matters. She directed officials to ensure immediate action wherever children's safety was compromised and to pursue strict legal action against those found responsible.

On the Jafrabad case, the Chief Minister said the law was already taking its course, but added that the government would not remain a mute spectator. She said the Delhi government would extend legal assistance to the child's family if required. The Chief Minister also addressed the alleged sexual assault of a three-year-old nursery student by a school bus driver in Bawana, expressing strong displeasure over the staff member's alleged involvement and questioning the school management's accountability in the matter.

The Chief Minister said school man-

agements were responsible for ensuring proper verification and continuous monitoring of bus staff involved in transporting children. She warned that if any school bus staff member was found involved in a similar incident in the future, responsibility would extend to the school management as well. She said the government intended to ensure that safety responsibilities laid down for schools, daycare centres and school transport systems were fully followed, with strict action against anyone found negligent.

The Chief Minister further expressed grief over the rape of a 16-year-old girl from Uttar Pradesh, allegedly assaulted inside a moving bus in the Delhi-NCR region. She raised concern over the alleged role of the bus driver and conductor involved, saying such incidents shook the conscience of civilised society.

To address safety gaps in interstate bus travel, the Chief Minister said the Delhi government would hold discussions with neighbouring state governments to strengthen safety measures for women and children travelling to and from the capital by bus.

She said the Government planned to develop a system linking the GPS systems of buses entering Delhi from other states with the tracking system used by the relevant Delhi government department. This, she said, would allow authorities to monitor the location of such buses and access other necessary information, enabling swifter action during emergencies.

Delhi draft voter roll shrinks 37.18% after SIR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The draft roll for Delhi after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise has 97,53,577 electors, compared to 1,55,24,858 in the electoral roll used for the Assembly elections held last February — a decline of 57,71,281, or 37.18 per cent.

Men account for a larger share of the decline as their numbers fell from 83,49,645 in 2025 to 49,88,993 in the draft roll, a reduction of 40.25 per cent. The number of female electors fell from 71,73,952 to 47,64,137, or 33.59 per cent.

As a result, women now account for 48.85 per cent of the draft electorate, compared to 46.21 per cent in the 2025 roll. The difference between male and female electors has narrowed from 11.76 lakh to 2.25 lakh. The change is significant among third-gender electors, whose numbers fell from 1,261 in 2025 to 447 in the draft roll, a reduction of 64.55 per cent.

The draft also has about half as many first-time voters in the 18 to 19 age group as compared to the 2025 roll. Their numbers have fallen



from 2,08,302 in 2025 to 1,03,870 now, a decline of 50.13 per cent.

Among electors aged 85 years and above, the number has fallen from 1,09,941 in 2025 to 40,871, or by 62.82 per cent. The draft roll separately lists 189 electors aged 100 years and above.

The largest of these categories was permanently shifted, absent or others, at 43,32,775 electors, or 29.86 per cent of the starting figures. Another 2,82,412 electors, or 1.95 per cent, were reported dead, while 1,41,535, or 0.98 per cent, were iden-

tified as enrolled at multiple places or duplicates.

The 57.71 lakh difference between the 2025 roll and the draft roll cannot, however, be treated as the number of electors deleted through the SIR.

The election authorities placed the remaining 47,56,722 electors in categories covering those who shifted permanently, were absent or otherwise not found, dead, and those enrolled at multiple places or identified as duplicates. The 2025 Assembly election roll had 1,55,24,858 electors,

whereas the SIR began with 1,45,10,299 electors. The draft roll figures of 97,53,577 reflect the enumeration forms collected during the exercise.

The 2025 Assembly election roll had 1,55,24,858 electors, whereas the SIR began with 1,45,10,299 electors. The draft roll figures of 97,53,577 reflect the enumeration forms collected during the exercise.

The draft roll is not the final electoral roll. The claims and objections period began on Monday and will continue till September 30. Electors whose names are missing can seek inclusion by submitting Form 6 with the prescribed declaration.

The Election Commission has also asked those who will turn 18 on or before October 1, 2026, to apply for inclusion through Form 6. Special enrolment drives are planned across Delhi. Transpersons and community representatives had pointed to problems during the enumeration stage, including differences in names across documents, difficulties in providing permanent address proof and lack of access to documents held by estranged family members.

Editor's
TAKE

Why India's Uzbekistan
upgrade matters

The Comprehensive Strategic Partnership takes bilateral ties beyond diplomacy, encompassing energy, defence, trade and regional connectivity

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's two-day state visit to Uzbekistan on August 29-30 – his fourth to the country – produced more than ceremony. At Tashkent's Kuksaroy Presidential Palace, Modi and President Shavkat Mirziyoyev agreed to elevate the 15-year-old India-Uzbekistan Strategic Partnership to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, timed with Uzbekistan's 35th Independence Day. Modi was also conferred the 'Oliy Darajali Do'stlik' Order, Uzbekistan's highest honour for a foreign leader and his 36th international award. Beyond symbolism, the visit yielded substance: sixteen outcomes, by official count.

A Coordination Council at foreign-minister level will steer the relationship, and the Joint Commission moves from secretary- to ministerial-level. The two sides agreed on a long-term uranium-supply framework for India's civil nuclear programme, growing defence cooperation spanning the industrial domain and the 'Dustlik' joint military exercise, and a trade target of \$5 billion by 2030 - nearly four times the \$1.3 billion in bilateral trade recorded in 2025, itself up a third over the previous year.

Why Uzbekistan? It is Central Asia's demographic and geographic anchor – home to nearly 38 million people, close to half the region's population, bordering all four Central Asian neighbours plus Afghanistan. Under Mirziyoyev, it has pursued sustained economic liberalisation and plays a leading role in the Central Asia-India summit format the two leaders reaffirmed at the level of heads of state. Civilisational memory, from Babur's Ferghana roots to the Silk Road threads binding Samarkand and Bukhara to the subcontinent, gives this relationship a resonance rare in India's extended neighbourhood.

The stakes extend well beyond bilateral ties. India shares no land border with Central Asia, and Pakistan blocks the direct route – a single fact of geography that explains the enduring importance of Iran's Chabahar port and the International North-South Transport Corridor as alternative arteries into a region India cannot otherwise reach. It also explains why uranium and critical minerals matter here: Central Asia offers India resource diversification independent of traditional suppliers. Add counter-terrorism cooperation, given the region's proximity to Afghanistan, and the logic sharpens further – a stable, partnered Uzbekistan is a hedge against instability spilling southwards.

There is a great-power dimension too: Russia remains Central Asia's historic security partner, China its largest trading partner and infrastructure financier through the Belt and Road Initiative. India can offer something distinct – a non-hegemonic partner with civilisational ties, pharmaceutical and technology capacity, and no territorial designs. The test, as ever, lies in execution: whether the \$5 billion trade target survives the connectivity bottleneck, and whether ministerial mechanisms translate into completed projects rather than communiqués.

India's quest for energy Atmanirbharta

India's dependence on imported hydrocarbons has long been its greatest energy vulnerability, a risk sharply exposed by recent disruptions to global oil supplies. By investing heavily in offshore exploration, India is seeking not instant self-sufficiency, but a stronger and more resilient energy base capable of cushioning the economy against future geopolitical shocks



ABHISHEK PRATAP SINGH KAUSTUBH TRIPATHI

The Union Cabinet approved the National Offshore Exploration Scheme, termed Samudra Manthan, on July 2026 31, committing ₹84,084 crore through Financial Year 2030-31, pushing for offshore hydrocarbon exploration, along with the stated ambition of adding over 600 million tonnes of oil equivalent to India's reserve base. This new scheme does not seem to be an incidental policy intervention, but rather part of a larger strategic orientation towards building sustainable energy goals.

In the last four months, India has had to face the test of its energy security challenges, given the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, resulting in the collapse of oil traffic by almost 97 per cent. The vulnerability lies in the very structure of the energy supply chains. India's import dependence on crude oil has climbed from 77 per cent in 2014 to nearly 88 per cent in 2026. Rising domestic demand, stagnant production and the gestation lag have made it more difficult. Also, roughly half of India's natural gas supply is imported from West Asia. Moreover, around 90 per cent of crude is bought from abroad, and half of that transits through the Strait of Hormuz. Even today, indigenous output accounts for only about 12 per cent of total domestic refinery demand.

At the same time, India finds itself competing directly with China for the same limited pool of discounted Russian and Venezuelan oil, a rivalry that analysts expect will continue for as long as Gulf supplies stay constrained by conflict. Russian oil, meanwhile, has grown more expensive to keep buying, since the risk now attached to it has pushed up the premium that buyers are forced to pay. Every lever India has used so far to manage its import dependence, whether that is Russian discounts, diversity of Gulf suppliers, or flexibility in the spot market, has been narrowed in recent months, laying bare the very risk that this dependence always carried.

Samudra Manthan can be best seen as India's long-term policy response to disruptions in global energy supply chains, aiming to convert demonstrated vulnerabilities into a long-term industrial project. Pushing for local exploration is not just an economic or policy goal but a geopolitical imperative. Huge public investment in offshore exploration is a well-intended political choice made by the government.

For the past two decades, India's energy strategy has leaned mainly on demand-side diver-



SAMUDRA MANTHAN CAN BE BEST SEEN AS INDIA'S LONG TERM POLICY RESPONSE TO DISRUPTIONS IN THE GLOBAL ENERGY SUPPLIES CHAINS, AIMING TO CONVERT DEMONSTRATED VULNERABILITIES INTO A LONG TERM INDUSTRIAL PROJECT. PUSHING FOR LOCAL EXPLORATION IS NOT JUST AN ECONOMIC OR POLICY GOAL BUT A GEOPOLITICAL IMPERATIVE

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sification. In simple terms, this has meant buying oil from a wider range of countries, settling payments in different currencies, and relying on a greater variety of shipping routes. To say, when Hormuz was shut, India's energy diversification strategy of the preceding three years was tested and found to be only partially adequate, with floating Russian cargoes at sea and a temporary waiver from Washington permitting their purchase. Samudra Manthan is trying to address this challenge from the supply side of the energy equation. This policy is more inclined towards reducing India's reliance on external energy shocks, given any kind of geopolitical volatility. Offshore exploration is one lever that India can possibly design and operate on its own terms, and that is precisely what Samudra Manthan is largely aiming for in the longer run.

Some critics may argue that with this policy initiative, India is moving away from clean energy. However, energy security and energy transition are not necessarily mutually exclusive objectives. The prolonged dependence of heavy transport, aviation, shipping, and petrochemicals on hydrocarbons underscores the strategic urgency of bolstering domestic energy output and production capacity over imported fuels. Another argument is that domestic production is not a quick substitute for import security, and the scheme's own six-year horizon concedes this fact. Deepwater and ultra-deepwater exploration, which Samudra Manthan is designed to accelerate, are globally among the most expensive hydrocarbon initiatives. In addition, they require quite advanced and complex technological support, big-term investment timelines, and stable policy frameworks. Having said that, this new policy by the

Modi government is pushing India's overarching energy transition from source diversification to import substitution by building home-grown offshore resources. The Samudra Manthan policy operationalises this strategic doctrine through three transformative takeaways.

Firstly, it dismantles historic exploration bottlenecks by co-funding up to 50 per cent of high-risk deepwater drilling costs, catalysing substantial private and global upstream investments into this sector. Secondly, scaling domestic crude and natural gas output constructs a reliable "strategic buffer" that insulates core industries like aviation, shipping, and heavy freight logistics from recurring supply chain disruptions.

And thirdly, in the longer run, by drastically reducing the country's energy import bill, it preserves critical foreign exchange reserves, enabling India to reinvest sovereign capital into building state-of-the-art subsea infrastructure and indigenous industrial supply chains. More importantly, this can lead to developing domestic advanced naval capabilities, cementing our stature as a formidable maritime power in the Indian Ocean.

The fact that Samudra Manthan addresses the structural, decade-scale vulnerability in India's energy security is very significant and well timed. The scheme's success should be measured not against whether it makes India self-sufficient, but whether it narrows, even if incrementally, the gap between a growing economy's appetite for oil and the barrels that India imports globally. Thus, Samudra Manthan is not a stand-alone policy initiative but part of a broader policy strategy to maximise every viable domestic energy resource and aim for self-reliance in energy security for India in the near future.

PIC TALK



Painted storks stand in a waterbody, at the Alipore Zoological Garden in Kolkata PHOTO: PTI

Janmashtami: When Krishna is born within



RADHANATH SWAMI MAHARAJ

2ND OPINION

Every year, millions celebrate Janmashtami with devotion, fasting, prayers, music and joyous festivities. Temples are beautifully decorated, homes resonate with the chanting of Krishna's names, and stories of His divine birth are lovingly retold. Yet the deepest significance of Janmashtami lies beyond history or celebration. It invites us to ask a profound question: Can Krishna be born in our own hearts? According to the ancient scriptures, Lord Krishna appeared in a prison at midnight. Symbolically, this prison represents the condition of the human mind. We often become prisoners of fear, anger, greed, ego and endless desires. Though materially comfortable, many people silently struggle with anxiety, loneliness and dissatisfaction. True freedom does not come merely from changing external circumstances; it begins



with transforming our inner consciousness.

Krishna's appearance signifies the arrival of divine wisdom that dispels the darkness within. Just as dawn naturally removes the night, love, compassion and selfless devotion gradually dissolve ignorance and suffering. Janmashtami, therefore, reminds us that every human heart has the potential to become a sacred temple where divine qualities can awaken. One of Krishna's greatest teachings is that real happiness cannot be purchased, possessed or achieved through status alone. Wealth, success and recognition have their place, but they cannot satisfy the deepest longing of the soul. Lasting fulfilment arises when our lives are connected to a higher purpose and when our actions become expressions of love and service.

In today's fast-paced world, people are surrounded by

constant distractions but often feel disconnected from themselves and from one another. Krishna's message is timeless because it calls us back to relationships built on trust, compassion, gratitude and humility. Even a few moments of sincere prayer, meditation, chanting or selfless service each day can bring remarkable peace amidst life's turbulence. Janmashtami is also a celebration of hope. Krishna was born during a period of oppression and uncertainty, reminding humanity that divine grace often manifests when darkness appears greatest. Every challenge carries within it the possibility of spiritual awakening. Every setback can become an opportunity to deepen faith, strengthen character and discover resilience.

Ultimately, Janmashtami is not merely about commemorating an event that happened thousands of years ago. It is an invitation to experience that miracle here and now. Whenever we replace selfishness with kindness, resentment with forgiveness, pride with humility and fear with faith, Krishna is born again within us.

Perhaps the most meaningful way to celebrate Janmashtami is not only by decorating temples, but by beautifying our own hearts. For when the heart becomes pure through love, compassion and devotion, every day becomes Janmashtami, every action becomes worship, and every moment becomes an opportunity to experience the presence of the Divine.

The writer is the spiritual guru of the International Society for Krishna Consciousness

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NURTURING INDIA'S SPORTING TALENT
BEYOND CRICKET

The Indian cricket legend Kapil Dev has rightly emphasised the promotion of non-cricketing disciplines in India. He was appealing to the Telangana government to provide platforms for budding golfers and nurture them into champions. Apart from cricket, other disciplines such as athletics, football and badminton suffer due to various factors.

Athletes suffer from substandard facilities, especially in rural areas, where talent is immense. Most public schools lack standard-sized football grounds. Badminton is an expensive sport, with facilities predominantly available in urban hubs such as Hyderabad and Bengaluru. Consequently, these facilities do not reach the rural masses, where raw talent might otherwise be identified and nurtured. In hockey too, India does not consistently perform as well as it once did.

Cricket offers much greater commercial opportunities, making young athletes choose cricket over hockey. Identifying young talent in sports other than cricket is the first step required. After that, they need to be given sustained coaching, proper nutrition, fitness training and competitive exposure.

It is imperative for government bodies to act with great earnestness to enable players to compete in global events across disciplines other than cricket. India has no shortage of sporting talent; what it needs is a robust system to identify, nurture and support athletes from an early age. Greater investment in grassroots infrastructure, coaching facilities and equal opportunities can help India develop a stronger sporting culture and produce champions across a wider range of disciplines.

S SANKARANARAYANAN | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

China-Nepal floods: A humanitarian crisis

The devastating floods near the China-Nepal border have caused significant loss of life and immense suffering. So far, more than 400 people, including Indian and foreign nationals, have been reported missing due to the flood havoc. Although India responded immediately to this neighbourhood concern on the highest priority, the situation remains alarming, with the death toll continuing to rise across different regions of Nepal. So far, 360 bodies have been recovered from Rasuwa, Chitwan, Dhading, Gorkha and Nawalparasi West. The floods have also caused widespread infrastructural destruction in Nepal. Considering the severity of the crisis, the bordering states of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar have been placed on high alert.

Natural disasters come without warning, leaving deep scars and tragic trauma for survivors and the families of those who have lost their lives. Pilgrims undertaking the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, hydropower project workers, tourists and local residents were among the major victims of these devastating floods.

The governments of India, China and Nepal must work together to manage the crisis, providing immediate relief, rescue operations and speedy recovery. We hope the situation will soon come under control and that assistance will reach the affected people as quickly as possible.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

No political victory at children's cost

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay's legal defence before the Madras High Court, stating that the alleged use of children to sway voters cannot invalidate an election victory, is a tactical manoeuvre to evade political ethics and morality. Even if Section 100 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, demands proof of a "material impact" on poll outcomes, masking child exploitation behind statutory technicalities sets a dangerous precedent.

The Election Commission of India's order of February 5, 2024 explicitly directed political parties not to engage children in any form of election campaign, including rallies, slogan-shouting, distribution of posters or pamphlets, or any other election-related activity. It also directed political leaders and candidates not to use children for campaign activities in any manner.

Dismissing this core directive as a non-binding guideline that carries no penalty for a winning candidate makes a mockery of child-protection measures. If political leaders rely on loopholes to bypass child-welfare standards during elections, we risk normalising the exploitation of impressionable minds for political survival. Electoral victories should never come at the cost of children's dignity, safety and rights.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

The long road back for Indian hockey

It is with reference to the news in the Sports column, "Indian men's hockey team finishes 8th at WC" - August 30. The Indian hockey team, dreaming of winning a World Cup after 51 years, could finish in eighth place at the 2026 FIH Men's Hockey World Cup after losing a close penalty shootout 3-4 to Belgium. Before the World Cup, Head Coach Craig Fulton had said that India had about a 5-6 per cent chance of winning the title. He was not wrong; they were ranked eighth in the world. Even though India had won an Olympic bronze medal only two years ago, they were not among the favourites to reach the final.

India started well in the pool stage, beating Wales and Pakistan, but struggled in the second round, with losses to top sides such as the Netherlands and a 3-5 defeat to Australia, which ended their semi-final hopes. The tournament highlighted the need to improve collectively in defence. Harmanpreet Singh's eight goals were a bright spot, but India must address defensive shortcomings ahead of the Asian Games and the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. Strengthening zonal championships at U-16 and U-19 levels can help identify talent early and smooth its transition to the senior squad.

P VICTOR SELVARAJ | TAMIL NADU

Shifting the strategy from reactive relief to ecological resilience

To escape the annual cycle of crisis, India must shift its strategy from reactionary containment to integrated ecosystem restoration. A primary defence against floods requires strengthening environmental, forest, riverscape and floodplain zoning laws and ensuring their strict implementation



BKP SINHA | ARVIND KUMAR JHA

In every monsoon season, the Indian landmass is under siege from its own rivers and rainwater trying to adhere to their traditional drainage routes. The most chronically affected belts include the Brahmaputra and Barak river valleys in Assam; northern Bihar, with surging rivers such as the Bagmati, Kosi and Gandak flowing from Nepal; eastern Uttar Pradesh along the Ganges, Rapti and Ghaghara basins; and the low-lying deltas formed by the Mahanadi, Subarnarekha and Hooghly rivers in coastal Odisha and West Bengal. Surprisingly, traditionally dry regions also now face unpredictable flood disasters, while many urban and major cities like Mumbai, Chennai and Bengaluru suffer chronic annual flooding from overflowing rivers and overburdened drainage systems. The Central Water Commission (CWC) estimated flood-related financial losses at ₹12,000-15,000 crore in 2024 and ₹14,000-17,000 crore in 2025.

In the 2026 monsoon season, severe hydrological destruction has occurred across multiple Indian states, leaving a path of catastrophic infrastructure loss and mass displacement. Assam's border districts of Sivasagar and Charaideo, Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh suffered flash floods triggered by cloudbursts, resulting in massive damage to mountain infrastructure, the local economy, life, property and people's livelihoods. Jammu & Kashmir alone suffered damage due to over three dozen cloudbursts. Gujarat and Maharashtra faced torrential downpours that submerged urban centres, disrupted civic infrastructure and caused fatal structural collapses. In Odisha, emergency evacuation of over two lakh people from low-lying settlements had to be resorted to. In southern India, Kerala suffered fierce flash flooding that brought not only urban areas to a halt but also triggered red alerts across hilly terrains.

In the case of the widely reported floods in Assam's rural areas, fast-moving runoff overwhelmed the channels, long clogged by silt and debris from upstream deforestation, illegal coal mining and riverbed quarrying. It swept away border villages, killed a large number of people and livestock, and submerged agricultural lands. Interestingly, however, routine urban flooding in Guwahati, driven by severe soil erosion across the surrounding slopes and denuded hills, occurs every year. Monsoon downpours bring silt and debris into the city's drainage channels, choking them. The Guwahati Municipal Corporation and Public Works Department spend multi-crore budgets annually on drain desilting, relying heavily on a recurring, symptom-focused fix, while yearly topsoil entering the drains nullifies the cleanup efforts year after year.

Public discourse often blames climate change for severe floods. Empirical hydrological data, however, proves that forest destruction, reckless construction and damaged natural drainage truly dictate the scale of the disaster, with heavy rain acting as the trigger.

Neglecting land-use policy has allowed the unplanned restructuring and misuse of natural landscapes to become the primary driver of India's recurring floods. Customary common lands like gairans, having been diverted mindlessly for various purposes, have increased biotic pressure on forest lands significantly over time. Deforestation and diversion of forest lands in river catchment areas have stripped away topsoil, which washes down into waterways. Silt accumulates rapidly, raises riverbeds and strips channels of their natural carrying capacity, leading to huge areas becoming inundated. Rampant and unplanned urbanisation has led to the systematic encroachment of wetlands, lakes and floodplains that historically functioned as natural sponges. In urban areas, with concrete pavements replacing soil surfaces, rainwater runoff does not get soaked into the ground, and streets turn into raging channels. This problem is further compounded by urban drainage systems designed for population densities of a bygone era, which are routinely left choked with plastic and solid waste, as well as unmanaged sediment.

The human and financial toll of this annual neglect is profound. Marginalised communities living along vulnerable riverbanks, sandbars and low-lying urban informal



BY PAIRING NATURE-ALIGNED HYDROLOGICAL DESIGN WITH STRICT ENVIRONMENTAL ACCOUNTABILITY, INDIA CAN TRANSFORM ITS URBAN AND RURAL LANDSCAPES FROM VULNERABLE LANDMASSSES INTO RESILIENT, FLOOD-SAFE ENVIRONMENTS. FORESTS, BEING A UNIQUE 'NATURAL INFRASTRUCTURE' AND THE BEST DEFENCE AGAINST FLOODS, MUST BE SUSTAINABLY MANAGED BY INDIA AT ALL COSTS

The writers are former PCCFs of Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra

settlements/slums routinely bear the brunt of displacement. Essential public utilities, bridges, power grids and local transport networks face structural decay from repeated waterlogging, imposing a heavy economic burden on states. Beyond immediate destruction, which also hinders disaster management efforts, standing floodwaters mix with open sewage systems to contaminate drinking water sources, creating public health crises through outbreaks of waterborne diseases.

Despite the above, governance priorities remain weak on long-term solutions. Regulatory bodies often favour costly, reactive engineering projects over ecological management. Concrete embankments are planned at huge public expense, while damaged river dynamics and siltation remain unaddressed. Post-disaster allocations prioritise short-term relief over long-term resilience. Direct allocation to India's environment and forestry sector is under 0.01 per cent of its GDP. Urban master plans often bypass environmental assessments to prioritise real estate, ignoring watersheds, floodplains and natural drainage systems.

Compounding the above structural failures is the continuous dilution of environmental safeguards designed to protect sensitive ecosystems. Amendments to Environmental Impact Assessment guidelines have raised the built-up area thresholds required for rigorous ecological clearances, allowing large-scale real estate and commercial projects to bypass detailed scrutiny. The provisions of the Forest Conservation Act have been diluted. Rampant land-use changes - driven by forest encroachments and illegal regularisations - have worsened due to weak Forest Rights Act implementation, while the Jan Vishwas Act has decriminalised some offences previously prosecutable under the Indian Forest Act. Introduced decades ago by the CWC to restrict building on river basins, the Model Flood Plain Zoning Bill remains largely unadopted by major flood-prone states due to real estate pressure and rapid urbanisation. Systemic dismantling of protective laws leaves catchments, rivers and natural drainage paths legally unprotected, permitting heavy development on land that naturally absorbs floodwaters. This ultimately results in a flawed approach: prioritisation of engineering structures to control flood effects rather than working with nature to tackle root causes. Several nations have adopted nature-based approaches to flood management. The Netherlands' 'Room for the River' programme restored floodplains and widened riverbanks to allow controlled flooding. Japan has combined massive underground discharge channels beneath Tokyo with robust disaster response systems, community drills and resilient housing programmes.

While treating catchments and drainage lines remains important for reducing urban floods, sustainable water management increasingly embraces the concept of sponge cities. These designs use permeable pavements, rain gardens, green roofs and urban wetlands to absorb, store and purify rainwater, reducing runoff and flood risks. During heavy monsoons, storm runoff soaks naturally into ground aquifers or collects in subterranean retention ponds. When dry spells occur, this filtered water is pumped back out for domestic use and landscape irrigation, effectively converting a flood hazard into a secure water reserve.

To escape the annual cycle of crisis, India must shift its strategy from reactionary containment to integrated ecosystem restoration. Effective land-use policy, a primary defence against floods, requires active forestry sector participation in its creation and enforcement. Strengthening environmental, forest, riverscape and floodplain zoning laws and ensuring their strict implementation; establishing an independent regulator; and innovating solutions like the creation of sponge city infrastructure are crucial for flood management. By pairing nature-aligned hydrological design with strict environmental accountability, India can transform its urban and rural landscapes from vulnerable landmasses into resilient, flood-safe environments. Forests, being a unique 'Natural Infrastructure' and the best defence against floods, must be sustainably managed by India at all costs.

THE GIFT WE FORGET TO NOTICE

Most of us complain that life has grown dull and mundane. Every day, it is the same routine - waking, eating, working, sleeping, day after day. We live from weekend to weekend. I once asked myself whether I could still see something beautiful in life. As I woke up and walked to the window, I saw a huge mango tree, its leaves hanging low, with beautiful sunrises peeping through them. I simply stood there, watching. I made my morning tea, and it tasted wonderful. I thought - life truly is beautiful. The sunrises, the greenery around, people who care for us, the good health to do the things we want, every comfort we enjoy - and yet we still call life mundane. The Upanishads remind us that the infinite does not announce itself only through the extraordinary; it lives quietly in the air we breathe, in what we see, in the music we hear, and in every new day given to us. We call these things ordinary only because we have stopped noticing them. Gratitude does not wait for life to improve. It looks at what is already here and refuses to look away. The moment we begin counting what we have been given, rather than what we lack, the same life we once called dull begins to glow. Tonight, before you sleep, name three things you received today that you did not earn. You may find the day was not as ordinary as you thought.



Scan to know more

Healthcare does not end at the doctor's door



ADARSH YADAV

India's healthcare system has made remarkable progress. We have advanced hospitals, highly trained doctors, better diagnostics and increasingly accessible digital health services. Yet, somewhere between the doctor's consultation and the patient's recovery, an important part of healthcare remains largely invisible: the patient journey itself.

For a patient, going to a hospital is rarely just about meeting a doctor. It can involve finding the right department, managing appointments, completing paperwork, waiting in queues, arranging tests, understanding admission procedures and dealing with discharge formalities. For families already dealing with fear and uncertainty, these seemingly routine tasks can become an additional burden.

The question we need to ask is simple: Who supports the patient through everything that happens around the treatment?

India has excellent medical professionals, but doctors and nurses cannot be expected to manage every non-clinical requirement of a patient. Their primary responsibility is medical care. The rest of the journey often falls on family members, who may themselves be working, living in another city or unable to spend hours at a hospital.

Changing family structures are making this gap more visible. Children increasingly live away from their parents. Working couples may find it difficult to take repeated leave for hospital visits. Elderly people may have to navigate hospitals on their own. Even when families are available, the emotional pressure of managing a hospital visit alongside medical concerns can be considerable.

This is where patient assistance needs to become part of the larger healthcare conversation.

A trained Hospital Companion can help with the practical aspects of a hospital visit: accompanying a patient, assisting with appointments and paperwork, helping navigate hospital processes, waiting in queues and supporting admission or discharge formalities. Such a person is not a doctor, nurse or substitute for a family caregiver. The role is different. It is about ensuring that a patient does not have to navigate a complicated system alone.

The need for such support is not merely about convenience. It is about dignity and peace of mind.

Healthcare technology has already made several parts of the system easier. People can book appointments online, consult doctors remotely and access reports digitally. But there are moments when technology cannot replace human presence. A patient who is anxious, an elderly person who is unfamiliar with a hospital or a family dealing with a medical emergency may need someone physically present to help them navigate the process.

The experience has reinforced a simple belief: healthcare must become more human not only inside the consultation room but throughout the patient's journey.

This does not mean every patient needs a companion. It means that those who need one should have access to reliable and trained support.

As India becomes more urban, mobile and digitally connected, healthcare delivery will also need to evolve. Hospitals, healthcare companies and policymakers should consider patient assistance as part of the wider ecosystem rather than treating it as an informal responsibility of families.

The quality of healthcare should not be judged only by the expertise available inside a hospital. It should also be judged by how a patient experiences the system from arrival to discharge.

A doctor provides medical expertise. A hospital provides infrastructure and treatment. But there is another need that deserves recognition: someone who can help a patient navigate the journey.

Sometimes, making healthcare more humane begins with simply making sure that no patient has to walk through it alone.



The writer is a healthcare expert and runs a non-governmental organisation

From Chicago to New York: A civilisational continuity



RAHUL KAUSHIK

lation of Bharatiya civilisational thought has taken place on American soil. In the centenary year of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, Sarsangchalak Mohan Bhagwat's address at the Universal Oneness Celebration in New York carried an unmistakable message: Hindu thought does not seek the triumph of one community over another; it seeks a world that recognises the fundamental unity of existence.

The historical circumstances are, of course, very different, and no two speeches need to be artificially equated. Yet the philosophical continuity between the message Swami Vivekananda carried to America and the ideas articulated by Mohanji Bhagwat is striking. At the centre of both lies an ancient Indian conviction that diversity need not produce division and that spiritual consciousness can provide a foundation for human fraternity.

Mohanji began with an illuminating contrast. America frequently speaks of "pluralism"; Bharat speaks of "unity in diversity". But for Bharat, he

argued, both unity and diversity are part of its very DNA. Diversity is not an inconvenience to be grudgingly tolerated. It is something to be "celebrated", "respected" and "accepted", without losing sight of the underlying oneness connecting humanity.

This was not merely a political appeal for tolerance. He took the argument much deeper, to the philosophical foundations of Sanatan Dharma.

"Unity of existence is our truth," he declared. His formulation that "diversity is natural and unity is truth" beautifully condensed an enormous body of Bharatiya philosophical wisdom into a few words. Here was Hindu thought occupying centre stage without becoming exclusionary. Bhagwat did not ask Hindus to diminish their identity in order to demonstrate their tolerance. Instead, the argument was almost the reverse: it is precisely because Hindu civilisation understands the unity underlying different manifestations of life that it can confidently celebrate plurality.

That distinction matters enormously. For too long, Hindu assertion and universalism have sometimes been presented as opposites, as though Hinduism must choose between being unapologetically Hindu and being genuinely pluralistic. Mohanji's speech rejected that false choice. Sanatan Dharma's universalism does not require Hindus to become less Hindu. Its conception of fraternity arises from within its own civilisational worldview.

His definition of Dharma was equally significant. Dharma, he said, is the principle through which the universe is sustained and through which human beings can properly manage the quality



of life. He described the balanced "middle path" as Dharma. This transforms the discussion from identity politics into civilisational responsibility.

The Hindu ideal is not simply "live and let live". It goes further towards recognising that existence itself is interconnected. Mohanji reminded his audience that Bharatiya saints pray even for the disappearance of enmity from the minds of those harbouring ill will. This is not weakness. It represents a civilisation sufficiently secure in itself to desire welfare beyond the boundaries of its own community. Perhaps one of the most important parts of the address was directed specifically towards Bharatiyas living in America. Mohanji asked them to remain loyal to their Karmabhoomi. Only after fulfilling that obligation, he said, should their desire to contribute to their Janmabhoomi find expression, and the finest way to do so is by living the values Bharat has given them.

This deserves attention. It was not a call for an expatriate community to remain detached from

American society. It was an appeal for integration without civilisational amnesia: be responsible citizens of the country in which you live, while carrying with confidence the values of the civilisation from which you emerged.

And what should Bharatiyas give the world?

Not domination. Not conversion. Not cultural uniformity. His answer was example.

"The duty of a Bharatiya," he argued, is to carry this message to the world "through practice, not through preaching". That may have been among the most profoundly Hindu lines of the entire address. The symbolism of the occasion becomes still more striking in the RSS's centenary period. From its beginnings in Nagpur in 1925, the Sangh and the wider ecosystem inspired by it have developed a substantial presence among Hindu communities outside India. A gathering bringing together numerous Hindu-American organisations, faith leaders and a large diaspora audience therefore carries significance beyond the event itself. It demonstrates that organised Hindu civilisational consciousness is no longer confined geographically to Bharat. The scale and breadth of mobilisation around the Sarsangchalak unquestionably illustrate the Sangh's emergence as one of the most consequential organised voices of Hindu civilisational identity globally.

And therein lies the larger significance of New York. Mohanji invoked Swami Vivekananda's teaching that every nation has "a message to deliver, a mission to accomplish, and a destiny to fulfil". For Bharat, he said, that destiny is to realise, and repeatedly help the world realise, the

unity amid diversity. At a time when societies across the world struggle with religious conflict, racial tensions, ideological polarisation, loneliness, consumerism and competing absolutisms, the proposition that humanity can celebrate difference while recognising an underlying unity is anything but antiquated.

He also connected this philosophy with responsibility: what matters is not merely how much one earns but how much one gives back. "We have to give back. That is our Parampara," he said, presenting the Bharatiya idea of life as a sustainable model worth carrying forward. That is ultimately what made the address important.

In Chicago in 1893, Swami Vivekananda famously presented Hindu civilisation before the modern West with extraordinary confidence. In New York in 2026, Mohanji Bhagwat spoke from a different platform, in a different century and under entirely different historical circumstances. But an ancient civilisational conviction could still be heard: humanity is one; diversity enriches that oneness; Dharma sustains rather than divides; and the highest expression of Hindu consciousness is not merely the welfare of Hindus, but the welfare of all. More than a century after Chicago, Sanatan Dharma's proposition to humanity therefore remains remarkably relevant: not that the world must become uniform, but that it must learn how to remain diverse without forgetting that we belong to one another.

The writer is a commentator on socio-political issues

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Order Order

SC rejects SBI appeal over Jet Airways ex-employees' PF dues



The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed a plea by the State Bank of India against a National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) order directing the payment of provident fund and gratuity dues to former Jet Airways workmen and employees in full.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana refused to interfere with the June 30 NCLAT order. "Even though there are arguable points raised in this appeal, which ordinarily would require this court to decide, and the peculiar factual circumstances of the case, we are not inclined to interfere with the impugned order. The questions of law are left open to be examined in the appropriate case," the bench said.

The NCLAT upheld an earlier order passed by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) directing the airline's liquidator to pay provident fund and gratuity dues while dismissing appeals filed by the State Bank of India (SBI) and seven other financial creditors. The lenders had argued that provident fund, gratuity and pension fund dues should form part of the liquidation estate and be distributed among all the creditors under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC). They also contended that such dues could be excluded only if dedicated provident fund and gratuity funds existed at the commencement of liquidation.

The NCLAT said that employees' statutory dues would remain outside the liquidation estate, protecting them from competing creditor claims.

The top court in November 2024 ordered the grounded airline's liquidation, forfeiture of ₹200 crore infused by successful bidder Jalan Kalrock Consortium and permitted the lenders led by the SBI to encash ₹150 crore performance bank guarantee. (PTI)

Calcutta HC refuses West Bengal cricketer's early hearing plea



The Calcutta High Court on Monday refused a prayer by arrested Bengal cricketer Abhishek Porel for an expedited hearing of a petition by a woman alleging that he had sexual relations with her on the promise of marriage.

Porel's lawyer, Mayukh Mukherjee, sought an early hearing, stating that the cricketer had been in custody since August 11, his electronic devices had been seized, and the chargesheet had already been filed before the trial court.

The petition is currently scheduled to be heard on September 14.

Mukherjee submitted that Porel's bail plea had been rejected by the trial court as the alleged victim's petition was pending before the High Court.

He also said the selection process for the Bengal team was scheduled to begin soon.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya, however, refused to advance the hearing, observing that the allegations were serious in nature.

Porel's lawyer said the high court had earlier directed the cricketer's arrest and seizure of devices on which objectionable data could have been stored.

The high court had ordered police to arrest Porel and seize his electronic devices to prevent the dissemination of photographs of the complainant. Porel, who has played for Delhi Capitals in the Indian Premier League, was arrested by police in Hooghly district following a complaint by a medical student alleging that he had sexual relations with her on the promise of marriage. He is currently in judicial remand. (PTI)

SC rejects PIL seeking ethanol per cent label at petrol pumps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed a PIL seeking a directive to the Centre and others to ensure mandatory and uniform labelling on every dispensing nozzle at fuel pumps, disclosing the exact percentage of ethanol in petrol.

A bench of Justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale said it is not going to entertain the PIL under Article 32 (right to approach the Supreme Court directly) and the petitioner Narendra Kumar Goswami can approach the jurisdictional high court for relief. Attorney General R Venkataramani, appearing for the Centre, submitted

that it is a proxy litigation as a petition on a similar issue has been dismissed by the court.

"The petitioner wants the government of India to be answerable to him," the AG submitted.

Goswami, who produced a petrol pump receipt before the court, contended that he has the right to know the content of the petrol given at fuel pumps.

"Not only me but citizens at large should be informed about the composition of the fuel given to them," he submitted, adding that in the receipt there is no mention of ethanol content.

He further contended that the Attorney General had described the ethanol-



Externment order violates fundamental freedom: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday said an order of externment directly impinges upon the valuable fundamental freedoms guaranteed to a citizen, and it cannot be made as a matter of routine.

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu quashed an externment order passed in November last year against a man who was directed to remove himself from the territorial limits of Raigarh and contiguous districts in Chhattisgarh for one year.

The bench said the externment order was "infirm and indefensible" and cannot be sustained for want of any cogent reasons in support thereof.

"Further, merely because multiple criminal cases have been registered against a person would not, ipso facto, be a ground for ordering externment," it said.



It said before exercising such power, the district magistrate is required to arrive at a bona fide and informed subjective satisfaction that circumstances of the case warrant such an extreme measure and that externment is necessary to prevent the apprehended mischief.

The bench said although

the authority is not expected to render a judgment in the manner expected of a court of law, the order must nonetheless disclose, at least in broad terms, the reasons which persuaded it to arrive at such satisfaction.

"The existence of objective material and a discernible nexus between such

material and the conclusion reached are indispensable safeguards against arbitrary exercise of power," it said.

"An order of externment directly impinges upon valuable fundamental freedoms guaranteed to a citizen and, therefore, cannot be made as a matter of routine or on mere ipse dixit," the bench said.

The top court delivered its verdict on a plea filed by a man challenging a January order of the Chhattisgarh High Court.

The high court had dismissed his plea challenging the order of externment. It had also relegated him to the alternative statutory remedy of appeal under Section 9 of the Chhattisgarh Rajya Suraksha Adhiniyam, 1990.

The appellant had approached the High Court assailing an ex-parte order of externment passed against him. Dealing with the plea, the top court said no material was placed on record to show why the offences

alleged require the appellant to be externed.

"More importantly, as noticed earlier, the appellant was neither served with notice nor afforded an opportunity to tender his explanation before the order came to be passed," it said.

While quashing the High Court order as well as the externment order, the bench said the appellant is free to enter the districts from where his externment was ordered.

Referring to one of the provisions of the Adhiniyam, the bench said the object of the provision is to ensure that a person, against whom an externment order is proposed, is made aware of the material allegations against him and afforded an effective opportunity to tender his explanation.

It said there was no statutory basis for dispensing with compliance of the mandatory requirements of notice and opportunity of hearing before the impugned extern-

ment order came to be passed. The bench noted that in April 2019, a memorandum was submitted by the superintendent of police, Raigarh, to the DM recommending initiation of proceedings against the appellant to extern him under Sections 5(a) and (b) of the Adhiniyam.

The top court said it was premised on the appellant's alleged involvement in 10 criminal cases registered between 2009 and 2019.

Noting that the appellant had been acquitted in the criminal cases referred to in the memorandum, the DM closed the case by letting him off with a warning to refrain from indulging in criminal activities in future.

Two FIRs, including the one arising out of allegations of insulting a saint revered by a particular community, were registered against the appellant and consequently, a fresh report was submitted before the DM.

Marital status can't disqualify daughters from compassionate jobs, says Chhattisgarh HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bilaspur

The Chhattisgarh High Court has directed a bank to grant compassionate appointments to two married daughters of deceased employees, observing that their marital status should not be treated as a disqualification when the bank's scheme makes no distinction between a married son and a daughter.

Rejecting the daughters' claims solely on marital status was arbitrary, discriminatory, and legally unsustainable in law, a division bench of Chief Justice Ramesh Sinha and Justice Ravindra Kumar Agrawal said in the order on July 30.

If marriage does not disqualify a son from being considered a dependent family member, the same principle must apply when assessing the



case of a daughter, the HC noted. It held that denial of compassionate appointment to married daughters solely on the basis of their marital status, when married sons had been granted the same benefit under the scheme, was arbitrary, discriminatory and violative of Articles 14 and 15 of the Constitution.

The court allowed two separate appeals filed by Sheena David (33) of Bilaspur and Ankita Mishra (32) of Raipur challenging the HC's single-bench order.

Supreme Court agrees to hear Delhi Police's plea to quash FIRs against NEET protesters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court agreed to hear on Tuesday a plea filed by the Delhi Police seeking quashing of 13 FIRs registered against students who participated in the NEET paper leak protests and registering a fresh case against 2,873 individuals who were present during the stir to probe their role in the violence.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submission by Solicitor General of India Tushar Mehta, who mentioned the matter, seeking an urgent hearing.

As the bench was about to rise after the day's proceedings, Mehta said, "We want to move an IA (interlocutory application). It's regarding that protest for quashing of



FIRs... We are invoking Article 142 (of the Constitution)."

The top court remarked that it has no problem if parties are reconciling, and agreed to list the matter for hearing on Tuesday.

The application said that according to the decision taken by the central government on July 25, the Delhi Police no longer wished to pursue 13 FIRs registered in connection with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests.

"It is submitted that 2,873 individuals having serious criminal antecedents as per the National Crime Records Bureau database were prima facie reported to be present at the protest site. The investigation is required to ascertain their role, if any, in the commission of offences relating to bodily harm or destruction of property at the said protests.

"The Delhi Police seeks leave to file a fresh FIR only for these 2,873 individuals.

Goa nightclub fire case: Supreme Court upholds Bombay HC order cancelling bail of club owners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to interfere with the Bombay High Court order cancelling bail granted to the owners of a Goa nightclub where a fire claimed 25 lives in 2025.

A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu upheld the August 18 order of the high court and dismissed multiple petitions filed by Saurabh Luthra, Gaurav Luthra and Ajay Gupta, the co-owners of the Birch by Romeo Lane nightclub in North Goa's Arpora area, where a massive fire on December 6 last year left 25 people dead and over 50 injured.

The top court directed the trio to surrender within two weeks and asked the lower court to expedite the trial in the case by speeding up the process for framing of charges.

Senior advocates Abhishek M Singhvi and Siddharth Dave, appearing for Luthra brothers, submitted that the case is not a



direct intentional offence and it is of the nature of alleged negligence.

Dave submitted that there was no act on the part of the Luthra brothers which led to the killings.

He said, "Section 304, Part II (of IPC) is wholly and can never be applied to this case. There is no act of mine which has caused death. Maximum, if the prosecution wants to succeed in this case, then it can be under Section 304A (causing death by negligence)." Justice Datta asked Singhvi how many people lost their lives

in the restaurant.

The senior counsel submitted the death toll was 25, but there are two basic errors in the impugned judgment of the High Court.

He submitted that several other co-accused have been granted bail in the case.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for Gupta, submitted that he has only ten per cent share in the business and has nothing to do with the incident.

Additional Solicitor General SV Raju and standing counsel Surjendu Sankar Das, appearing for Goa,

opposed the petitions filed by the trio and said the High Court has asked them to surrender in two weeks.

The bench, while dismissing the petitions, said two weeks' time is granted to them from today to surrender. The Luthras had left for Phuket in Thailand shortly after the fire incident, following which an Interpol Blue Corner Notice was issued against them.

The two were detained by the Thai authorities in Phuket on December 11 following the intervention of the Indian mission, which was in close touch with the Thai government in the case. A Delhi court on December 16, 2025 granted a two-day transit remand to Goa police after they brought to India.

The high court had on August 18 set aside the bail of the trio, saying the trial court failed to properly consider the material collected during the probe, and erred in observing that the offence was not as heinous as murder or dacoity.



Colonel Sofiya Qureshi, MP minister Kunwar Vijay Shah

Sanction awaited to prosecute MP minister over remarks against Col Sofiya Qureshi: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court was informed on Monday that sanction was awaited to prosecute Madhya Pradesh minister Kunwar Vijay Shah for his remarks targeting Army officer Col Sofiya Qureshi after Operation Sindoor.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was also told by Additional Solicitor General KM Nataraj that the probe by the special investigation team (SIT) is complete, and the chargesheet will be filed once sanction is obtained from the competent authority.

"The report (by SIT) states that the investigation is complete and the report has been kept in a sealed cover. However, the issue of sanction is still pending consideration before the competent authority.

"It is submitted that as soon as sanction is granted, the chargesheet shall be submitted before the court of competent jurisdiction. Hence, as the issue of sanction is still pending consideration," the bench said in its order.

The top court took note of the submissions and adjourned the matter.

Senior advocate Maninder Singh, appearing for Shah, submitted that the minister had publicly apologised the

very next day and requested that the apology be considered.

The bench said the investigation report ultimately has to go before the competent authority.

On July 28, 2025, the top court had pulled up Shah for not placing a public apology over his remarks on record against Col Qureshi, saying he was "testing the court's patience".

It had pointed out that the minister's conduct was prompting it to doubt his intentions and bona fides.

The counsel for Shah had earlier argued that the minister issued a public apology, which was shared online, and would be placed on the court's record.

On May 28, last year, the top court ordered the closure of proceedings before the Madhya Pradesh High Court against Shah for his controversial remarks against Col Qureshi and asked for a status report from the SIT.

Earlier, the top court chided Shah and constituted the SIT to probe the FIR lodged against him.

Shah came under fire after a video showed him allegedly making objectionable remarks against Col Qureshi, who gained prominence along with another woman officer, Wing Commander Vyomika Singh, during the media briefings on Operation Sindoor.

India has the will. It hasn't costed the way

Ninety-three lakh subsidised GPU hours built the machine. Nobody has budgeted a rupee for the day it starts answering citizens



NISHANT SAHDEV

Cast your mind back to September 2016. Data in India costs around ₹250 a gigabyte. Then Jio arrived, and within a year the price of a gigabyte had fallen by more than 90 per cent. Every sensible person predicted the same thing: our phone bills were about to collapse. They did not. What collapsed was the price of a gigabyte. What happened to the bill was something else entirely. We stopped sending texts and started watching videos. Then we watched a video in high definition. Then we watched it on the train, in the kitchen, at the dinner table, all day. A country that had been among the world's stingiest consumers of mobile data became the most voracious.

The oldest law in economics that nobody remembers

In 1865, a young English economist named William Stanley Jevons noticed something odd about coal. James Watt's improved steam engine used far less coal to do the same work. Everyone assumed this would extend Britain's coal reserves. Jevons showed the opposite had happened. Because the engine was cheaper to run, it was installed everywhere — in mills, mines, ships, railways - and Britain burned more coal than ever before. Efficiency did not reduce consumption. It multiplied it.

The pattern has recurred so often it now has his name on it. Cheaper air conditioners did not lower summer electricity demand. Wider roads in Delhi did not reduce congestion; they filled up. Cheaper light did not mean less lighting. And cheaper intelligence will not mean a smaller bill.

The numbers are genuinely astonishing, in both directions

Take the falling side first, because it is spectacular. The price of a fixed level of AI capability has dropped roughly a thousandfold in three years. Output that cost about five thousand rupees per million words in late 2021 now costs about five rupees. Independent trackers put the median rate

of decline near fifty times a year, accelerating to around two hundred times a year since the start of 2024. There is no comparable price collapse in the history of industrial technology.

Now the other column of the ledger, which almost nobody prints alongside it.

One leading AI company's bill for simply running its models — not building them, running them — was reported at around 8.4 billion dollars in 2025, roughly four times what it had been the previous year. Corporate spending on generative AI tripled from 11.5 billion dollars to 37 billion dollars over the same period in which per-unit prices fell a thousandfold. The average large company's annual AI budget has gone from about 1.2 million dollars in 2024 to about 7 million dollars in 2026. One search company reported processing over three quadrillion units of text a month by the middle of this year, seven times what it handled a year earlier.

Prices down a thousand times. Bills up several times. Both true, simultaneously, and neither one is a mistake.

What makes AI different from the gigabyte

Here is where the Jio comparison stops being merely useful and becomes urgent.

When data got cheap, a gigabyte remained a gigabyte. The unit stayed still while its price fell. We simply bought many more of them.

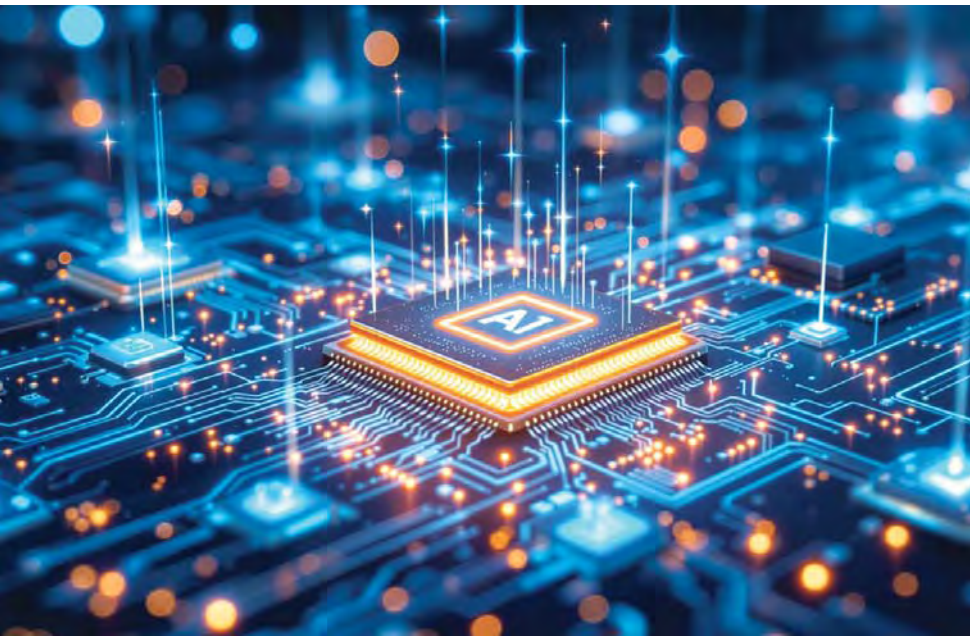
With AI, the unit itself has been quietly redefined.

AI systems are billed by the token, which is roughly three-quarters of a word. You pay for the words that go in and the words that come out. In 2020, a typical question consumed something like two hundred tokens. By 2025, a typical question consumed around twenty-two thousand.

Why? Because the newest models think out loud before they answer. They draft, check themselves, discard a line of reasoning, try another, and only then reply. All that invisible working is generated text, and all of it is metered. The reply you see may be four lines. You were charged four hundred.

So the price of a word fell by a factor of a thousand, and the number of words consumed per question rose by a factor of a hundred, before you count the growth in the number of people asking and the number of questions each asks. Two of those three terms are still climbing. We cut the price of the unit, and then redefined the unit.

Which brings us to India's budget documents



India's AI mission has done something impressive and something incomplete.

The impressive part: shared computing capacity has crossed forty-five thousand GPUs, with more than two hundred projects drawing on close to ninety-three lakh subsidised GPU hours. That is real, and it lowered a genuine barrier for Indian researchers and startups.

But notice what kind of spending that is. It is training. It is the cost of building a model. It is lumpy, one-time and capital-shaped, and the Indian state is extremely good at that shape. Sanction, tender, commission, ribbon, plaque.

The money in AI is not in building the model. It is running.

Every grievance answered by a departmental chatbot, every crop advisory sent to a farmer,

every land record parsed, every scanned FIR summarised, every pension query resolved is a metered event with a price attached. That cost never ends. It is not a building. It is a utility bill, and it arrives every month for as long as the service exists, growing with every citizen who uses it.

Now go and search the Union Budget and the state budgets for a line item called inference. You will not find one. We have heads for capital outlay and heads for salaries. We have no heading for the electricity of thought.

The failure will be silent, and it will not be fair

This is the part that worries me most, and it has had almost no discussion anywhere.

When the bill grows and the sanctioned budget does not, no department will announce a cut. There will be no press conference and no circular. What will happen is quieter. The service will be shifted to a cheaper model. The routing rule will be adjusted so that only complicated cases reach the good model. A configuration file will be edited on a Friday afternoon.

And because no Government publishes which model answers which citizen, that degradation will be invisible.

So ask the obvious follow-up question: who ends up on the cheap model?

Not the applicant with a lawyer. Not the exporter with a consultant, or the company with a grievance-redressal contact. It will be the query typed in Bhojpuri rather than English. The scanned document that is faint. The case that looks routine on the surface. Cost pressure inside an AI system does not fall evenly across a population. It falls hardest on the least articulate query.

That is a new kind of inequality, and India will encounter it before almost anyone else, simply because we will deploy these systems at a scale no other country can match.

Three things that would cost nothing to fix

First, make every AI proposal state its steady-state annual running cost at full rollout, the way a highway file must carry its operation and maintenance estimate. A pilot with ten thousand users on subsidised compute costs approximately nothing. The same service at ten crore users, on a model that thinks before it speaks, is a different order of magnitude. Every AI pilot in the Indian Government today is being judged at the one point on the curve where the economics look free.

Second, measure cost per resolved case, not cost per query. A cheap model that gives a wrong answer, gets escalated to a human, and generates a second visit to the office is not cheap. It has simply moved the cost from a budget line to a citizen's aftermoon.

Third, publish the tier. Which model serves which citizen-facing service should be on the record, so that a downgrade is a decision someone signs rather than a setting someone changes.

None of this requires new technology. It requires treating AI as what it actually is.

The falling price is real, and it is the best news in this entire technology. But 2016 taught us something we appear to have already forgotten. When a thing becomes almost free, we do not consume the same amount of it for less money. We consume vastly more of it, and find a larger bill waiting where the old one used to be.

Cheap is not the same as affordable. We learned that once with the gigabyte. We are about to learn it again, with the thought.

The author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a contributor at the *Wall Street Journal*

AGI: Can India turn disruption into opportunity?

If AGI is as close as experts suggest, India must prepare for opportunity and disruption



RAJESH SETH

In his recent Independence Day address from the Red Fort, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced an ambitious target: to skill one crore young Indians in Artificial Intelligence within a year. The announcement is significant for a country whose young population will enter a workplace increasingly shaped by AI. But the next question is much bigger: what happens if AI itself takes another giant leap: from today's increasingly capable systems to Artificial General Intelligence (AGI)?

Demis Hassabis, the Nobel-winning scientist who has spent much of his career pursuing AGI, recently stepped back from the day-to-day running of Google DeepMind to focus more closely on its long-term development. "I've been working towards AGI my whole life and now, like many of you, I feel it is close at hand," he told colleagues.

If AGI is indeed approaching, India's challenge will not simply be to train one crore people to use today's AI. It will be to prepare an entire generation for a world in which machines may be capable of learning and performing a far wider range of intellectual tasks.

If someone who has spent much of his career pursuing AGI now believes it is "close at hand", India needs to ask a practical question: are we ready?

AGI not simply a better LLM

We already use AI to write emails, translate languages, create images, analyse data, write code and answer questions. AI agents are beginning to go further, planning and carrying out tasks on our behalf.

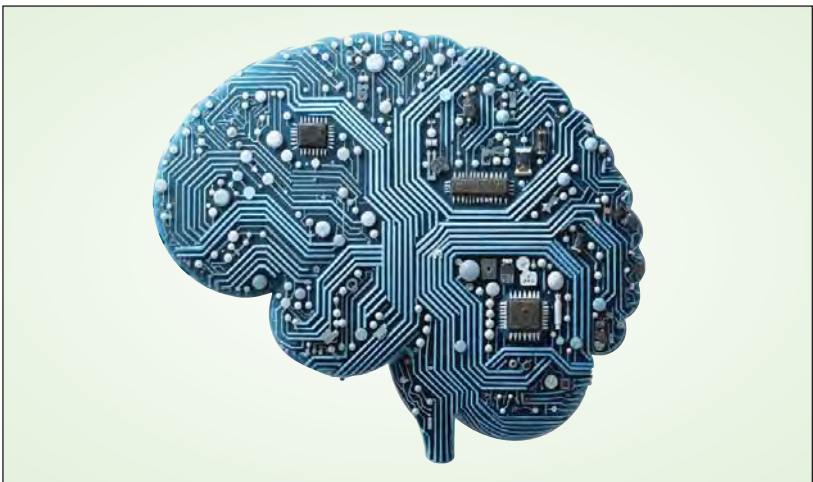
AGI would be a bigger step. It would be an AI system able to perform a wide range of intellectual tasks, much as a capable human can move between mathematics, writing, research and problem-solving.

Nobody knows exactly when this will happen and experts disagree about how close we are. But India does not need to predict the exact date to prepare for the possibility.

The opportunity: intelligence for every Indian

For India, perhaps the greatest promise of AGI is the possibility of making expertise more accessible.

Consider education. Imagine a child in a small town having a personal tutor available at any time, able to explain mathematics in Hindi, English or another Indian language, adjust the explanation when the child is struggling, create exercises and patiently try another approach. This is not entirely futuristic.



'*Sampurna Shiksha Kavach*', an AI-enabled personalised-learning programme supported by NITI Aayog, has reached more than 2.85 lakh students across Jharkhand, Bihar, Rajasthan and Himachal Pradesh. AGI could potential-



ly take such personalised assistance much further, making it more capable and widely available.

But AGI should not mean replacing teachers. Education is not merely the delivery of information. Teachers motivate, understand emotions, build confidence, teach values and help children learn to work with others. The likely future is teachers working with increasingly capable AI.

Healthcare offers another powerful example. India has excellent doctors and medical institutions, but specialist expertise is not evenly distributed. AI is already being used for diagnostics, clinical decision support, drug discovery and disease surveillance.

Consider eye care. Smartphone-based AI systems are being developed and used in India to screen for conditions such as diabetic retinopathy, glaucoma and age-related macular degeneration. AGI could eventually extend this idea far beyond individual diagnostic tasks, helping doctors in smaller towns draw on a much wider pool of medical knowledge.

It would not replace the doctor. It could extend the doctor's reach.

The same principle could apply to agriculture, scientific research, financial services, Government and small businesses. A small entrepreneur could potentially access sophisticated assistance in marketing, finance, law and technology without hiring several specialists.

AGI could therefore become a great leveller: making some forms of expertise abundant that are today scarce and expensive.

The disruption: what happens to India's jobs?

This is the other side of the story, and perhaps the more difficult one.

India's economic success has been built partly on millions of people performing cognitive and service-oriented work in IT, software development, business-process outsourcing, customer support, finance and other knowledge services. What happens if increasingly capable AI can perform much of this work?

Vinod Khosla, the Indian-origin technology investor, has offered one of the most striking forecasts. He has argued that AI could perform 80 per cent of the economically valuable work humans do within five years. That is a forecast, not a certainty, but it highlights a serious issue for India: what happens to the first rung of the employment ladder if AI becomes capable of doing much of the routine work through which young people traditionally enter professional careers?

Sam Altman offers a somewhat different perspective. In May 2026, the OpenAI chief said he no longer expected the kind of "jobs apocalypse" that some in the technology industry had predicted, noting that AI had not eliminated as many entry-level white-collar jobs as he had earlier expected. But he also acknowledged that work will change.

The disagreement is important. Nobody knows precisely how employment will evolve. The more immediate lesson for India is that it cannot assume that the jobs which powered its services economy will remain unchanged.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and Professor of Practice at IILM University, Gurugram with an interest in AI, Technology and Strategy

What to study if AI scares you

'Fast forward frugal *swadeshi* enabled AI-powered super computing technology'



PRAVIN KAUSHAL

A seventeen-year-old asked me recently whether there was any point in choosing a course at all. Whatever she studied, she said, would be obsolete before she finished it. Her parents were in the room, and they were nodding.

The fear is genuine, and it is not stupid. It is also built on a misreading of what the technology in question actually does.

Economists who study this properly do not ask whether a machine can replace a job. They break the job into tasks and ask which of those tasks a machine can do. The honest answer for most white-collar work is a large minority: perhaps a third, in some roles a little more. What follows from that is the part almost nobody says aloud. If a third of the work becomes cheap, the remaining two-thirds becomes more valuable, not less, because it is now the scarce ingredi-

ent. The people who lose are not the ones whose jobs contained a u n a t a b l e tasks. They are the ones who kept doing those tasks by hand while someone else moved on.

Software engineering is the clearest evidence available, because it is the field the technology has hit hardest and earliest. If the collapse thesis were right, we would see it there first. Instead, competent engineers are busier than they have been in years and the shape of the work has changed. Specialists who once did only front-end or only back-end now do both. The same broadening is showing up elsewhere. A marketing coordinator who once ran one stage of a campaign now runs the whole cycle. A recruiter who once sourced candidates now handles the process end to end. Some teams have started asking marketing candidates what software they have built, and expecting an answer. Finance staff are writing their own scripts to open documents, check figures against each other and flag what needs a human eye. Recruiting departments are hiring engineers to sit inside them.

The bargain is visible in that list. Tasks come off your plate, and in exchange you are expected to be good at more things. That is a demand for more education, not less.

Which brings me to the part stu-



dents most need to hear, and it is not about employment at all.

The evidence now emerging is that when students use these tools on their coursework, their marks go up and their retention goes down. They score better on the assignment and worse weeks later, when the assignment is gone and only what they a b s o r b e d remains. This is not mysterious. Getting an answer and learning something are different activities, and one of them has been made almost frictionless while the other has not. Anyone who works with these tools daily can confirm it privately: you solve a problem, ship the thing, and six months later you cannot reconstruct how it worked, so you ask again.

So the practical rule is to separate the two modes and be ruthless about it. When you are producing, offload whatever you like. When you are learning, do not. The struggle is not an inefficiency in the process; it is the process. A student who cannot tell which mode they are in will graduate with a good transcript and nothing underneath it.

This matters because of where the durable human advantage sits. It is not raw intelligence. It is context: the thousands of small things you know from having been in the room, watched something fail, seen a customer's face change, absorbed how your field actually behaves as opposed to how it is described. Judgement and taste are what we call context after it has been compressed by experience. No shortcut to it exists, which is precisely why it will remain valuable, and why sitting through a demanding degree

is worth more now than it was five years ago rather than less.

There is a related trap worth naming. Using these tools every day is not the same as being good at them. Firms that assess this at scale report that most employees badly overrate their own level. Opening a chatbot each morning to tidy emails is adoption. Knowing how to structure a prompt, chain steps together, feed a model your own working documents and judge when its output is confidently wrong is proficiency, and the gap between the two is enormous.

So, what should the seventeen-year-old study?

There is no safe major, and anyone offering one is selling something. Choose a field with real intellectual depth, ideally one you can stand to spend years inside. Learn to build things, whatever your discipline, because the cost of building has fallen so far that the constraint is now deciding what is worth building. And cultivate the quality employers are quietly listing more and more often, which is agency: noticing a problem and doing something about it without being told.

One warning specific to us. University curricula in India are revised on a timescale of years, through committees and approvals, while this field moves every few months. A great many students are being prepared for the jobs of 2022. Work hard in your classes anyway, then close the gap yourself with free courses and small projects built for real users.

Fear makes people freeze, and freezing is the only strategy here that reliably fails. The skill that protects you is not any single tool. It is how fast you can learn the next thing.

The author is an entrepreneur, public policy commentator and columnist

UAE intercepts incoming Iranian drone

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

An Iranian drone was intercepted early on Monday over United Arab Emirates territorial waters, the Defence Ministry said. The attack followed an exchange of fire between Iran and the United States on the weekend, which was the first significant military action in the war for more than a month. Iran fired a drone at the United Arab Emirates on Monday, which the UAE's Defence Ministry said was intercepted over its territorial waters. After more than a month with no significant fighting, the US attacked rocket launchers on an Iranian island on Sunday, saying they were preparing to launch mines into the Strait of Hormuz. Iran responded by launching missiles at US sites in Jordan, all of which were intercepted. Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said that his country was not seeking war, but that "we will respond decisively to aggressors. The UAE called the attack a "dangerous escalation" from Iran. During the



lull in fighting, the US has been ratcheting up economic pressure on Iran with the hope of forcing concessions out of Tehran, including reopening the vital Strait of Hormuz to shipping. Lebanon's Joseph Aoun is asking for Greece's help in implementing an agreement to end the war with Israel. During meetings on Monday in Athens, Aoun told

Greek President Constantine Tassoulas and Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis that Lebanon has been through long wars and "its people are tired." He suggested that Greece has good relations with both Lebanon and Israel and could help facilitate an end to decades of war. In comments aired by local TV stations, Aoun referred to the US-brokered

framework agreement between Lebanon and Israel that was signed in late June, saying "we ask Greece to do all it can to help Lebanon in implementing the agreement." In an apparent reference to daily Israeli airstrikes and shelling despite a June 20, Israel-Hezbollah ceasefire, Aoun said that "trying to solve the problem through military force will not

succeed." He said that the agreement "should not be implemented by one side but both sides." Mitsotakis told Aoun that "the security of Lebanon and Israel are not conflicting goals." "Greece, as a traditional friend of both Lebanon and the Arab world, but also a strategic partner of Israel, stands ready to support every effort toward de-escalation and mutual understanding," he said. American aircraft carrier heading toward Thailand for port call after lengthy deployment The US aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln is nearing Thailand, where it is expected to make a port visit after its lengthy deployment to the West Asia. The carrier with some 5,000 sailors and its accompanying battle group was sailing Monday toward the Gulf of Thailand where it was expected to make a port call near the city of Pattaya. The Lincoln, one of the US Navy's largest warships, was supporting the US war against Iran. Its deployment included a record-setting uninterrupted time at sea of more than 250 days.

Israel signs multi-billion-dollar weapons deal with Greece

SAM MEDNICK/
DEREK GATOPOULOS ■ Tel Aviv

Israel signed a multi-billion-dollar weapons deal with Greece, the largest between the two Mediterranean countries, as Israeli defence exports soar. Israel's Defence Ministry said Monday the nearly 3 billion Euro (\$3.5 billion) defence export deal, coined Achilles Shield, is one of the country's largest and includes a multilayered air defence system for Greece using Israeli technology. "Israel and Greece share common strategic interests and face shared regional challenges. At a time when actors with hegemonic ambitions are seeking to expand their influence and undermine stability in the region," said Defence Minister Israel Katz. The agreement comes as Israeli weapons exports have reached record highs with more than \$19 billion last year, a 30 per cent increase from 2024, according to official data, despite widespread criticism of Israel's conduct in its wars in



Defense Ministry Director General Amir Baram and his Greek counterpart, Ioannis Bouras, sign a sale of Israeli systems to Greece

Gaza, with Hezbollah and with Iran. Experts say Governments look to Israel because its weapons are battle-tested and they're able to see in real time that the munitions and systems work. Israel and Greece have deepened defence ties in the last decade. Monday's signing, however, marks the most significant deal between the two as Greece focuses on modernising its armed forces to keep pace with its neighbour and fellow NATO member Turkey amid long-standing disputes over sea boundaries in the eastern Mediterranean. Previous deals have included a \$1.65 billion agreement with Israeli defence contractor

Elbit to build a flight training school in southern Greece as well as the planned sale of Israeli rocket launchers, anti-tank guided missiles and drones. Israel says Monday's agreement is the first time it will provide a complete array of defence weapons against a range of threats from ballistic missiles to drones. It includes multiple Israeli systems such as David Sling and SPYDER as well as a new national command and control system. In addition to the agreement, a complementary deal valued at \$30 million (26 million Euros) was signed for the sale of Rafael's Drone Dome systems, it said. (AP)

Nepalese teacher evacuates school in Trishuli Valley just ahead of raging flash flood

SHONAL GANGULY/
SHEIKH SAALIQ ■ Bidur

Rajendra Dawadi was inside his classroom when the school's accountant rushed in with a warning: Floodwaters were racing through Nepal's Trishuli Valley, tearing apart homes, bridges and entire villages. Then a teacher received another warning by phone. Moments later, a parent arrived to take her child home. The danger had not yet been confirmed, but Dawadi had little time to act. He rang the school bell and ordered his students and staff out of the building and toward higher ground. "I immediately decided to stop... school and (get the children out)," he said. As he followed them to a nearby hill, the floodwaters rose behind him. From the safety of the hillside, he turned to watch the school where he had once been a student — and where he had spent years teaching — disappear beneath a torrent of water, mud, boulders and debris. Two staff members could not make it and remain missing. Dawadi's decision to evacuate the school saved at least 900 students from last week's devastating flash floods in Nepal, unleashed after a



glacial collapse in the Himalayas. The disaster killed over 900 people across Nepal and China, while more than 4,700 remain missing. As Nepal grapples with the catastrophic natural disaster, Dawadi's story has emerged as a striking example of foresight and courage. The Tribhuvan Trishuli Secondary School in the Trishuli Valley of north-central Nepal had 1,643 students. At least 900 were on campus that morning, while some students were still making their way to

school. Dawadi ordered those already there to leave and called bus drivers, telling them to only stop at safer places. One bus, packed with students, had already reached the school when Dawadi told the driver to turn back, he said. The bus crossed a newly constructed bridge and, moments later, the old bridge beside it collapsed. For Dawadi, the scale of the destruction has become personal, as the school had been both his workplace and a large part of his life. (AP)

We will die here: Nepal flood survivors recount desperate escapes as search for missing continues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Devighat

Badri Prasad Devkota saw a wall of muddy water rushing towards the bus carrying him, his wife and 34 other pilgrims to the Hindu holy site of Gosainkunda in Nepal's Rasuwa district. "My wife grabbed my hand and pleaded, 'Do not jump.' I told her, 'We will die here,'" Devkota told The Kathmandu Post. He broke free from her grip and jumped from the moving bus as the Bhotekoshi flood swept across the road at Bhainse in Nuwakot. The wave knocked him into a roadside drain, but he clung to vegetation on the hillside. From there, he watched the bus disappear beneath the floodwaters. The newspaper reported on Monday that two bodies had been recovered and 28 people remained missing from the group — one of them is Devkota's wife. The August 26 floods have left survivors facing the task of rebuilding their lives while thousands of families continue searching for missing loved ones. With hundreds dead and thousands still missing,



People look at completely destroyed, mud-caked houses on the banks of the swollen Trishuli River, in Nuwakot district, Nepal

accounts from those who escaped offer a glimpse of the suddenness and scale of the disaster. After the flood subsided, Devkota and his cousin Tularam, who was among six passengers who survived by jumping from the bus, climbed about 20 metres up the hillside and spent two hours on a patch

of grass. They saw people stranded on rooftops and others buried in mud before climbing higher to a village named Hilekharka, where local residents offered them tea and biscuits and helped them obtain first aid. The two returned to the Bhainse area the following day searching for their families, but found no trace of them before travelling back to their home district, Gorkha. At Betrawati, Santaman Lama survived by heeding a warning, but lost almost everything he owned. Lama told Onlinekhabar news portal on Sunday that he had taken his son and daughter to school on the morning of August 26 and was returning home when a nearby hardware-shop owner warned him that a flood was coming and told him to move uphill.

Russian drone strikes on warehouses trigger Kyiv food shortages

HANNA ARHIROVA/
BARRY HATTON ■ Kyiv

Russian forces relentlessly battered Kyiv and cities in the region around the Ukrainian Capital for a fifth straight day Monday, leaving some supermarket shelves bare after repeated strikes on warehouses as Ukraine reels from attacks with jet-powered drones. Russia has intensified its aerial attacks in recent months, more than four years after it invaded its neighbor. Almost constant air raid alerts in the Kyiv region in recent days have severely disrupted daily routines.



Two major attacks in July killed almost 50 civilians, and a strike on Saturday killed at least 38 people. Classes were due to resume at Ukrainian schools on Tuesday, but it

was unclear whether parents would send their children. Schools have air raid shelters, and classes can also be held online. "Right now, Russia's tactic is to wear down Ukraine and Ukrainians - first and foremost, our people," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on social media late Sunday. Ukraine has also tried to make Russian civilians feel the burden of war by hammering major online retailers and oil facilities. The attacks have brought shortages for ordinary Russians, though its strikes have not been as deadly for civilians. (AP)

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER:: PWD BUILDING:: ASSAM:: GUWAHATI-3.

No. নিবিদা প্রসংগ নং, CF/TB-III(B)/33/2025/32

PRESS NOTICE RE-INVIGING TENDER

পুনৰ নিবিদা আহ্বানৰ জাননী

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D (B), Assam on behalf of the Governor of Assam re-invites bids through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I of contract for the following work under P.W.D. (Bldg.), Assam from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having requisite experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

অসম চৰকাৰৰ মাননীয় ৰাজ্যপালৰ হৈ গড়কাপ্তানি বিভাগ (ভৱন), অসমৰ মুখ্য অভিযন্তাই তলত উল্লেখ কৰা কামৰ বাবে **Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I-ৰ** অধীনত পুনৰ নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰিছে। উক্ত নিবিদাত অনুৰূপ প্ৰকৃতিৰ কাম সম্পাদনৰ ক্ষেত্ৰত প্ৰয়োজনীয় অভিজ্ঞতা থকা আৰু সুশাসনধৰ্ম যোগ্যতাসম্পন্ন ফাৰ্ম/ঠিকাদাৰসকলে অংশগ্ৰহণ কৰিব পাৰিব। নিবিদা সম্পৰ্কীয় বিতং তথ্য ই-প্ৰক্ৰিউৰমেণ্ট প'ৰ্টেল www.assamtenders.gov.in-ত উপলব্ধ হ'ব। নিবিদাত অংশগ্ৰহণ কৰিব বিচৰা সকলো নিবিদাধাৰী www.assamtenders.gov.in ই-প্ৰক্ৰিউৰমেণ্ট প'ৰ্টেলত পঞ্জীয়নভুক্ত হোৱা বাধ্যতামূলক।

Sl. No. ক্ৰ. নং	Name of work কামৰ নাম	Approx. Value of work (in Rs) কামৰ আনুমানিক মূল্য (টকাত)	Bid Security নিবিদা পত্ৰ সুৰক্ষা	Bid Processing Fee নিবিদা প্ৰক্ৰিয়াকৰণ মূল্য (টকাত)	Completion period সমাপ্তি সময়সীমা
1.	Development of Mahapurush Sri Sri Anirudhadev Janmakhetra at Narayanpur, Lakhimpur, Assam.	Rs. 14,36,88,780.00 বাশি: ₹ ১৪,৩৬,৮৮,৭৮০.০০/-	Rs. 28,73,776.00 for General Category and Rs. 14,36,888.00 for Reserved Category সাধাৰণ শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে ₹ ২৮,৭৩,৭৭৬.০০/- আৰু সংৰক্ষিত শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে ₹ ১৪,৩৬,৮৮৮.০০/-	Rs. 20,000.00 ₹ ২০,০০০.০০/-	20 (Twenty months) ২০ (বিশ) মাহ।

Note টোকা:

(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT. কামৰ মূল্য বিতংভাৱে আহ্বান কৰা নিবিদা জাননী অনুযায়ী পৰিৱৰ্তন হ'ব পাৰে।

(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents. সকলো চৰ্ত আৰু নিয়মাবলী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰ অনুযায়ী হ'ব।

(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents. নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰৰ অংশ হ'ব।

Sd/-

Chief Engineer, PWD (Building) Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ, অসম, চান্দমাৰি, গুৱাহাটী-৩।

DIPR/C/PIO/122/1-Sep-26

SHEEL BIOTECH LIMITED

(CIN: L24239DL1991PLC046531)

Registered Office: 8 Balaji Estates, 2nd Floor, Block-C, Guru Ravidas Kalkaji, Delhi, India, 110019 / Telephone: +91-88511-89901 E-mail: compliance@sheelbiotech.com, Website: sheelbiotech.com

NOTICE OF 35th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING E-VOTING INFORMATION AND BOOK CLOSURE

1. Notice is hereby given that the 35th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of SHEEL BIOTECH LIMITED ("the Company") (CIN: L24239DL1991PLC046531) will be held on Thursday, 24th September 2026 at 11:30 A.M. through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM"), without the physical presence of Members at a common venue, in compliance with the applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), to transact the business that will be set forth in the Notice of the Meeting.

2. The aforesaid Notice and the Annual Report of the Company for the year ended 31st March 2026 will be sent in electronic mode to all the Members whose e-mail IDs are registered with the Company/Depository Participants. The Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report will also be available and can be downloaded from the website of the Company i.e. www.sheelbiotech.com and on the website of the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (NSE Emerge) i.e. www.nseindia.com (Stock Code: SHEEL, ISIN: INE0YJV0107).

3. In this regard, the Members are hereby further notified that

(a) The Company has completed the dispatch of the Notice of the 35th AGM along with the Annual Report 2025-26.

(b) The Company is pleased to provide all its Members (holding shares both in physical and in electronic form) the facility to exercise their vote through remote e-Voting, for which the Company has engaged Skyline Financial Services Private Limited, Registrar and Transfer Agent (RTA), as the authorised agency the facility being provided through Skyline's iVote platform as well as through the NSDL/CDSL e-Voting systems, as applicable. Members holding shares in physical or dematerialised form as on the cut-off date, i.e. Thursday, 17th September 2026, may cast their vote through remote e-Voting. The remote e-Voting shall commence on Saturday, 19th September 2026 at 9:00 A.M. IST and end on Wednesday, 23rd September 2026 at 5:00 P.M. IST.

(c) The Members who have not registered their e-mail addresses with the Company or Depositories need to follow the process below for obtaining login credentials for remote e-Voting & E-Voting during the AGM:

- For physical shareholders – please provide necessary details, such as folio no., name of shareholder(s), scanned copy of the share certificate (front and back), PAN card (self-attested) and Aadhar card (self-attested), by e-mail to the Company (compliance@sheelbiotech.com) / RTA, Skyline Financial Services Private Limited (rtg@skylinertg.com).
- For demat shareholders – please provide Demat account details, i.e. CDSL – 16 digit Beneficiary ID, or NSDL – 16 digit DPID + Client ID, Name, Client Master or copy of Consolidated Account Statement, PAN card (self-attested) and Aadhar card (self-attested) to the Company (compliance@sheelbiotech.com) / RTA, Skyline Financial Services Private Limited (admin@skylinertg.com).

3. Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and Regulation 42 of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, the Registrar of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company shall remain closed from Friday, 18th September 2026 to Thursday, 24th September 2026 (both days inclusive) for the AGM to be held on 24th September 2026.

4. Only those Members who have registered themselves as a speaker by e-mail at compliance@sheelbiotech.com on or before Monday, 21st September 2026 (up to 5:00 P.M.) will be allowed to express their view/ask questions during the AGM.

5. Any person who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a Member after dispatch of the Notice, and holds shares as on the cut-off date, i.e. Thursday, 17th September 2026, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at <http://www.evoting@cdslindia.com>.

6. For the process and manner of remote e-Voting, Members may go through the remote e-Voting instructions sent via e-mail to the Members whose e-mail IDs are registered with the Company / Depository Participant, or visit the CDSL website <https://evoting.cdslindia.com>.

7. If you have any queries or issues regarding attending the AGM & e-Voting, you may contact the CDSL helpdesk at helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or toll-free no. 180021 09911.

FOR Sheel Biotech Limited

Sd/-

Anupam Pandey; Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Date: 31.08.2026

Place: New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform General public that the name of Delhi City School, Pocket C-8, Sector -8, Rohini, Delhi-110085 has been changed to North-Ex Public School with effect from 27th August, 2026 after getting approval from the Directorate of Education Govt. of NCT of Delhi.

C.A.S.K. Gupta (Chairman)

North-Ex Public School

Senior Secondary

Affiliated to CBSE

PUBLIC NOTICE

Subject: Transfer of ownership in respect of Property No. 658, Sector-46, Urban Estate, Faridabad Whole share of Late Shri Ramesh Chander Gora son of Late Anishlal Gora, resident of House No. 658, Sector-46, Faridabad, upon the death of Shri Ramesh Chander Gora, who was the owner of 100% share in the property mentioned under subject, as per records he died on 14-09-2023. Whereas, the followings are the surviving legal heirs of Late Shri Ramesh Chander Gora: (i) Saroj Gora - [Wife]; (ii) Gopal Gora - [Son]; (iii) Rohit Gora - [Son]. I, Saroj Gora wife of Late Shri Ramesh Chander Gora, resident of House No. 658, Sector-46, Faridabad, intends to apply for the transfer of the whole share of the deceased in the said property in my favour. If any person is having objection against the transfer of the said property/house, he/she can submit objections in writing to the Estate Officer, HUDA, Faridabad, along with supporting documents within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice. Otherwise the Estate Officer may sanction mutation of the property as per HUDA policy and may not entertain subsequent claim if any.

Legal Heir

Saroj Gora.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it hereby known to all concerned that my clients, Sh. Bishamber Singh, S/o Sh. Ganpat Singh, and his wife, Diarammai, residents of C-72/A, Phase-3, Street No. 5, Shiv Vihar, Karawal Nagar, Delhi-110034, have disowned their son, Anil, and his wife, Mrs. Hitesh Dolly, from all their movable and immovable properties, assets, rights and interests, and have severed all relations with them. Any person dealing with the aforesaid persons shall do so entirely at his/her own risk, cost and responsibility, and my clients shall not be held liable for the same.

NAUNIHAI YADAV, Advocate

Delhi High Court,

Chamber 475, Patiala House Court,

New Delhi-110001, Phone : 7068136783

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public and all existing allottees of Commercial Plotted Colony under Licence No. 165 of 2022 dated 13.10.2022, situated in the revenue estate of Village Shikhopur, Sector-82A, Gurugram, being developed by M/s Valika One India Next Pvt. Ltd. The Directorate of Town & Country Planning (DTCP), Haryana, Chandigarh, vide Letter of Intent (LOI) Memo No. LC-4693-B/JE(SK)/2026/30743 dated 26.08.2026, has granted in-principle approval/LOI for grant of licence for setting up of a Commercial Plotted Colony over an additional area measuring 1.96875 Acres in addition to the existing Licence No. 165 of 2022, resulting in proposed revision in the earlier approved Layout Plan of the colony. Accordingly, objections/suggestions, if any are hereby invited from existing allottees' general public regarding the proposed revision in the layout plan, as per DTCP policies dated 25.01.2021 and 24.04.2023. A copy of the earlier approved layout plan and the proposed revised layout plan showing changes are hosted on the company's website (<https://www.valikacollections.com/real/gurgaon/valika-crossover/>) and are also available for inspection at our Office as well as in the office of the Senior Town Planner, Gurugram. Any existing allottee having any objection/ suggestion to the proposed revision of the layout plan may submit their objection in writing, in our Office - Unit No. A-402, INX1 City Centre, Ground Floor, Block-A, Sector-83, Gurugram - 122012, and/or in the office of the Senior Town Planner, Gurugram (Address: HSPV Complex, Sector-14, Gurugram) within a period of 30 (thirty) days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which it shall be presumed that no allottees has any objection to the proposed revision in the layout plan, and DTCP Haryana shall proceed with final approval as per law. For M/s Valika One India Next Pvt. Ltd. Place: Gurugram Date: 01.09.2026

State Council of Educational Research & Training (S.C.E.R.T.) Government of Delhi

Applications are invited for DPSE Course (2026-28) under Management Quota

For the Recognized & Affiliated Institutions of SCERT. For more details, Contact:-

Rukmini Devi College of Education B-5, Sector-4, Rohini, Delhi-110085 Phone: 011-48018033, 8882705401

Manvi Institute of Education & Technology C-7, Sector-7, Rohini, Delhi-110085 Phone: 7827577477, 701677474

Apply latest by 10.09.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that M/s Valika Seven Elements Pvt. Ltd. has applied to the Directorate of Town & Country Planning, DTCP, Haryana, for the transfer of part licensed land measuring 4.175 Acres out of total land measuring 14.30 Acres in Licence No. 41 of 2013 dated 06.06.2013 (granted for setting up of a Group Housing Colony in the revenue estate of Village Harsaru & Hayapur, Sector-88A, Gurugram) from the in-principle approval to the proposed transfer of licence under Rule 17 of the Haryana Development and Regulation of Urban Areas Rules, 1976. Accordingly, objections, if any, are hereby invited from the General Public regarding the proposed transfer of licence, strictly limited to any adverse effect on their rights, if any. Any person having any objection may submit their objection in the office of the Senior Town Planner, Gurugram, within a period of 30 (thirty) days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which it shall be presumed that no one has any objection to the proposed transfer of licence and the Directorate of Town & Country Planning, Haryana shall proceed further to grant final approval for the transfer of licence in accordance with the publication of the in-principle approval is also hosted on the company's website at <https://www.valikacollections.com/homes-future-ready/gurgaon/seven-elements/> For M/s Valika Seven Elements Pvt. Ltd. Place: Gurugram Date: 01.09.2026

These corridors will serve as a backbone for India's economic growth, strengthening its position as a globally competitive manufacturing and logistics hub.

CM Sai urges investors to join mineral block auction in Chhattisgarh



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chhattisgarh is emerging as an important contributor to India's strategic supply chain in critical minerals required for defence equipment, clean energy, electric vehicles, batteries, electronics and emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence. The state has significant potential for critical minerals, including lithium, graphite, rare earth elements, tungsten, vanadium and gallium.

A roadshow was organised by the Ministry of Mines, Government of India, in Nava Raipur for the eighth tranche of auctions of critical and strategic mineral blocks. The eighth tranche includes 20 mineral blocks across seven states, including five blocks from Chhattisgarh. Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai called upon investors to actively participate in the auction of these blocks. Chhattisgarh has so far auctioned 65 mineral blocks, with a potential revenue of around ₹4 lakh crore.

The Chief Minister said minerals such as lithium, graphite and rare earth elements are important for batteries, energy storage, electronics, drones, defence equipment and advanced manufacturing. The state government has also emphasised environmental protection alongside mining. According to the State Government, the forest area in Chhattisgarh has

increased by 1.22 per cent through sustainable mining practices, reflecting the focus on both mineral development and environmental conservation.

Union Minister of State for Coal and Mines Satish Chandra Dubey said that self-reliance in critical and strategic minerals is essential for India's economic and strategic strength. He called upon investors, youth and startups to take advantage of the opportunities emerging in this sector and emphasised sustainable and responsible mining, along with environmental protection and the interests of local communities.

Union Minister of State Tokhan Sahu said the success of mineral block auctions should be reflected in exploration, investment, processing, value addition and employment generation. He also emphasised the need for planned development of civic infrastructure such as housing, transport, drinking water, healthcare and education in mining areas.

Secretary, Ministry of Mines, Government of India, Keshav Chandra said that the auction process for 88 critical and strategic mineral blocks has been initiated across the country so far, of which 56 blocks have been successfully auctioned. He said the country's first lithium-bearing mineral block was auctioned from the Katghora Lithium and Rare Earth Element block in Chhattisgarh.

LIC celebrates 70 years of trust

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), the country's leading life insurer and a financial institution of national significance, is proudly celebrating its 70th Anniversary on 1st September 2026.

From its establishment on 1st September, 1956, to spread life insurance widely across the country and provide financial protection at a reasonable cost, LIC has completed seven decades of a remarkable journey built on trust, service, financial strength and an unwavering commitment to the people of India.

LIC continues to sustain its Leadership position in the market with 65.16% market share in policies and 56.66% market share in first-year premium income in the financial year 2025-26. Total AUM increased by 5.08% to ₹57.29 lakh crore.

Despite the opening of the insurance sector to



private participation, LIC has retained its position as India's largest life insurer, supported by its extensive network of branches, agents and digital platforms.

It offers a wide range of life insurance, pension and market-linked products to meet the diverse financial needs of individuals and families.

A major milestone in LIC's journey was its IPO in May 2022, followed by its listing on the NSE and BSE. Since then,

the Corporation has continued to focus on corporate governance, transparency, digital transformation and customer service, while consolidating its leadership in the Indian life insurance industry.

LIC's Golden Jubilee Foundation (GJF) was established in the year 2006 as a part of LIC's Community Service Initiatives and has so far disbursed ₹303 crore under 1045 projects spread throughout the country. It has also given 41,776 schol-

arships amounting to ₹105.27 crore to needy students.

LIC made remarkable strides in enhancing its digital platforms, ushering in a new era of convenience and efficiency for its vast clientele. Its digital initiatives, including the My LIC App, have enhanced customer convenience, accessibility and service delivery.

As LIC commemorates its 70th Anniversary, it acknowledges with gratitude the enduring confidence and support of its policyholders, shareholders, employees, agents and other stakeholders. Guided by the ethos of "Yogakshemam Vahamyaham—Your welfare is our responsibility," LIC remains steadfast in its commitment to protecting lives, strengthening financial security and serving the evolving needs of its customers.

With this enduring legacy as its foundation, LIC looks ahead with renewed purpose to a future of continued service and growth.

SECL, MCL IPO by year-end: CIL CMD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Coal India Ltd (CIL) Chairman and Managing Director B Sairam on Monday said the Initial Public Offerings (IPOs) of two of its largest subsidiaries, South Eastern Coalfields Ltd (SECL) and Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd (MCL), will be completed within the current financial year.

Responding to questions from shareholders and stakeholders during an interaction, Sairam said the exact timeline would depend on market conditions and Government directives.

"... regarding the IPO of SECL and Mahanadi Coalfields Limited. We plan to complete the IPO by the year-end positively. Its IPO will be completed in this current financial year only. The exact month and date will depend upon the market



Coal India Ltd (CIL) Chairman and Managing Director B Sairam

conditions and the Government directives, etc," Sairam said.

CIL's board had in March this year accorded in-principle approval for divestment of up to 25 per cent equity stake each in SECL and MCL through an offer for sale (OFS), along with issuance of fresh equity shares by SECL of up to 10 per cent of its post-issue paid-up capital through the IPO route.

ONGC to enter oil trading, build strategic reserves

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) plans to enter crude and petroleum-product trading and build a new strategic petroleum reserve as it seeks to strengthen supply security and extract more value across its energy portfolio, while continuing to make upstream exploration its central focus.

ONGC's new trading unit is expected to begin operations "end of this year", Chairman and CEO Arun Kumar Singh told reporters. The unit will initially handle the group's own crude and product requirements, while also pursuing third-party business.

The unit, which ONGC is considering locating in Dubai or Singapore, could create opportunities worth about USD 1 billion a year through better crude sourcing, freight



management and risk management, Singh said. "We are very close to it (setting up trading desk). Already 95 per cent work is done. We are waiting for one or two boxes to be ticked," he said. A partner and location of the desk is yet to be decided, he said.

Hindustan Petroleum Corp Ltd (HPCL), Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd (MRPL), and an international trading partner that ONGC is currently selecting are expected to have stakes in the trading venture.

The unit would also coordinate with ONGC Videsh

Ltd, the group's overseas investment arm, and ONGC Petro Additions Ltd.

The move would give ONGC and its group companies a single commercial interface in global oil markets, replacing a fragmented model in which individual businesses source, sell and procure crude and feedstock separately.

While ONGC produces the barrels, its subsidiaries HPCL and MRPL import crude independently. Its overseas arm OVL sells its own equity production, and OPAL sources its own feedstock.

Daichi-Ranbaxy case: Delhi HC orders forensic audit into transactions of Fortis, Singh brothers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday appointed a forensic auditor to examine the transactions of former Fortis promoters Malvinder Mohan Singh and Shivinder Mohan Singh in connivance with Fortis Healthcare Ltd, leading to dissipation of shares in connection with a ₹3,500 crore arbitral award passed in favour of Japanese pharma major Daiichi Sankyo.

Justice Subramonium Prasad said the purpose of the forensic audit is to identify and reconstruct the entire chain of events to enable the court to identify the persons and the companies involved in the dissipation of shares. The high court appointed S Ramanand Aiyar and Co as the forensic auditor to conduct the audit and complete the exercise within six months.

In its 213-page judgment,



Fortis promoters Malvinder Mohan Singh and Shivinder Mohan Singh

the court allowed the applications of Daiichi seeking appointment of a forensic auditor to unearth the transactions between Fortis Healthcare Ltd (FHL), Singh brothers and others leading to dissipation of assets which would have otherwise been sufficient to pay the decree amount passed in favour of Daiichi and against Singh brothers.

The court noted that there was a sharp decline in the shareholding of FHL held by Fortis Healthcare Holdings

Private Limited (FHHPL), which was controlled by Singh brothers. "This court is of the opinion that rather than this court entering into a sale-by-sale analysis and examining its disclosures, an expert would be in a better position to unearth these transactions."

"They would also be able to identify the complicity by FHL or violation of SEBI regulations by the companies and judgment debtors, and banks which will attract its own penal consequences," it said.

SRM University-AP hosts quantum, AI workshop for AP tech vision



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

The Quantum & AI Innovation Centre (QAIC) workshop was held on Monday at SRM University-AP's Amaravati campus, organised by the Amaravati Quantum Valley, Government of Andhra Pradesh, and hosted by the university, under the theme "Mentor Mapping, Use Case Allocation, and QIC Team Formation".

The proceedings brought together senior academic leadership and Government functionaries in a day devoted to mapping mentors to emerging quantum use cases and to giving shape to the State's quantum innovation cells.

Presiding over an occasion of considerable institutional significance, Sri Pradyumna PS, IAS, secretary to the Chief Minister, lent the workshop its most consequential address, underscoring the importance the State Government attaches to the university's quantum ambitions.

Professor CH Satish Kumar, vice chancellor of SRM University-AP, opened the proceedings with remarks on the university's institutional journey, tracing the path that had brought SRM University-AP to this juncture, and outlined the university's forthcoming plans to advance quantum technology initiatives across the campus, signalling a sustained institutional commitment to the discipline in the years ahead.

Delivering the inaugural keynote, Professor GP Raja Sekhar, vice chancellor of Andhra University, framed the workshop as part of a wider effort to redefine technology, offering young people the chance not merely to participate but to innovate, and urged that students be asked not what job they wish to do, but what problem they wish to solve. Sri CV Sridhar, mission director of the AP State Quantum Mission, Government of Andhra Pradesh, commended SRM University-AP for the initiative, noting that the workshop advanced the Mission's vision on design, products and R&D; talents and jobs; and industry partnership.

Following this, Sri Pradyumna PS, IAS, Secretary to the Chief Minister, spoke on behalf of the Chief Minister's vision for the State. He noted that technology was changing rapidly, threatening jobs rather than people, and pointed to a future where work becomes optional. He urged the audience to embrace change, affirming that Andhra Pradesh would root R&D and global trade under Make in India, and that AI and humanity are not adversaries.

For SRM University-AP, the workshop marked a further step in aligning its academic mission with the State's quantum agenda, bringing mentors, use cases and Quantum Innovation Cells into closer alignment under the framework set out over the course of the day.

ITC Infotech to acquire 22.1% stake in Happiest Minds for ₹1,330 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Diversified conglomerate ITC Ltd on Monday said its wholly-owned subsidiary ITC Infotech will acquire a 22.1 per cent stake in Happiest Minds Technologies for around ₹1,330 crore, as part of a deal which will lead to the merger of the two entities into a \$1-billion tech giant.



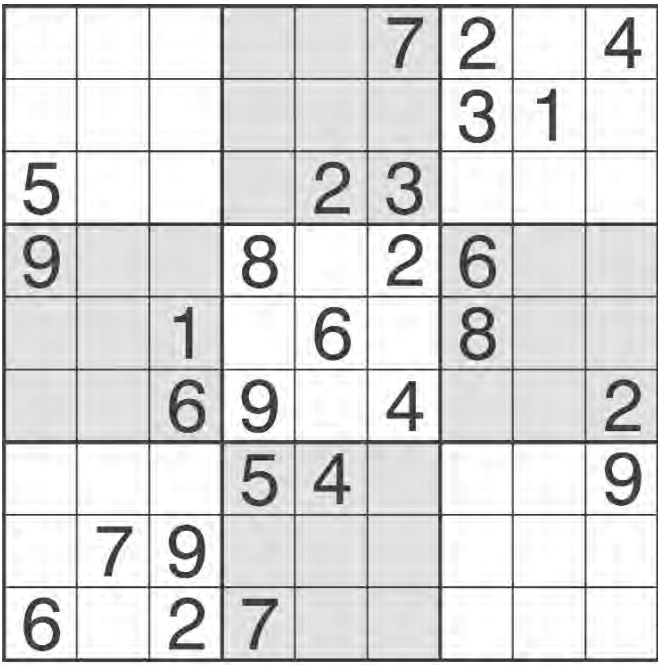
The acquisition of 3,36,61,700 equity shares will be made from Happiest Minds' promoter Ashok Soota and Ashok Soota Medical Research LLP in two tranches, ITC said in a regulatory filing.

Following the stake purchase, Happiest Minds will be amalgamated with and into ITC Infotech.

After the merger, ITC Infotech is proposed to be listed on the BSE and the National Stock Exchange (NSE). "The coming together of our complementary strengths, deep domain expertise and future-ready capabilities will further enhance our ability to deliver cutting-edge solutions across geographies. I am particularly encouraged by the shared values, people and customer-centricity that define our organisations," Sanjiv Puri, Chairman of ITC Limited and ITC Infotech, said.

Post-amalgamation, ITC Limited will hold a 73.4 per cent stake in the merged entity, while Happiest Minds' shareholders will hold the remaining 26.6 per cent.

DAILY SUDOKU



No. SSG23232 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

HOW TO SOLVE IT
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



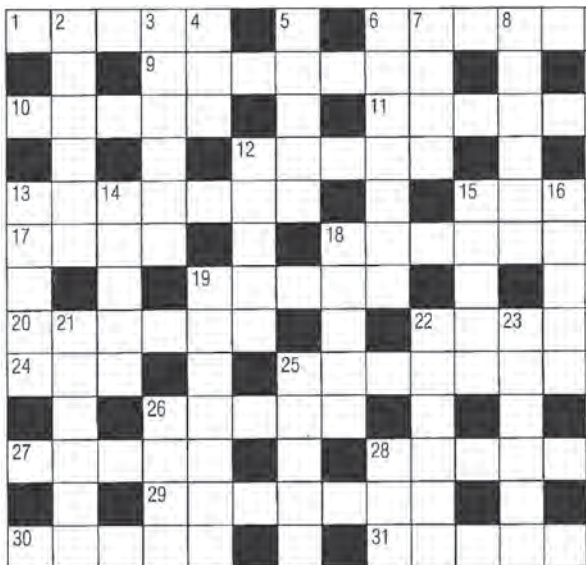
DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

SOLUTION (31.8.26)

2	4	1	7	6	5	8	3	9
6	5	7	3	9	8	4	2	1
9	3	8	2	1	4	6	7	5
7	1	5	6	8	3	2	9	4
8	2	3	9	4	1	7	5	6
4	9	6	5	2	7	3	1	8
1	8	2	4	7	9	5	6	3
5	7	4	1	3	6	9	8	2
3	6	9	8	5	2	1	4	7

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DOUBLE CROSSWORD TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 1, 2026



ACROSS

- I call for a change of colour (5)
- By harbouring the sick, make a name (5)
- A game of wits (7)
- It sounds wet (5)
- Figure a measure to be a sure success (5)
- Brightens up because of the benefits (5)
- Weaponry for our army, possibly (7)
- Brief contributor to the latest edition (3)
- Incline to be angular? (4)
- He didn't rule the waves (6)
- A bighead, some new broom (5)

DOWN

- Dirty little devil on the river (6)
- Female deadlier than the male (6)
- Tom may take a walk (3)
- Edifice rebuilt by Abe? (5)
- Great star, so how can he be an awful hack to many? (7)
- At Oxford, the Thames is doubled (4)
- The case of a miniature (6)
- Takes excessive interest in redeveloping piers (5)
- Frenchman I leave to get Anglicised (5)
- Alma's mum? (5)
- Though varying in cut, is usually

- Lofty ladies can have them (6)
- They're apt to get knotted (4)
- This way for the country! (3)
- Riding one can give you a sort of kick (7)
- Relating to the sound of coins rattling? (5)
- Assert for many a purpose (5)
- Do fully, once again (5)
- Keen to laze around inside the house (7)
- It may be of merit (5)
- Study a noted duet arrangement (5)

- uniform (5)
- Thick scattering of seed around the end of the garden (5)
- Such relief can bring a smile (5)
- Singular garment, evidently floral (7)
- One spent in Florida, perhaps? (6)
- A key worker (6)
- Elevated wild delta at the end of the Nile (6)
- It can religiously be described as a good read (5)
- Mass of glue! (4)
- Expected to be a bit subdued (3)

SOLUTION (31.8.26)

- | | | | |
|---------------|---------------|---------------|--------------|
| ACROSS | 22, Hath | DOWN | 17, Pekes |
| 3, Past-a | 23, He-re | 1, S-prog | 19, All-owed |
| 8, Spree | 24, De-MOT-ed | 2, Retouch | 20, Sh-aft |
| 10, Angie | 26, F-actor | 4, A-Cre | 21, Stick |
| 11, Ra-T | 29, War | 23, Heroics | 23, Heroics |
| 12, B-ring | 31, Takes | 5, To-ng-le | 24, Do-sag-e |
| 13, Monocle | 32, Deposit | 25, Tap | 25, Tap |
| 15, Get-up | 34, Rapid | 27, A-ar-on | 28, Ter-NS |
| 18, U-re | 35, Ian | 9, Ran | 30, Min-or |
| 19, All-ude | 36, You-NG | 12, B-L-ether | 32, Dine |
| 21, Scuttle | 37, Actor | 14, C-ru | 33, Sat |
| | 38, S-even | 16, Tuned | |

BRIEFLY

Indian para athletes sign off with 16 medals in Finland

India signed off with a haul of 16 medals including six gold, four silver and six bronze, from the ITTF World Para Future Lahti tournament in Finland. The singles events accounted for 10 medals, while India parathletes added six more in doubles including two gold, one silver and three bronze.

Rameshbhai Chaudhary and Sumit Sehgal spearheaded the men's doubles campaign in Classes 4-8, claiming gold with a composed 3-0 victory over South Africa's Ibrahim Abdullah and Rakan Abdulrahman in the final.

Sumit completed a memorable doubles' double, partnering with Deepikarani Ramanathan to the mixed doubles title. The duo overcame Finland's Timo Kalavei and Aino Tapola 3-0 in the final.

Sonal Patel and Rameshbhai added a silver in mixed doubles after reaching the final, while three Indian combinations secured bronze. Shubham Wadhwa and JD Madan took the men's doubles bronze, Prachi Pandey and Savita Ajjanakatti claimed bronze in women's doubles while Shivam Pal and Noorali Jamani completed the doubles tally with a mixed doubles bronze.

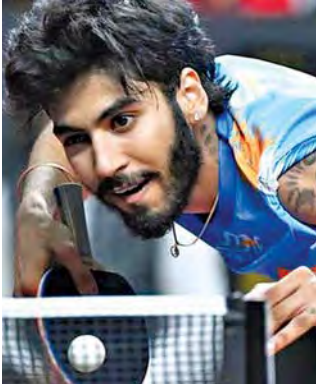


Ankur wins maiden WTT title, doubles gold in Czechia

Indian paddler Ankur Bhattacharjee produced a memorable performance to win his maiden WTT men's singles title, while also securing the doubles gold with Akash Pal at the WTT Feeder Olomouc tournament in Czechia. The World No. 78 overcame third-seed Slovenian Deni Kozul 3-1 (9-11, 11-4, 11-5, 11-6) in the singles final to cap a remarkable campaign. He had joined forces with Akash earlier to defeat Hungary's Csaba Andras Szantosi and Poland's Alan Kulczycki Zaleski 3-1 (11-8, 4-11, 13-11, 11-9) in the men's doubles final. The singles final began with a setback for Ankur as Kozul edged the opening game 11-9. The Indian, however, quickly found his rhythm, tightening his placement and controlling the rallies to win the next three games and seal the title. In the men's doubles, Ankur and Akash overcame an early setback.

The two took the opening game 11-8, but Szantosi and Zaleski levelled with an 11-4 second game.

The Indians regained the advantage in a closely fought third game, winning 13-11, before holding their nerve to close out the fourth 11-9.



Lakshya spearheads Indian challenge at China Masters, young women's singles trio in focus



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Shenzhen

Lakshya Sen will look to bounce back from the disappointment of his early exit at the World Championships but a tough opener awaits him when he spearheads the Indian challenge at the \$1,250,000 China Masters Super 750, beginning here on Tuesday.

Sen, who became the first Indian male shuttler to reach an Olympic semifinal in Paris two years ago before finishing fourth, will face France's newly-crowned world champion Alex Lanier in his opening match.

The Indian has enjoyed some notable results this season, including a runner-up finish at the All England Championships, and will be keen to regain consistency against a strong field after a shock second-round loss to world number 92 Garrett Tan at the Worlds. Former World No. 1 Kidambi Srikanth, meanwhile, faces Chinese Taipei's Chi Yu-jen after reaching the US Open Super 300 final in June, where he finished runner-up.

His campaign on the Tour after that has been patchy. It was interrupted by an injury-forced retirement due to injury at the Canada Open before he suffered a first-round exit at the Korea Masters. In men's doubles, fourth seeds Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty will be among India's biggest hopes.

The former world Number 1 pair ended a two-year wait for an international title by winning the Taipei Singapore Open earlier this year.

They will open against China's Hu Ke Yuan and Lin Xiang Yi, who won the Orleans Masters title this season.

Satwik has been dealing with a recurring shoulder issue.

The duo returned to action after missing a few events only to make a third-round exit from the Worlds at home. The Indian pair will hope for a deeper run as it builds up to the Asian Games title defence in Japan.

India's young women's singles contingent will also be under the spotlight, with young prospects Unnati Hooda, Tanvi Sharma and Devika Sihag carrying the national flag.

Unnati, the 18-year-old from Rohtak, faces fifth seed Han Yue of China.

She became the youngest Indian to win a BWF World Tour title when she claimed the Odisha Open Super 100 crown in 2022 as an unseeded 14-year-old. She has since added the Abu Dhabi Masters and Odisha Masters titles to her cabinet. Tanvi takes on Denmark's Amalie Schulz.

The 17-year-old from Hoshiarpur climbed to the junior world No. 1 ranking last year, a run that included a silver medal in singles and a bronze in the mixed team event at the 2025 World Junior Championships — making her the first Indian to win more than one medal at a single edition of that event.

She underlined her rapid rise this year by becoming the youngest-ever winner of the Taipei Open Super 300.

Hockey WC: Of missed chances and shift of power

MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ Amstelveen

The 2026 Hockey World Cup will be remembered for broken barriers, missed opportunities and shifting hierarchies, with Argentina ending the long Dutch reign in women's hockey, Germany retaining the men's title and India once again left to rue a missed opportunity.

For 16 days, hockey took centre stage across the Netherlands and Belgium, the first time since the 1998 World Cup in Utrecht that the men's and women's tournaments were played simultaneously, though in two countries.

It was like a carnival in Amstelveen with packed stands, mostly orange soaked passionate fans and music.

Secluded Wavre offered a more intimate and feel with fans enjoying hockey over drinks and waffles, adding a distinct Belgian flavour to the tournament.

The biggest story of the women's competition was the end of Dutch dominance. Nine-time champions and Paris Olympic gold medalist the Netherlands were denied a fourth successive World Cup title by a courageous Argentina in front of a packed home crowd.



The final was locked at 1-1 after 60 minutes before Argentina prevailed 3-1 in the shootout. Argentina had last won the title in Rosario in 2010. Rosario incidentally is the birthplace of legendary Lionel Messi.

Belgium defeated Australia for bronze, while Paris Olympic silver medalist China finished eighth.

The women's tournament showed how narrow the margins have become. Both semi-finals and the bronze-medal match were decided by a single goal, while the final went to a shootout.

Dutch drag-flicker Yibbi Jansen was the top scorer with eight goals and also reached 100 international goals.

Germany retained the title won in Bhubaneswar in 2023, defeating

Spain in the final at Belfius arena, Wavre. Spain, after stunning hosts the Netherlands, reached the final for the first time since 1998 and pushed Germany hard.

But a 44th-minute goal and Germany's disciplined defence proved decisive, giving them a fourth World Cup title and taking them level with Pakistan.

Belgium, the 2018 champions and co-hosts, finished seventh, while Australia failed to make an impact in either section.

Women's campaign was the most encouraging story from India's perspective.

The team lost only once, to the

Netherlands, after holding China, beating South Africa 6-1 and drawing with England.

A goalless draw with Australia ended their semi-final hopes, but India bounced back to beat higher-ranked Germany in the fifth-place match - their best World Cup finish since 1974. The achievement was particularly impressive with 11 World Cup debutants in the squad.

Young goalkeeper Bichoo Devi's spectacular save against England in the last 30 seconds was one of the tournament's memorable moments, while the experience of Savita Punia provided an important balance.

Djokovic out in US Open 1st round for first time

BRIAN MAHONEY ■ New York

The US Open's Sunday start gives some players a chance to get a nice head start. For Novak Djokovic, it turned into a stunning head start back to the airport. The 24-time Grand Slam champion was knocked out in the first round of the US Open for the first time, beaten by Mariano Navone of Argentina 7-6 (5), 5-7, 4-6, 6-2, 6-1.

Djokovic was 19-0 in the US Open first round and hadn't lost his opening match in any major since the 2006 Australian Open.

"It's a good record, another one. But yeah, I'm not really thinking about it," Djokovic said. "Of course, I've been very proud of all the achievements in the past, but now is now."

And now the No. 4 seed and four-time champion in Flushing Meadows looks every bit of his 39 years, vomiting and battling leg

problems during a match that lasted more than 4 1/2 hours. "Now I have to recover," Navone said. "It's almost 12 o'clock."

It made for a lengthy first day of play, with Venus Williams and fellow wild card Sofia Kenin not getting on the court until past midnight - after their match was set to move to another stadium but the players decided to wait and keep it in the main venue.

Kenin beat the 46-year-old Williams 6-2, 7-6 (6).

Nearly 12 hours earlier, third-seeded Jessica Pegula again experienced the benefits of the Sunday start that began last year. "It is a little bit weird, but I did kind of enjoy that I could breathe for the next couple of days and everyone else is still freaking out about whether they're going to win their first round," she said.

Djokovic later experienced the downside. "We were just talking about it, and I said, it's so nice to play on Sunday when you win. But if you lose it's not nice, because you feel like the tournament didn't even start and you're out of it," No. 11 seed Marta Kostyuk said. Pegula and Kostyuk both won easily and now they get the benefit of any extra day of rest before returning for the second round, where Pegula will play Kenin.

Pegula leads the women's tour with 46 wins this season. She has two titles and has reached three other finals. Pegula can become Rank 1 in rankings if she wins her first major title and Rank 2 Elena Rybakina loses before semifinals.

The No. 11-seeded Kostyuk beat Storm Hunter 6-4, 6-1 for a strong start to year's final major after reaching the



US Open getting longer, players left worried

BRIAN MAHONEY ■ New York

The US Open was a week old by the time Aryna Sabalenka and Carlos Alcaraz opened their title defenses. What once was a two-week quest for a Grand Slam championship now extends into a third week, and US Tennis Association CEO Craig Tiley was asked how he hoped to continue that growth. "Four weeks," he said with a smile. Some players might fear he is serious.

They were already becoming wary of an overcrowded schedule that makes it hard



to find many breaks, even before the US Open moved up the beginning of the singles main draw last year to make it a Sunday start. (AP)

NORTHERN RAILWAY (E-Auction Notice)			
No. 23 AC/Ctg./e-Auction/WVM & MPS/2026			Date: 31-08-2026
The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/ G. Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi Invites e-Auction through IREPS (https://ireps.gov.in/) for allotment of contracts of Water Vending Machines (WVMs) and Multi Purpose Stalls (MPSs) at following railway stations/locations:			
Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Cluster No.	No. of WVMs at Railway Stations
CTG-WVM-08-2026	16.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs	I	Total 06 WVMs (01 WVM at Garhi Harsaru, 01 WVM at Patli, 01 WVM at Pataudi Road, 01 WVM at Palam, 02 WVMs at Delhi Saarai Rohilla Railway Station).
		J	Total 10 WVMs (04-WVMs at Meerut City, 02 WVMs at Modinagar, 01 WVM at Vivek Vihar, 03 WVMs at Delhi Shahdara Railway Station).
		H	Total 09 WVMs (02 WVMs at Jind, 02 WVMs at Narwana, 02 WVMs at Tohana, 02 WVMs at Jakhal, 01 WVM at Mansa Railway Station).
		A	Total 10 WVMs (01 WVM at Baraut, 01 WVM at Baghpat Road, 01 WVM at Noli, 02 WVMs at Shamli, 01 WVM at Rampur Maniharan and 04 WVMs at Muzaffarnagar Railway Station).
		D	Total 07 WVMs (03 WVMs at Panipat, 02 WVMs at Samalkha and 02 WVMs Bhodwal Majri Railway Station).
		F	Total 06 WVMs (03 WVMs at Kurukshetra, 02 WVMs at Karnal and 01 WVM at Shahbad Marknda Railway Station).
		E	Total 06 WVMs (02 WVMs at Badli, 02 WVMs at Ganaur and 02WVMs at Sonipat Railway Station).
Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Railway Station	Lot No.
MPS-AUG-02-26	16.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs	DEE	MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-163-25-2 MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-131-25-2
		NZM	MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-115-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-122-25-1 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-158-25-2
		KUN	MPS-DLI-KUN-MPS-135-25-2
		MDNR	MPS-DLI-MDNR-MPS-147-25-2
		MTC	MPS-DLI-MTC-MPS-140-25-1 MPS-DLI-MTC-MPS-141-25-1
Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen.			https://ireps.gov.in/ (E-Auction-Leasing)
All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids: ➤ Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module-Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module. ➤ Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details. ➤ A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism. ➤ The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions. ➤ Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender /E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.			
Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query	Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055, Email: catering.delhidivision@gmail.com , Tel: 011-23743084.		
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE			3000/2026

medicamen MEDICAMEN ORGANICS LIMITED Corporate Identity Number (CIN): L74899DL1995PLC066416 Regd. Office: 10, Community Centre No. 2, Ashok Vihar Phase II, New Delhi, Delhi – 110052, Ph. No 011-27430249 Website: www.medicamenorganics.com Email ID: cs@medicamenorganics.in	
NOTICE OF 31ST ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING (VC) / OTHER AUDIO-VISUAL MEANS (OAVM) AND INFORMATION ON E-VOTING	
NOTICE is hereby given that: 1. The 31st (Thirty-First) Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Members of Medicamen Organics Limited ("Company") will be held on Friday, September 25, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. (IST) through Video Conferencing/ Other Audio Visual Means ("VC/OAVM") to transact the businesses as set out in the Notice of the AGM, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") & the rules made thereunder and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations"), read with the applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") for convening the general meetings through VC/OAVM. The deemed venue of the AGM shall be the Registered Office of the Company i.e. 10, Community Centre No. 2, Ashok Vihar Phase II, New Delhi, Delhi – 110052. 2. Pursuant to the applicable circulars issued by MCA and SEBI, physical attendance of the Members is not required at the AGM, and attendance of the Members through VC/OAVM will be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Act and the facility for appointment of Proxies by Members will not be available. The Company has appointed KFin Technologies Limited, Registrar and Share Transfer Agent of the Company ("KFinTech" or "RTA") to provide facility for voting through remote e-voting, for participation in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility and e-voting during the AGM. The manner and instructions to cast vote through remote e-voting and/or e-voting during the AGM have been provided in the notice of AGM. 3. The notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 including therein the Audited Financial Statements for Financial Year 2025-26, Auditor's Reports, Board's Report, along with all the annexures have been sent by the Company on Monday, August 31, 2026 in Electronic Mode to all the members whose E-mail IDs are registered with the Company / RTA of the Company or with the respective Depositories of members. However, an option is available to the Members to continue to receive the physical copies of the documents/ Annual Report by making a specific request quoting their Folio No./Client ID & DP ID to the Company or to RTA. These documents are also available on the website of the Company at www.medicamenorganics.com, RTA at www.kfintech.com and may also be accessed from the website of National Stock Exchange of India Limited ("NSE") at www.nseindia.com, where the securities of the Company are listed. 4. Additionally, as per Regulation 36(1)(b) of the Listing Regulations, a letter providing the weblink, including the exact path, of the Annual Report for Financial Year 2025-26, is being sent to those shareholders who have not registered their email address with the Company / RTA of the Company or with the respective Depositories of members. 5. In compliance with the provisions of Section 108 of the Act, read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, as amended from time to time, Regulation 44 of the Listing Regulations and in terms of applicable circulars issued in relation to e-voting facility, the Members are provided with the facility to cast their vote electronically, through the e-voting services provided by KFinTech, on all the resolutions set forth in the notice of AGM. 6. The remote e-voting period shall commence 9.00 A.M. (IST) on Tuesday, September 22, 2026, and shall end at 5.00 P.M. (IST) on Thursday, September 24, 2026. The said remote e-voting module shall be disabled for voting thereafter. Once the vote is cast by a member, the same cannot be modified subsequently. A Member may participate in the AGM even after exercising his right to vote through remote e-voting but shall not be allowed to vote again at the meeting. 7. The cut-off date for the purpose of ascertaining the eligibility of the Members to avail e-voting facility will be Friday, September 18, 2026. The voting rights of Members shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date. Members are eligible to cast vote through remote e-voting or e-voting during AGM, only if they are holding shares as on the cut-off date. 8. Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and become its Member after dispatch of the notice of the AGM and holding shares as on the cut-off date i.e. Friday, September 18, 2026, are requested to refer to the notice of AGM for the process to be adopted for obtaining the login id and password for casting vote through remote e-voting, for participation in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility and e-voting during the AGM. A person who is not a member as on the cut-off date should treat the notice of AGM for information purpose only. 9. Members attending the AGM who hold shares as on the cut-off date and who have not already cast their vote through remote e-voting and/or otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through the e-voting system during the AGM. 10. Members holding shares in the dematerialized form are requested to register/update their e-mail addresses with their relevant DPs. 11. The Members who wish to speak/raise questions during the meeting may register themselves as speaker for the AGM to express their views. They can visit www.kfintech.com and login through the user id and password provided in the mail received from KFinTech. On successful login, select Speaker Registration option, which will be open on Wednesday, September 23, 2026 from 9:00 A.M. (IST) to 5:00 P.M. (IST). Members registering themselves as a Speaker shall be provided a 'queue number' before the AGM. The Members reserves the right to resign the speakers at the AGM to only those Members who have registered themselves, depending on the availability of time for AGM. 12. Ms Divya Rani, Proprietor (Membership No. AB4841) of M/s. Divya Rani & Associates, Practising Company Secretaries, has been appointed as the Scrutinizer to scrutinize the e-voting process (including the votes cast during AGM) in a fair and transparent manner, the results declared, along with the Scrutinizer's Report shall be placed on the Company's website at www.medicamenorganics.com, after the declaration of result by the Chairman or a person authorized by him in writing. The results shall also be submitted to the Stock Exchange where the securities of the Company are listed. 13. In case of any query and/or grievance, in respect of voting by electronic means, Members may refer to the Help & Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) and E-voting user manual available at the download section of https://evoting.kfintech.com (KFinTech Website) or contact us, at Mr. Anandan, at evoting@kfintech.com or call KFinTech's toll free No. 1-800-309-4001 for any further clarifications.	
For Medicamen Organics Limited Sd/- Divya Sharma Company Secretary & Compliance Officer Membership No. A43980	
Date: August 31, 2026 Place: New Delhi	

Messi says he is retiring from playing for Argentina

DEBORA REY ■ Buenos Aires

Lionel Messi announced his retirement from international soccer on Monday after two decades representing Argentina.

"It was a decision that hurt - and still hurts deeply - but I understand that the time has come," the 39-year-old Messi said on his Instagram account.

"I swear to you that I always gave it my all - not just in these last few years when we won everything, but before that too; I always fought and left everything on the field for this jersey, to bring you joy and make you feel proud to be Argentine through football."

Messi played in a record-tying six World Cups, won it in 2022 in Qatar and led Argentina to this year's final, losing to Spain in extra time in New Jersey.

In the World Cup hosted in the U.S., Mexico and Canada, Messi played all eight matches and scored eight goals. He finished just one goal behind France's Kylian Mbappe, the tournament's top scorer. He concluded his international career as



Argentina's all-time leading scorer with 125 goals, 21 of which were scored in World Cups.

He explained he wrote his retirement letter on July 21 - two days after the World Cup final - but waited to publish it because his father was facing health issues that eventually claimed his life.

Jorge Messi died on Aug. 8

in his native Rosario.

Messi will continue to play for Inter Miami. Over the weekend he scored four times in a 7-1 win over CF Montreal.

He made his Argentina debut in 2006 but his journey was fraught with frustration until he finally lifted the World Cup in 2022.

"Thank you for all the love

these past 20 years," he said.

"I'm going to miss hearing you all from the inside so much. Now I'm going to be one of you, cheering and supporting you from the outside (through thick and thin, even more so)."

In the letter, the Inter Miami captain did not say how long he intends to continue playing.

"I leave with the peace of mind and pride of having given you - along with my teammates - moments we once only dreamed of. Experiencing this with you was incredible. I love you all," he added.

Messi's stellar recent success with Argentina nearly didn't happen.

A decade ago, before the World Cup triumph and Copa America titles in 2021 and 2024, he retired from the national team. The decision followed Argentina's defeat in the 2016 Copa America final to Chile on penalty kicks, one of which he missed. But Messi shook off the notion of not being able to win the big match. He continued starring for Barcelona, then Paris Saint-Germain, then Inter Miami.

He's the two-time defending Most Valuable Player in Major League Soccer, the star of the league reigning champion, someone who still creates goals in the biggest moments.

"He is pure history," Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said during the recent World Cup. "History. A legend." (AP)

We need to check where we went wrong as a batting unit: Shafali Verma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India opener Shafali Verma said the team's batting unit will have to assess its shortcomings on turners despite opening with a facile 94-run victory in the Women's Asia Cup opener here.

Shafali smashed 64 off 36 balls, including eight fours and three sixes, to provide India with a flying start. But after reaching 91 for one, India slumped to 127 for six before eventually crawling to 159 for nine in 20 overs. Thailand paid for their inexperience and were all out for 65.

"We will just go back and see where we are going wrong as a batting unit and where we can improve. Today's game is done and we did really well, and whenever we go to our room, we are just thinking about what we can improve and what we can give more to the team," Shafali said in press conference. Harmanpreet Kaur (5 off 9 balls), Bharati Fulamali (13 off 14 balls), Richa Ghosh (0) and Deepti Sharma (5) were disappointing against unher-



alded Thai bowlers.

India were aware that the pitch would offer some turn and hold. Shafali said the batters needed to adapt better as the innings progressed. "As we all know, we came here and before that also, we all knew there would be a turning track, there would be a bit of hold, so we were aware about this track," she said.

Shafali said the new ball came on nicely to the bat.

"Talking about the track with the new ball, the ball was coming very nicely. After the ball gets old, there is a bit of hold and there is a bit of turn." She departed after making a brisk 64, acknowledging that she could have played the ball better after it

gripped and arrived a little late.

"As a batter, I was set at that time. I just made a bit of a mistake. The ball gripped a little bit and came a little late. I might have been able to play it grounded," she said.

Shafali, who had played in the UAE during the 2024 Women's T20 World Cup, said her previous experience of the conditions helped her prepare for the Asia Cup.

"Two years back we came here for the World Cup, so I know the conditions and I am prepared. Back home, I was just preparing for this track and all," she said.

The opener gave credit to Thailand's bowlers for making India work hard for their runs. (PTI)

Vaibhav slams 92 but East Zone locked in intense battle with Central

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi underlined his red-ball credentials with a 92 full of fire and brimstone, but East Zone failed to take an innings lead over Central Zone on the second day of the Duleep Trophy semifinal here on Monday.

Left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey (4/66) and pacers Yash Thakur (3/66) and Aryan Pandey (3/43) shared all the wickets among them to bowl out East for 266, identical to Central's first innings total.

In a match that has now been reduced to a second-innings shootout, Central are placed rather precariously at 45 for three at close.

At stumps, Aman Mokhadde (23) and Aryan Pandey (4) were batting, but pacer Mukesh Kumar dealt a huge blow to Central, dismissing skipper Rajat Patidar in the closing minutes of the day.

But the 15-year-old Sooryavanshi was the star of the day and he became the youngest batter to score a fifty in the Duleep Trophy, surpassing Laxman Singh who achieved the feat as a 16-year-old in 1969. But there was more to the left-hander's batting on the day than that little statistical highlight.

His innings that spanned across 118 minutes and 81 balls was never really a settled-looking one but the Bihar boy showed a lot of temperament to bat on. (PTI)



Tilak's ton gives South Zone edge in Duleep Trophy semifinal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Captain Tilak Varma stood tall with a patient unbeaten 106 while Shreyas Gopal made 87 to give South Zone a vital first-innings lead of 90 runs in their Duleep Trophy

semifinal against North Zone here on Monday. Hitting his first boundary as late as on the 154th delivery that he faced, Tilak reached 106 not out off 225 balls with seven fours, as South Zone finished the day's play at 285 for nine.

North Zone were bowled out for 195 on the first day. Resuming at 40 for two, South Zone had a poor start as Gurnoor Brar (4/70) struck thrice in the first session to leave them struggling at 80 for five at one stage.

N Jagadeesan (36), resuming on 34, was cleaned up by Brar with one that went away from the batter and took his off-stump, while R Smaran's (27 off 35 balls, 4 fours) positive start was also ended

by the lanky pacer when he had one straightening up to crash into his wickets.

Brar got his third wicket in the form of Kodimela Himateja, having him caught behind on the second ball for a duck.

This was when Tilak joined forces with Gopal as the two put on 175 runs for the sixth wicket to turn the tables on North Zone.

Earlier in the day, a close appeal for leg-before off Anshul Kamboj (2/53) was rejected by on-field umpire while an outside edge flew past the slips when Tilak was in the 80s.

Gopal took the aggressive route to find boundaries at regular intervals, while Tilak farmed the strike to reach his fifty, and carried on in the similar manner.

Their partnership was broken in final session when Arshdeep Singh (2/59) found an outside edge off Gopal's bat to have him caught by Abdul Samad in the slip cordon, and North did not take long to get the following wickets as well.



Discussions happening with BCCI on pending series: BCB chief Tamim



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Bangladesh Cricket Board President Tamim Iqbal has not given up hope of a long-delayed home white-ball series against India materialising at some point, saying that both the countries are continuing to look for a window despite their hectic schedules.

In a conversation with Youtube channel 'Not Out Norman', the BCB chief admitted that the three ODIs and three T20Is will not happen in September as originally planned. India have a three-match T20I series against Afghanistan in the same window beginning September 13. "That it won't happen hasn't been decided yet," Tamim said.

"Both boards are very sincere that this thing happens. Both BCCI and BCB are looking at windows as well, which time what can be done. Roughly a date, around which we are also thinking whether it can be done at this time or not. "If I saw the intention was negative, then today I wouldn't even have said this word to you, 'Let's see what happens, we're hopeful.' I wouldn't have even said this word. Intentions are very positive," he asserted.

Tamim said regular discussions are happening between the two Boards and "dates are being figured out."

SLC hopes inaugural Women's Champions Trophy next year stays in Sri Lanka

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ COLOMBO

Sri Lanka's interim cricket Board says it would correct itself "from the very foundation" to ensure that the inaugural Women's Champions Trophy next year remains in the country amid speculation that the ICC might relocate the event due to government interference in the sport's administration here.

Interim Committee chair Erani Wickremaratna, appointed by the country's sports minister, said his committee is committed to reform the administration of Sri Lanka Cricket



(SLC).

"We are very committed to really correcting from the very foundation. We are not backing out," said

Wickremaratna, without elaborating.

The six-team T20 tournament, scheduled to be held in February 2027, is likely to be moved out of Sri Lanka due to gov-

ernment interference in the administration of SLC. Interim Committee official Prakash Schaffter said two and a half months back, the ICC had indicated that it was looking for an alternative venue other than Sri Lanka.

"Although they have not categorically told us their decision due to governance issues with SLC, we are hoping we will be able to demonstrate to them the steps we have taken so that they may even be persuaded to play it here," Schaffter told reporters on Monday. Former Sri Lanka captain Kumar Sangakkara, a member of the interim committee, said there is a

need to work in close cooperation with the ICC.

"We are passing the phase of formulating a new constitution and then have an elected body," Sangakkara said.

The current interim committee was appointed in April after the incumbent SLC administration was asked to resign for alleged mismanagement and corruption. The sports minister then appointed the current 'Transformation Committee' with the aim of revamping the SLC constitution and its governance structure. However, ICC is not in favour of political intervention in the administration of member countries. (PTI)

Pakistan likely to send Rizwan, Imam Haq back home from England

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Pakistan are likely to send wicketkeeper-batter Mohammad Rizwan and opening batter Imam Ul Haq back home from their tour of England where the team has endured heavy defeats in the first two Tests so far.

Placed at the bottom of the points table in the World Test Championship, Pakistan lost the opening Test to England by an innings and 103 runs at Leeds and the second Test at Lord's by 194 runs.

"It has been decided to send back Rizwan and Imam," Geo News reported.

The touring Pakistan media in England has also reported of a high-level meeting of the officials from the Pakistan Cricket Board following their defeat in the second Test. PCB chairman Mohsin Naqvi, COO Sumair Ahmed, PSL CEO Salman Naseer, former player and senior selector Aaqib Javed and head coach for limited-overs



cricket Mike Hesson attended the meeting.

A reliable source within the PCB said Naqvi, who is also a minister in the government of Pakistan, has been conveyed of their disappointment by those above him over how the Pakistan team has fared in England. "The incident of Imran Khan's sons' interview being aired during the second Test on Sky Sports has also upset the powers that be, but more than anything, it is the portrayal of the Pakistan team in the media and their performance that has caused concern," the source said.

From accidental shooter to Asiad-bound athlete: Kedarling's incredible journey

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

When Kedarling Balakrishna Uchaganve joined the Indian Army in 2018, he had no grand sporting ambition. Like many youngsters from his village in Karnataka, his immediate goal was simple — to secure a job, support his family and serve the country. Shooting was nowhere on his radar.

Today, the 27-year-old Naib Subedar of the 27 Madras Regiment is preparing to represent India at the Asian Games, having discovered the sport only after joining the Army. And while the Asian Games will mark the biggest chapter of his journey so far, Kedarling already has his eyes on an even bigger dream — winning an Olympic medal at Los Angeles. Coming from a small village in Karnataka, Kedarling grew up in



a family whose livelihood is rooted in agriculture. His parents continue to work in farming, while he grew up in a joint family with his siblings, grandparents and extended family.

Sporting ambitions were not necessarily part of his early life. As a

youngster, he had participated in running events, including the 1500m at the district level, but never imagined that one day he would represent India on an international sporting stage. His introduction to shooting was almost accidental.